FRIDAY
July 31, 2026
DELHI
CITY EDITION
24 Pages ₹ 12.00

THE HINDU

www.thehindu.com
INDIA'S NATIONAL NEWSPAPER SINCE 1878

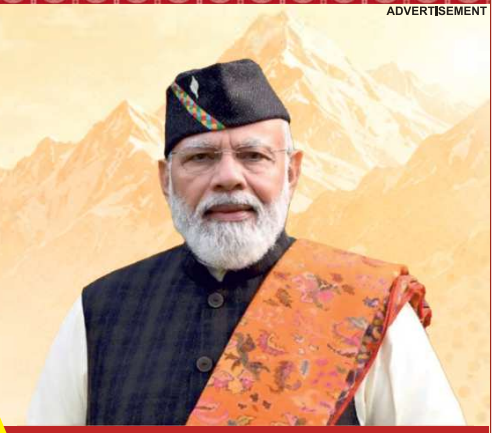
Vol. 16 • No. 181
Regd. DL(ND)-11/6110/2006-07-08
RNI No. UPENG/2012/49940

To subscribe, give a missed call at 9828331787 or scan QR code

Printed at » Chennai » Coimbatore » Bengaluru » Hyderabad » Madurai » Noida » Visakhapatnam » Thiruvananthapuram » Kochi » Vijayawada » Mangaluru » Tiruchirapalli » Kolkata » Hubballi » Mohali » Malappuram » Mumbai » Lucknow » Cuttack » Patna

ADVERTISEMENT

Govt. of Uttarakhand



Devbhoomi Uttarakhand

"The construction of a developed India in the 21st century rests on two main pillars: first, pride in our heritage, and second, making every possible effort for development. Today, Uttarakhand is continuously strengthening both these pillars. This decade is the decade of Uttarakhand."

Narendra Modi
Prime Minister

"Hon'ble Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi Ji has called the third decade of the 21st century the decade of Uttarakhand. In line with the Prime Minister's vision, we are working with a 'resolve without alternative' (Vikalp Rahit Sankalp) to make the state an ideal state in every field."

Pushkar Singh Dhami
Chief Minister, Uttarakhand

Viksit Bharat Sashakt Uttarakhand

Sankalp Se Shikhar Tak

Sewa - Sushasan - Samarpan

Employment

- Strict Anti-Copying/Anti-Cheating Law & Transparent Recruitment Process: Selection across multiple departments 33,000 youths given government jobs in the past 5 years.
- Chief Minister Skill Upgradation & Global Employment Scheme: Budget increased from ₹75 lakh to ₹33 crore; foreign language training provided to 147 children, with 92 securing employment abroad.
- Growth in MSME Employment: Number of people employed in MSMEs increased from 3,43,922 in 2022 to 4,56,605 in 2025.
- 10% Horizontal Reservation for Agniveers: Applicable to direct recruitment in Group 'C' uniformed services in government jobs.
- Devbhoomi Entrepreneurship Development Scheme: 300+ students established enterprises, registration of nearly 1,200 students is underway, and employment generated for 1,541 students and others.

Industries

- New Momentum to Development Through Grounding of Investments Worth Over ₹1.00 Lakh Crore.
- Investment Agreements Worth ₹3.56 Lakh Crore: Signed during the Global Investors Summit.
- Expansion of Land Bank: Over 6,000 acres of additional land bank developed for industries.
- Thriving MSME Sector: Over 96,400 MSME units active across the state.
- Massive Job Creation in MSME: Generated over 4.70 lakh jobs in the MSME sector.
- Flourishing Startup Culture: Over 1,750 startups established in the state.
- National Recognition: Uttarakhand recognized as a "Leader" state in the States' Startup Ecosystem Ranking.
- Large-Scale Industries: 128 large industrial units currently operational in the state.

Education

- Uttarakhand has become the first state in the country to implement the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020.
- Under the PM SHRI Scheme, 141 schools were selected in the first phase and 84 schools in the second phase.
- Virtual classrooms are being operated in 500 Government Secondary Schools across the state.
- The total number of Government and Private Degree Colleges in the state increased to 139 by 2025.
- The total number of Engineering Colleges (Government and Private) in the state increased to 52 by 2025.
- Under the Secondary Education programme, free textbooks are being provided to students of Class I to XII studying in Government and Private schools across the state.

Health

- Construction of the AIIMS Satellite Centre at Kichha is underway, with 85% of the work completed.
- The AIIMS Kichha project includes a 250-bed hospital, 10 Operation Theatres (OTs), 30 ICU beds, advanced Diagnostics & Laboratory facilities, and speciality departments including Cardiology, Nephrology, Urology, Neurology, General Surgery, Orthopaedics, General Medicine, Paediatrics, and an Emergency & Trauma Centre.
- More than 6.1 million Ayushman Cards have been issued across the state under the Atal Ayushman Yojana.
- Under the Atal Ayushman Yojana, more than 1.7 million patients have received cashless treatment worth over ₹3,400 crore.
- 207 types of pathology tests are being provided completely free of cost across the state.
- A target has been set to establish a Medical College in every district. At present, five Medical Colleges are operational, while two more are under construction.
- Super-speciality healthcare services are available at the Medical Colleges in Dehradun, Haldwani, and Srinagar.
- The newly constructed Child and Mother Care Hospital in Haridwar is now operational.

Connectivity

- Inauguration of the 210-km Delhi–Dehradun Economic Corridor, featuring Asia's longest 12-km Wildlife Corridor.
- The Rishikesh–Karnaprayag Rail Project is progressing at a rapid pace.
- The state's road network has expanded to 51,728 km.
- The All Weather Road Project has ensured seamless connectivity to the Char Dham shrines and border areas.
- A new terminal has been developed at Dehradun Airport, with regular flight connectivity to major cities across the country.
- 13 new heliports are currently under construction.
- Construction of the Sonprayag–Kedarnath (12.9 km) and Govindghat–Hemkund Sahib (12.4 km) Ropeway Projects has commenced.

Women Empowerment

- 30% horizontal reservation has been implemented for women in Government jobs across the state.
- 33% reservation for women has been ensured in Co-operative Management Committees.
- Under the Chief Minister Self-Help Group Empowerment Scheme, Self-Help Groups are provided interest-free loans of up to ₹5 lakh.
- Under the Lakhpati Didi Scheme, more than 2.54 lakh women in the state have become Lakhpati Didis.
- Under the Chief Minister Mahalakshmi Kit Scheme, women are provided with essential maternity kits after childbirth.
- Under the Nanda Gaura Scheme, the State Government provides ₹11,000 on the birth of a girl child and ₹51,000 for higher education after she passes Class XII.

Youth Welfare

- Under the New Sports Policy, a historic decision has been taken to provide Government jobs to medal winners at the National and International levels.
- The daily diet allowance for sportspersons has been increased from ₹250 to ₹480 per athlete per day, in line with the Sports Authority of India (SAI).
- Under the Chief Minister Emerging Sportsperson Development Scheme, around 3,900 emerging athletes aged 8 to 14 years are being provided a monthly sports scholarship of ₹1,500.
- Sportspersons who have won medals or represented the country at National and International events such as the Olympic Games, Asian Games, Commonwealth Games, etc., will receive the benefit of the 4% Sports Quota in Government Services.
- 60 Patent Information Centres have been established in various colleges, universities, and other institutions across the state.

Issued in Public interest by Department of Information & Public Relations, Uttarakhand, Dehradun

www.uttarainformation.gov.in | DIPR_UK | UttarakhandDIPR | UttarakhandDIPR

FRIDAY
July 31, 2026
DELHI
CITY EDITION
24 Pages ₹ 12.00

www.thehindu.com

THE HINDU

INDIA'S NATIONAL NEWSPAPER SINCE 1878

Vol. 16 • No. 181
Regd. DL(ND)-11/6110/2006-07-08
RNI No. UPENG/2012/49940

To subscribe, give a missed call at 9828331787 or scan QR code

Printed at » Chennai » Coimbatore » Bengaluru » Hyderabad » Madurai » Noida » Visakhapatnam » Thiruvananthapuram » Kochi » Vijayawada » Mangaluru » Tiruchirapalli » Kolkata » Hubballi » Mohali » Malappuram » Mumbai » Lucknow » Cuttack » Patna

IAS GS Foundation Course
Offline & LIVE Online Batch

Centre	English Medium	हिंदी माध्यम
Karol Bagh (Delhi)	11 Aug | 8:00 AM	20 अगस्त | सुबह 11:30 बजे
Noida (Delhi-NCR)	24 Aug | 11:30 AM	17 अगस्त | दोपहर 3:00 बजे
Indore	18 Aug | 5:30 PM	24 अगस्त | सुबह 8:00 बजे
Jaipur	11 Aug | 5:00 PM	6 अगस्त | सुबह 8:00 बजे

Download Drishti Learning App to Explore Our Courses!

Drishti IAS
Book Your Free Counselling Now
87501 87501
Karol Bagh | Noida | Prayagraj | Jaipur | Lucknow | Indore

IN BRIEF

Parliament clears Bill on National Song amid din

NEW DELHI
Amid din, the Lok Sabha passed the Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026, making intentional insult to *Vande Mataram* a punishable offence, on Thursday. The Rajya Sabha had cleared the legislation earlier. » Page 15

No plans to reopen window for higher pension: EPFO CEO

NEW DELHI
Ramesh Krishnamurthi, CEO of EPFO, said the employee pension scheme is a pooled fund and there are no plans to open the window for higher pension again. » Page 16

LIVE ONLINE OFFLINE
CSAT
FOUNDATION CUM MENTORSHIP for 2027 PRELIMS BATCH-3
by AMIT GARG (Director IAS SETU)
Starts: 10th August Offline: 15 Seats Left
For Online admission visit: www.iasetu.com
21, Old Rajinder Nagar, Delhi | 88266 19699

Pellet guns part of graded police response, says SC

Top court touches on 'exceptional circumstances' for their use without expanding on it; state must not meet students' protests with brutality, Bench says, but flags the possible 'hijacking' of protests

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday said the use of pellet guns by the police in "exceptional circumstances" was part of a graded approach to break civilian protests.

The court, however, did not expand on which "exceptional circumstances" justified the use of pellet guns, nor did it ask the Union government for an explanation during the hearing.

"Police rules allow the use [of pellet guns] in exceptional circumstances. One of the graded responses is the use of pellet guns," Justice Joymalya Bagchi, one of the three judges on the Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, observed orally. Hesitant to consider a blanket ban on pellet guns, the court said it would examine particular incidents during which the police had used pellet guns indiscriminately or arbitrarily in violation of the standard regulations mapping graded responses for crowd control.

> The use of such projectile activated guns for crowd dispersal fails the constitutional tests of necessity, proportionality, and reasonableness
>
> **PETITION AGAINST PELLET GUNS**

> Police rules allow the use [of pellet guns] in exceptional circumstances. One of the graded responses is the use of pellet guns
>
> **JUSTICE JOYMALYA BAGCHI**
> Supreme Court judge

The court was hearing a petition filed by former Indian Police Service (IPS) officer Yashovardhan Azad, and two pellet injury victims, Prashant Kumar Singh and Shekh Irshad Mansoori, primarily for a direction to ban the use of kinetic metallic pellets by law enforcement agencies on civilian assemblies.

The petition argued that the use of projectile-activated guns (PAG) or pellet guns loaded with partly or wholly metallic pellets for crowd dispersal fails the constitutional tests of necessity, proportionality, and reasonableness.

Though the court "completely agreed" that the state must meet students' protests with non-violence and not brutality, the Bench flagged the possibility of unscrupulous elements "hijacking" a *bona fide* students' protest, driving it into a spiral of violence.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 14
KASHMIR'S PELLET VICTIMS
» PAGE 14

Big turnout for Datia bypoll, high drama in Bankipur

The Hindu Bureau
PATNA/BHOPAL/AHMEDABAD

Datia Assembly constituency in Madhya Pradesh witnessed a bumper turnout of 71.44% on Thursday. In Manjalpur, Gujarat, the turnout was 37.50%.

Polling ended with 34.30% turnout in the Bankipur byelection in Bihar. High drama unfolded after Jan Suraaj Party (JSP) founder Prashant Kishor, who made his electoral debut in Bankipur, accused Bihar Police of detaining at least 20 of his party workers engaged in poll work.

Around 1 a.m., Mr. Kishor went with a large group of supporters to the Jakkanpur police station, leading to a heated argument with Station House Officer Rituraj Singh over "illegally" detaining JSP workers.

Counting of votes will take place on August 3.

DETAILS ON
» PAGE 4

MAINTENANCE CHARGES
Debit cards becoming costlier for customers
BUSINESS » PAGE 17

JETS SCRAMBLED
Russian missile fell in Poland, says NATO
WORLD » PAGE 20

PARLEY
The promise and constraints of fast-track courts
Have the special courts delivered speedy justice?
OPINION » PAGE 11

In deep waters

A man wading through a waterlogged area after heavy rain triggered flooding in Odisha's Balasore district on Thursday. PTI (REPORT ON PAGE 4)

Women face doxxing, online threats after Delhi protests

Suruchi Kumari
NEW DELHI

Following the protests at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi demanding the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan as Union Education Minister, several women who took part in the movement have reported being subjected to online harassment.

The Hindu has verified multiple such instances, including women facing doxxing (the circulation of personal information) and rape and death threats online.

Videos and photographs of women who attended the protest last week or gave social media bytes have been shared across social media platforms, with several X and Instagram handles urging their followers to "teach them a lesson".

Several social media handles have been found to be sharing details of women who took part in the July 20 march. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

One woman was declared "most wanted" in a post that said a "search is on" and sought information about her whereabouts. By Thursday afternoon, posts claiming she had been identified were circulating online, carrying her name, city, and a copy of a zero FIR registered in Noida. In the purported video, the woman is alleged to have "abused" Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 14

No adverse action over NEET protest: Delhi govt.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Home Department of the Delhi government on Thursday issued an order stating that no adverse legal action will be taken against people involved in the protests against the NEET paper leak issue.

"The protection, however, shall not extend to persons having criminal antecedents," it said, citing a Supreme Court order dated July 28. In cases of arrests or detentions related to the protests, the process for releasing those held will be undertaken "expeditiously", as per the order.

DETAILS ON
» PAGE 2

Activists raise transparency concerns as PM CARES Fund withholds audit statements since FY 2022-23

Bindu Shajan Perappadan
NEW DELHI

The Prime Minister's Citizen Assistance and Relief in Emergency Situations (PM CARES) Fund has not made public any audited financial statements for the past three fiscal years even as activists raise concerns about its transparency.

The fund, a public charitable Trust established in March 2020 amid the COVID-19 crisis to support relief efforts during public health emergencies and other disasters, is chaired by the Prime Minister and funded entirely through voluntary contributions, according to information released by the Centre.

Chaired by the PM, the fund was set up in 2020 to aid relief efforts during public health emergencies and other disasters. FILE PHOTO

The last publicly available audited financial statements, for the financial year 2022-23, show an opening balance of ₹5,415.65 crore, voluntary contributions of ₹909.64 crore, total receipts of ₹6,723.07 crore, total payments of ₹439.38 crore, and a closing balance of ₹6,283.68 crore as on March 31, 2023. Audited financial statements for 2019-20, 2020-21, 2021-22, and 2022-23 are available on the PM CARES website.

The absence of publicly available audit statements after 2022-23 is "extremely concerning", Anjali Bhardwaj, co-convener of the National Campaign for People's Right to Information, told *The Hindu*.

"The fund was presented as having been set up by the Union government, making it appear to be a public authority. Government employees also contributed from their salaries," Ms. Bhardwaj said.

"However, when information regarding the funds collected and spent was sought, the government maintained that the Trust is not a public authority under the RTI Act... At present, PM CARES remains outside the ambit of the RTI Act, parliamentary scrutiny, and audit by the Comptroller and Auditor-General," she said.

Information relating to the PM CARES Fund should be made available to the public, former Central Information Commissioner and RTI activist Shailesh Gandhi said.

'Falls in ambit of RTI'

"Legally speaking, the PM CARES Fund falls within the ambit of the RTI Act... In fact, anything associated with the Prime Minister, except matters affecting national security, should be open to public scrutiny. The trustees of the PM CARES Fund are Union Ministers. They are public servants and should be accountable," he said.

CWMA upholds order directing release of Cauvery water to T.N.

B.S. Satish Kumar
BENGALURU

In a setback to Karnataka, the Cauvery Water Management Authority (CWMA), which met in Delhi on Thursday, upheld the Cauvery Water Regulation Committee's (CWRC) order directing Karnataka to release water to Tamil Nadu at a rate of 3,500 cusecs a day for 15 days.

The CWMA, which is the apex body that monitors implementation of water release as per the Supreme Court's verdict, asked Karnataka to release water to Tamil Nadu in accordance with the CWRC's order. The CWRC had on Tuesday ordered Karnataka to commence release of water to Tamil Nadu with effect from Wednesday. However, Karnataka had filed an appeal against the CWRC's order before the CWMA. At Thursday's meeting, Karnataka appealed to the CWMA to keep the CWRC's order in abeyance for another fortnight and take a call after reviewing the evolving hydrological situation. But the CWMA, which looked into the issue besides taking stock of the hydrological conditions, endorsed the CWRC order.

Protests being held against the CWRC's order in Mysuru on Thursday. M.A. SRIRAM

Meanwhile, Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar convened an all-party meeting on Sunday to deliberate on the CWMA's decision.

In its submission before the CWMA, Karnataka said that it was facing an acute hydrological distress, and the cumulative inflows into all the four reservoirs in the Cauvery basin were 65.65% below the 30-year average due to the super El Nino effect.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 14

IN BRIEF

Palam fire: shortcomings in response worsened death toll

A magisterial inquiry into the March 18 fire in a residential building in Palam, which claimed nine lives, has concluded that the blaze most likely started due to an electric short circuit near the building's main circuit breaker box. The report, submitted to the Delhi government, also stated that the high death toll was the result of a combination of building deficiencies, violations of safety norms and systemic shortcomings in the emergency response. The report noted that a glitch rendered the Delhi Fire Services' skylift inoperable. A second skylift arrived later, but by then all nine had died. PTI

DU approves Semester Away Programme, direct PhD entry

The Delhi University's Executive Council on Thursday approved the introduction of a Semester Away Programme for undergraduate students in collaboration with foreign higher education institutions. It also cleared a proposal allowing students to directly pursue doctoral studies after completing four-year undergraduate programmes. The approvals came despite opposition from some elected members who raised concerns about the "dilution" of the university's degrees and submitted a dissent note. PTI

No legal action against Jantar Mantar protesters: Delhi govt.

Protection shall not extend to persons with criminal past, in line with SC order; CJP says cases should be formally withdrawn and any dilution of govt. assurances could force students back onto the streets

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi government on Thursday said that no legal action will be taken against those arrested in connection with the recently held protests against the NEET question paper leak.

The protection, however, shall not extend to persons with "criminal antecedents", in line with the Supreme Court's Tuesday's order, the Home Department stated in an order.

The arrests were made after the police crackdown on protesters on July 20 during a march to Parliament spearheaded by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP).

If anyone has been arrested or detained in these cases, the process for reviewing the arrests and releasing them will be undertaken "expeditiously", according to the order.

Students from various Left outfits staging a protest against the recent police action on protesters in West Bengal, Bihar, and Assam, at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi on Wednesday. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

"Government of NCT of Delhi does not propose to take any further adverse action against the individuals involved in the protests, and the matter shall be treated as closed without any future proceedings on this account," the order read.

The CJP welcomed the Delhi government's notification, but said the cases should be formally withdrawn and warned that any dilution of the assurances given by the Centre on July 25, when the CJP called off its 36-day protest, could force students back onto the streets. CJP chief spokesperson Saurav Das said the wording of the notification did not reflect what was promised by the government.

"The Delhi government has released a notification which says that all the FIRs will not be pursued further and they may be treated as closed. We are not very happy with the term. The term that they should have used is that the FIRs will be withdrawn," Mr. Das said.

"The government is saying that the Supreme Court has mandated that the FIRs proceed. But that's a misreading and a misleading of the situation. Nowhere in the Supreme Court order has it said that the FIRs cannot be withdrawn. Those powers exist with the government," he said.

'Honour the assurances'

The CJP urged the Centre to honour the assurances given to protesters.

Delhi Home Minister Ashish Sood clarified in a statement that the relief will not apply to individuals who have criminal cases registered against them or those who indulged in violence, vandalism, or any other unlawful activities under the guise of the protest. "Such persons will face action strictly in accordance with the law. The government fully respects the democratic right to peaceful expression, but no leniency will be shown towards those who disrupt law and order or engage in violent activities," Mr. Sood said.

(With inputs from PTI)

Woman rushed to RML Hospital with injuries on July 20 discharged

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Protesters claim the 21-year-old was injured in a stampede-like melee during police lathi charge on July 20. FILE PHOTO

The 21-year-old injured woman, who was admitted to Dr. Ram Manohar Lohia (RML) Hospital on July 20 in critical condition, has been discharged with follow-up instructions after making a satisfactory recovery, hospital officials said on Thursday.

While hospital authorities did not provide the exact cause of her injuries, protesters who participated in the 'Chalo Sansad' march have claimed that she sustained injuries in a "stampede-like" situation following the police lathi charge.

A week in ICU

In a release, the hospital stated that on admission, the woman was resuscitated in the emergency department and shifted to the intensive care unit (ICU), where she was placed on ventilator support. "Following sustained clinical improvement, she was successfully weaned off ventilator support and, after one week in the ICU, shifted to the Nursing Home ward for further recovery and rehabilitation," read the RML Hospital statement. It added that as of Thursday, the 10th day of her hospitalisation, the 21-year-old is conscious, alert and stable.

10-day hospitalisation

"In view of her satisfactory clinical recovery and stable condition, she is being discharged today with appropriate medical advice and follow-up instructions," said the Central government-run medical facility.

Several protesters were injured during the July 20 march, with most being discharged later that day after receiving medical treatment.

Notice to Vikaspuri school over fire safety lapses

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi government has issued a show-cause notice to a private school in Vikaspuri over "life-threatening safety hazards and financial irregularities".

According to a statement issued from the office of Education Minister Ashish Sood, the school was found to be running 43 classrooms without fire safety clearance and had unauthorised structures, including a tin-shed block, a basement and a third floor.

The school has been given seven days to respond, failing which action, including a possible takeover by the Delhi government, may follow.

Authorities have also flagged illegal use of groundwater, unpaid teacher salaries, unrecognised classes and unauthorised fee hikes during the pandemic.

2020 riots: HC to hear today Umar Khalid's bail plea in UAPA case

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Activist Umar Khalid has moved the Delhi High Court seeking bail in a case under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA) linked to the alleged "larger conspiracy" behind the February 2020 north-east Delhi riots.

His appeal challenging a trial court order of July 4, which dismissed his bail plea, is listed for hearing before a Bench of Justices Prathiba M. Singh and Vikas Mahajan on Friday.

Mr. Khalid, arrested in September 2020, has been booked under the UAPA as one of the alleged "masterminds" of the violence that left 53 dead and over 700 injured during protests against the Citizenship (Amendment) Act, 2019, and the proposed National Register of Citizens.

Set up HC Circuit Bench in Gurugram, Haryana MP urges Central govt.

The Hindu Bureau
GURUGRAM

Rajya Sabha member Sanjay Bhatia on Thursday urged the Centre to set up a Circuit Bench of the Punjab and Haryana High Court in Gurugram to improve access to justice.

Raising the issue during the Zero Hour proceedings in the ongoing Monsoon Session, he said litigants from south Haryana districts such as Gurugram, Faridabad, Nuh, Palwal, Rewari and Mahendragarh had to travel to Chandigarh, leading to higher costs and delays.

Mr. Bhatia said Gurugram's growth as a corporate and start-up hub had increased legal cases. Citing Articles 39A and 21, he stressed the need for accessible and speedy justice, and called for a feasibility study.

Clear water dues or face sealing: DJB to defaulters

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi Jal Board (DJB) has issued notices to commercial property owners with outstanding dues of ₹25 lakh or more, Water Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh said on Thursday.

He said the government has given defaulters until August 15 to clear their dues, adding that failure to do so could result in the attachment and sealing of properties under the relevant provisions of the law.

"The DJB has the authority to attach and seal the properties of water bill defaulters. So far, we have identified 1,025 commercial properties with outstanding water bills of ₹25 lakh or more accumulated over the years. If the defaulters fail to pay within the deadline, appropriate action will be taken in accordance with the rules," the Minister said.

The government aims to recover nearly ₹5,000 crore in outstanding principal water dues while providing relief by waiving approximately ₹11,000 crore in accumulated late-payment surcharge.

कार्यालय परियोजना प्रबंधक, यूनिट–18
कन्सट्रक्शन एण्ड डिजाइन सर्विसेज
उत्तर प्रदेश जल निगम (नगरीय)
(उ0प्र0 सरकार का उपक्रम)
मकान सं.–7बी/108, बौद्ध विहार मझोला योजना सं.–4, भाग–2 (निकट संविधान साहित्य वाटिका, चन्द्रशेखर आजाद पार्क के सामने), दिल्ली रोड, मुरादाबाद–244103
E-mail: pm18mbd@gmail.com

पत्रांक– 2070/एम-18 / 596
दिनांक: 29.07.2026

अल्पकालीन ई–निविदा सूचना

उत्तर प्रदेश जल निगम (नगरीय), की ओर से अधोहस्ताक्षरी द्वारा Construction of Govt. Inter college Manunagar Bilaspur Rampur (Library room) अनुमानित लागत ₹ 14.25 लाख, हेतु दिनांक 13.08.2026 की अपरान्ह 16:30 बजे तक ई-निविदाएं आमन्त्रित की जाती हैं। उक्त कार्य हेतु ई-निविदा प्रपत्र दिनांक 31.07.2026 से दिनांक 13.08.2026 के मध्य उत्तर प्रदेश सरकार की e-procurement की वेबसाइट https:// etender.up.nic.in से डाउनलोड किये जा सकते हैं तथा ई-निविदा दिनांक 14.08.2026 को अपराह 13:30 बजे कार्यालय परियोजना प्रबन्धक, यूनिट-18, सी. एण्ड डी.एस., उ.प्र. जल निगम (नगरीय), मुरादाबाद में खोली जायेंगी। ई-निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य ₹ 2,000.00+GST (18%) अतिरिक्त देय होगा। निविदा की किसी भी शर्तों को परिवर्तित करने तथा निविदा को बिना कोई कारण बताये अस्वीकृत करने का अधिकार विभाग के पास सुरक्षित रहेगा।

निविदा से सम्बन्धित विस्तृत विवरण विभाग की वेबसाइट www.cdsupjn.org एवं प्रोक्योरमेन्ट पोर्टल https://etender.up.nic.in पर उपलब्ध है। समस्त शुद्धि पत्र (Corrigendum) https://etender.up.nic.in पर ही अपलोड किये जायेंगे, **इनका पृथक से कोई प्रकाशन नहीं किया जायेगा।** निविदादाताओं को सलाह दी जाती है कि वे उक्त वेबसाईट का समय- समय पर अवलोकन करते रहें।

TO ADVERTISE PLEASE CONTACT
Mr. N SELVA KUMAR
PH: 9820350726
selvakumar.n@thehindu.co.in
THE HINDU
India's National Newspaper

NORTH EASTERN RAILWAY
OPEN TENDER NOTICE NO. NER-BSB0SnT-OT-38-2026

"Open Tenders" through Online (E-Tendering) are invited by Divisional Railway Manager (Signal & Telecomm)/ Varanasi/North Eastern Railway for and behalf of the President of India for the following works:-
Sl No.-1, Tender Notice No. and Description of Work: NER-BSB0SnT-OT-38-2026, Name of Work: Provision of Aspiration type Fire alarm system along with FADS at balance locations in the section of ADSTE/BSB & ADSTE/MAU. **Details:** Approx. Value (Rs.): ₹ 2,86,74,012.69, Earnest Money (Rs.): ₹ 5,73,500/-, Cost of Tender Form (Rs.): ₹ 00.00, Completion Period: 12 Months. Tender Closing Date & Time: 24-08-2026 up to 15:00 Hrs.
(1) Tender Online will be submitted up to 15:00 hrs. on date 24-08-2026.
(2) For full details and submission of bid kindly visit the official website of Indian Railways i.e. *www.ireps.gov.in*
Divl. Rly. Manager (S&T)
CPRO/Signal-83 **Varanasi**
Never travel on roof and foot boards.

CM: govt. to introduce land records Bill, issue Aadhaar-like ID cards

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The proposed Bill is likely to be tabled in a special session of the Assembly, according to CM Rekha Gupta's office. ANI

The Delhi government is working on a new Bill to create a consolidated digital record of all properties in the city, the Chief Minister's Office said on Thursday.

"Once the law comes in to force, every property in Delhi will undergo a scientific survey and a comprehensive digital record will be created. Each property will then be assigned a unique Property Aadhaar Card," an official statement read. The proposed Delhi Land Records Bill, 2026, however, will not be tabled in the Monsoon Session of the Assembly and the government is likely to convene a special session later in connection with the Bill.

"Just as the Aadhaar card has provided every citizen with a trusted form of identity, every property in Delhi will now be given a secure and authentic digital identity. This will make property records across the national capital more transparent, well-organised and technologically secure," Chief Minister Rekha Gupta was quoted as saying.

"With the new system in place, authenticated digital property records will be available, improving transparency," she said.

Assam govt. seeks Central package for relief, rehabilitation of flood victims

Press Trust of India
GUWAHATI/ NEW DELHI

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Thursday said the State has demanded a support package from the Centre for relief and rehabilitation of the people ravaged by an unprecedented flood.

The State government placed its demand before the Inter-Ministerial Central Team (IMCT), which concluded its four-day tour to the flood-devastated districts of Upper Assam on Wednesday. "The flood this year has been on an unprecedented scale, leaving behind a trail of devastation which our double-engine govt. will mitigate to sufferings of our people," Mr. Sarma said in a post on X.

He said the State government has placed a demand for recognition of the Upper Assam flood as an "atypical, high-intensity, rapid-onset event" with flexible norms for damage assessment and assistance.

Flood-affected residents using a makeshift raft to navigate through inundated areas while shifting belongings in Sivasagar. FILE PHOTO

It demanded a "dedicated Central support package" for Sivasagar, Charaideo, Jorhat and Golaghat, covering relief, housing, infrastructure and livelihood restoration, Mr. Sarma said. He, however, did not mention how much money the State has asked from the Centre under the package.

The flood situation in Assam remained grim on Thursday even as water receded from most parts of the State, with the death toll rising to 78 and over three lakh people continuing to reel under the deluge, officials said. The State Disaster Management Authority's daily bulletin issued on Wednesday night said three deaths were reported in the last 24 hours – two from Sivasagar district and one from Golaghat. With these, the toll in this year's flood has reached 78.

Mr. Sarma said the IMCT visited the State to undertake an on-ground assessment and review the ongoing relief, restoration and rehabilitation efforts as per assurances given by the Union Home Minister Amit Shah. "During the review, the team was apprised of the extensive damage caused to critical infrastructure, agriculture and livelihoods," he added.

To deal with the situation, Assam sought relaxation of documentation and eligibility norms under Central and Centrally sponsored schemes to enable affected households to access hassle-free support, the CM said.

Heavy rain batters Chhattisgarh districts; 5 killed, roads cut off

Press Trust of India
RAIPUR

Heavy rain lashed several parts of Chhattisgarh over the past few days, inundating low-lying areas, swelling rivers and streams, disrupting road connectivity and creating flood-like conditions in parts of the State, officials said on Thursday. At least five people have died in rain-related incidents during the period, they said.

The worst-hit areas are in the Raipur, Bastar and Durg divisions, where several roads remained submerged, and authorities issued alerts for residents living along riverbanks.

A 55-year-old man was swept away while attempting to cross the swollen Sargi stream in Gariaband district on Wednesday. His body was recovered around five kilometres away near Khuteri village, officials said.

Continuous rainfall has disrupted road connectivity in the district, with National Highway-130 linking Raipur and neighbouring Odisha remaining closed due to waterlogging.

The Gariaband-Mahasamund, Gariaband-Nagri-Dhamtari and Kochbay-Malgaon-Kasanala roads were also shut, officials said.

In Sarangarh-Bilaigarh district, the bodies of a couple, who were swept away along with their car, were recovered on Wednesday.

In another incident, the body of a 20-year-old man from Durg-Bhilai, who was swept away in the Damaudhara waterfall in Sakti district while on an outing with friends, was recovered on Wednesday after a nearly 24-hour rescue operation.

On Tuesday, a farmer was killed after a tree fell on him in the Gangaloor area of Bijapur amid heavy rain.

Timings
DELHI

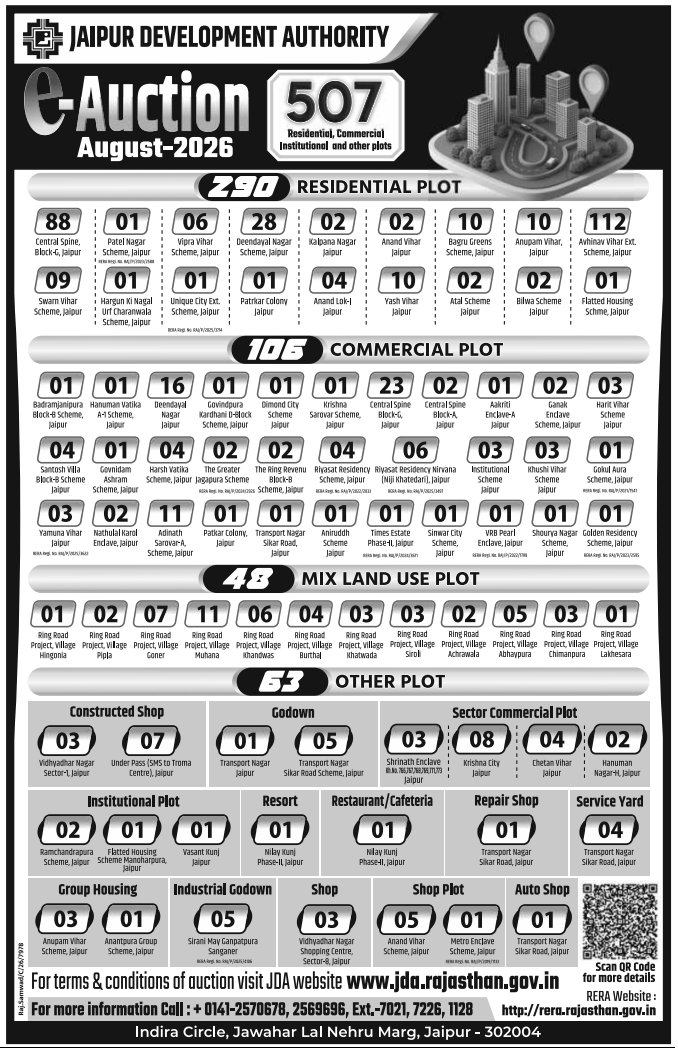
FRIDAY, JUL. 31		
RISE	05:42	SET 19:13
RISE	20:22	SET 07:02
SATURDAY, AUG. 01		
RISE	05:43	SET 19:12
RISE	20:52	SET 07:59
SUNDAY, AUG. 02		
RISE	05:43	SET 19:12
RISE	21:21	SET 08:56

Delhi Weather	max	min
Delhi City	36	28
Safdarjang	36	28
Palam	35	26

Delhi Palam Today
34°C The weather will be warm. Night also will be comfortable. Spell of light rain and thundershower with gusty winds to occur.

Delhi Palam Tomorrow
33°C The weather will be warm. Spell of moderate rain and thundershower with strong winds to occur.

© Copyright Skymet Weather 2026
All rights reserved.



INBRIEF

Waris Punjab De leader, 14 others booked over protest

The Chandigarh police have booked Akali Dal Waris Punjab De leader Manpreet Singh Ayali and 14 others for clashing with police personnel after they were stopped from marching to Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann's residence during a protest on Wednesday. Besides Mr. Ayali, the police named 14 others in the FIR, including Satinderjit Singh Gill, Kabal Singh Bhullar, Parmjit Singh Johal, Chamkaur Singh Dhunn, and Iman Singh Khara. The Akali Dal Waris Punjab De supporters had taken out the march seeking the release of jailed Khadoor Sahib MP Amritpal Singh. PTI

West Bengal cash haul rises to ₹28.5 crore; one arrested

The West Bengal police on Thursday arrested Minar Mondal, brother-in-law of absconding stone trader Tullu Mondal, following a night-long search operation. In one of the State's biggest seizures of alleged illegally amassed assets in recent years, the police recovered ₹20 crore and and 15 kg of gold from Mr. Minar's two-storey residence at Deucha village in Birbhum district till Wednesday evening. On Thursday, the police said the cash haul had risen to ₹28.5 crore. The State police, accompanied by Central forces, also reached the residence of Mr. Tullu, where a search operation is likely to be carried out. PTI

High turnout recorded in Datia Assembly bypoll, high drama in Bankipur

Jan Suraaj Party candidate Prashant Kishor accuses Bihar Police of detaining at least 20 party workers; Congress alleges polling agent detained in Datia; voting largely peaceful in Manjalpur

The Hindu Bureau
PATNA/BHOPAL/AHMEDABAD

Polling ended with 34.30% voter turnout on Thursday in the Bankipur Assembly byelection in Bihar, 7% less in comparison to the 2025 Assembly election, as per the data shared by the Election Commission (EC).

Datia Assembly constituency in Madhya Pradesh witnessed a bumper turnout of 71.44% to decide the fate of 21 candidates in the fray, with the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and Congress locked in a tight contest. In Manjalpur, Gujarat, the turnout was 37.50%.

Jan Suraaj Party (JSP) founder Prashant Kishor, who made his electoral debut in Bankipur, accused Bihar Police of detaining at least 20 of his party workers engaged in poll work.

Around 1 a.m., high drama unfolded at the Jakkanpur police station when Mr. Kishor went with a large group of supporters, leading to a heated argument with Station House Officer Rituraj Singh over "illegally" detaining JSP workers. Later, the police issued a statement asserting that during the 'silence period', which comes into effect 48 hours before the conclusion of polling, it was found that "individuals from other districts were present in the constituency and there were indications that they were engaging in poll campaigning", leading to these individuals being placed under preventive detention.

People showing their inked fingers after casting their vote for the Bankipur Assembly byelection in Patna on Thursday. PTI

Mr. Kishor, however, alleged that the State government misused the police machinery to support BJP candidate Neeraj Kumar Sinha and stopped JSP supporters from voting at several booths. The seat had fallen vacant after BJP national president Nitin Nabin was elected to the Rajya Sabha in April.

Heated arguments

JSP and BJP workers had heated arguments at several places outside polling booths during voting, including Anandpuri, Peermuhani, and Kidwaipuri.

The Datia bypoll, necessitated following the disqualification of Congress's Rajendra Bharti in April due to his conviction in a bank fraud case, is likely to be a straight fight between the BJP and the Congress.

The BJP has fielded debutant Ashutosh Tiwari, after snubbing former State Home Minister Narottam Mishra. The Congress fielded Ghanshyam Singh, a member of the erstwhile Datia royal family and former legislator from the neighbouring Sewda Assembly seat.

Even as Collector and Returning Officer Swapnil Wankhede claimed that polling was peaceful, the Congress alleged that one of its polling agents was detained "without any reason" and sought the EC's intervention.

The voting process for the Manjalpur bypoll, necessitated by the death of Yogesh Patel on June 2, remained peaceful throughout the day, officials said.

Counting of votes will take place in all three constituencies on August 3.

West Bengal gets its first NIA police station in Kolkata

Senjuti Sengupta
KOLKATA

West Bengal's first dedicated National Investigation Agency (NIA) police station will come up in Kolkata's New Town. It will handle the investigation of offences across the State, including cases related to threats to sovereignty and security, and acts of terrorism.

In a notification issued on Wednesday night, Governor R.N. Ravi formally declared the premises on the 15th floor of the National Buildings Construction Corporation Square, Action Area III, New Town as the NIA police station for West Bengal. The regional branch of the NIA has been functioning from the same building since 2014.

Long-pending proposal

The notification clears a long-pending proposal to set up an NIA police station in the State. According to officials, the proposal had remained pending during the previous Trinamool Congress government and was not implemented.

The new Bharatiya Janata Party government approved the proposal in a Cabinet meeting chaired by Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari last week.

The facility in Kolkata will be the 17th police station of the NIA in the country. FILE PHOTO

With the new police station in place, the NIA will now be empowered to register FIRs directly in Kolkata in connection with any case in West Bengal. Until now, NIA investigations in the State could commence only after a copy of the FIR was received from the Central probe agency's headquarters in the national capital.

This will be the 17th police station of the NIA in the country. The 16 other police stations are located in New Delhi, Jaipur, Ahmedabad, Bengaluru, Bhubaneswar, Chennai, Guwahati, Hyderabad, Imphal, Jammu, Kochi, Lucknow, Mumbai, Raipur, Ranchi, and Visakhapatnam.

Akal Takht chief rejects Punjab govt.'s 'unsatisfactory' response to anti-sacrilege law objections

Press Trust of India
AMRITSAR

Akal Takht Jathedar Giani Kuldip Singh Gargajj on Thursday rejected the Punjab government's response on the anti-sacrilege law, terming it "unsatisfactory".

His remarks came a day after Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) legislator Inderbir Singh Nijjar submitted the State government's response to objections raised by the Akal Takht regarding the Jaagat Jot Sri Guru Granth Sahib Satkar (Amendment) Act, 2026.

On June 29, Mr. Gargajj had directed the AAP government to address objections concerning the law within a month.

Addressing the media in Amritsar on Thursday, Mr. Gargajj directed all Sikh legislators and Cabinet Ministers to ensure that no discussion takes place on the anti-sacrilege law during the Assembly session beginning on August 3 until consensus is reached with the Akal Takht Sahib and the Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee on the issue. He also directed them not to give consent to any further amendments to the law.

It is clear that the AAP dispensation is not ready to make further amendments to the law, Giani Kuldip Singh Gargajj said. FILE PHOTO

Referring to the government's response, the Jathedar said it is clear that the AAP dispensation is not ready to make further amendments to the law in accordance with the sentiments conveyed by the Akal Takht.

AAP clarification

AAP MP Malvinder Singh Kang on Thursday asserted that the government's anti-sacrilege law is solely aimed at ensuring strictest punishment for those who deliberately commit acts of sacrilege and has no intention of interfering in Sikh religious affairs.

Senthilbalaji's appeal against bail denial to be heard by SC today

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court agreed to urgently hear on Friday an appeal filed by former DMK Minister for Prohibition, Electricity and Excise V. Senthilbalaji against the Madras High Court's refusal to grant him pre-arrest bail in a case registered against him by the Directorate of Vigilance and Anti-Corruption (DVAC).

Making an oral mentioning before Chief Justice of India Surya Kant on Thursday, senior advocates Kapil Sibal and Mukul Rohatgi, along with senior advocate Amit Anand Tiwari, said the FIR was based on allegations levelled by the Enforcement Directorate (ED) in an affidavit filed two years ago in the apex court. "The DVAC gleaned that a cognisable offence was made out owing to events that occurred between 2021 and 2025," Mr. Rohatgi submitted.

Mr. Tiwari said the case in which the ED had filed an affidavit was sub judice in the Supreme Court and its proceedings remain stayed. Mr. Sibal added that there was a risk of his client's bail being cancelled in the stayed case too due to the allegations made in the FIR lodged by the DVAC on July 28.

'Laundered money'

The DVAC alleged that the former Minister and others "laundered huge illicit money in the Tamil Nadu State Marketing Corporation Limited by various means of manipulation and favouritism".

Earlier in the day, the Madras High Court rejected Mr. Senthilbalaji's advance bail petition.

The court observed that it was a case requiring custodial interrogation.

Calcutta HC seeks report from police over 'encounter death' of Baruipur rape-murder accused

Senjuti Sengupta
KOLKATA

The Calcutta High Court on Thursday sought a detailed report from the Baruipur district police in connection with the "encounter killing" of Prabhash Mondal, the main accused in the rape and murder of a minor girl.

A Division Bench of Justices Tapabrata Chakraborty and Partha Sarathi Chattopadhyay passed the order while hearing a public interest litigation plea filed by advocate Shiladitya Rakshit. It claimed that the police's statements in connection with the "encounter killing" were "fabricated".

Around 12.45 a.m. on July 8, a team from the Baruipur police station took the accused to the encounter spot for the reconstruction of the crime scene.

The police said the accused allegedly snatched the service weapon of a police officer, fired one round at the police team, and attempted to flee.

The HC was hearing a PIL claiming that the police statements in connection with the 'encounter killing' were 'fabricated'

Prima facie, the autopsy report found two bullets in the body of the accused fired by Inspector Arghya Mondal, officials said.

Preliminary investigation into the rape and murder case suggested that the accused had abducted the girl and raped her before throwing her into a pond, according to officials. Four persons have been arrested in connection with the crime after the 12-year-old girl's body was fished out of a pond on July 5 in Baruipur, South 24 Parganas district of West Bengal. The incident sparked a violent protest in the area, with an angry mob killing a person over suspicion of his involvement in the crime.

Appearing for the petitioner, senior advocate Bikash Ranjan Bhattacharya told the court that the police failed to arrange sufficient security measures at the reconstruction site that led to the mishap. He also questioned the timing of the crime reconstruction late at night amid adverse weather conditions.

Advocate General Rajdeep Majumder argued that the police had to shoot in self-defence. He said the police also registered a suo motu FIR and the matter is being probed by the Criminal Investigation Department. The case will be heard again on August 18.

Alleged assault on doctors after death of patient in Kota

Press Trust of India
KOTA

A 70-year-old patient's death at the New Medical College Hospital in Kota on Thursday triggered a ruckus, with his family allegedly assaulting doctors over claims of negligence, police said. Resident doctors boycotted work for around three hours demanding action over the incident.

Amar Singh, a resident of Rampura, had been undergoing treatment in the ICU for nearly a week and died around 10 a.m., Circle Inspector Harendra Singh said. The police have arrested the deceased's son, Shakti Singh, for allegedly assaulting the doctors and obstructing their work.

7 lakh people affected by floods in 20 districts of Odisha

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

Over seven lakh people across 20 districts of Odisha have been hit by floods and heavy rain resulting from a deep depression weather system that formed over the State and Chhattisgarh on July 28.

The primary reason attributed to flooding in the Mahanadi and Brahmani rivers is 96.7% excess cumulative rainfall recorded in July. "The cumulative rainfall in the State from July 1 to 30 stood at 644.1 mm against the normal average of 327.4 mm, registering a surplus of 96.7%," the office of the Special Relief Commissioner stated.

The average rainfall recorded in the State for the 24 hours ending at 8.30 a.m. on Thursday was 20.3 mm. The highest rainfall of 164 mm was recorded in Sinapali block of Nuapada district. Twelve blocks received over 100 mm of rainfall while 26 blocks recorded rainfall between 50 mm and 100 mm, it added.

An aerial view of flood-hit areas in Jajpur, Bhadrak, and Balasore districts of Odisha on Thursday. PTI

Odisha Revenue and Disaster Management Minister Suresh Pujari conducted an aerial review of the flood-affected areas. The situation is under control, Mr. Pujari said.

3 deaths reported

The State government has received reports of three deaths and post-mortem examinations will be conducted, according to an official statement.

Bhadrak is the worst affected district, with over four lakh people estimated to have been impacted.

The State government has opened 234 relief camps in Bhadrak district to accommodate more than one lakh people. In Balasore and Jajpur districts, the affected people are estimated at 1,46,504 and 1,37,010 respectively.

As many as 136 response teams have been deployed across the State to carry out rescue operations.

Eight persons, who were stranded on the roof of a poultry farmhouse amid rising floodwaters near Birighat village under Khariar block of Nuapada district, were rescued by the Odisha Disaster Rapid Action Force.

The situation may worsen as some embankments have reportedly been breached at different locations, according to officials. A medium-level flood is expected in the Mahanadi river system as its upper catchment has received heavy rain in the past 24 hours, read a statement issued by the Special Relief Commissioner's office.

'Odisha medical exam paper shared on social media during the test'

Press Trust of India
BHUBANESWAR

Amid nationwide outrage over the alleged NEET leak, a question paper of the Odisha medical postgraduate examination was allegedly shared on social media during the test, officials said on Thursday.

Photographs of a question paper of the All Odisha Medical PG Examination was found forwarded on a social media platform on July 27, when the theory exam of a subject of the 2023-26 batch students was under way, they said.

The photographs of the question paper (second) for General Surgery of the MS/MD course were allegedly shared on WhatsApp groups formed by some PG students. Some students also claimed that answers were circulated from certain numbers while the test was under way, they said.

The matter came to light when a student of a private medical college in Bhubaneswar allegedly possessing pictures of the question paper flagged the issue and disclosed that he had received it from a WhatsApp group formed by a student of MKCG Medical College and Hospital in Berhampur, an official said.

"It is not a question paper leak. Had the question paper come out before the exam, we could have termed it a leak," MKCG Dean and Principal Harekrushna Dalai said.

Published by Nirmala Lakshman and Printed by S. Ramanujam at HT Media Ltd. Plot No. 8, Udyog Vihar, Greater Noida Distt. Gautam Budh Nagar, U.P. 201306, on behalf of THG PUBLISHING PVT LTD., Chennai-600002. Editor: Suresh Nambath Chandrasekar (Responsible for selection of news under the PRP Act).
ISSN 0971 - 751X

Court grants relief to Baghel in morphed CD case

Shubhomoy Sikdar
RAIPUR

The Chhattisgarh High Court on Thursday stayed further proceedings against former Chhattisgarh Chief Minister Bhupesh Baghel in a Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) court in the alleged morphed CD case involving BJP MLA Rajesh Munat, said Harshwardhan Pargania, one of the lawyers who argued the case on behalf of the ex-Chief Minister.

Mr. Pargania told *The Hindu* that Justice Radhakishan Agrawal passed the interim order while hearing Mr. Baghel's petition challenging the January 24, 2026 order of the Special Judge (CBI), Raipur, which had set aside a previous discharge and directed that charges be framed against him.

Mr. Baghel argued that the trial court had already proceeded to frame charges pursuant to the revisional court's order. He contended that if the trial were allowed to continue, the present petition would be rendered infructuous

A detailed order is awaited.

Heavy security, extra buses as Kanwar Yatra begins in U.P.

35,000 police personnel, 151 companies of PAC and several companies of paramilitary forces deployed across 840 stretches for the pilgrimage

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

Uttar Pradesh Police has deployed over 35,000 personnel, 151 companies of the Provincial Armed Constabulary (PAC) and multiple companies of paramilitary forces across 840 stretches for the annual Kanwar Yatra, which started on Thursday, a senior officer said. The measures are part of the government's push for an incident-free yatra.

Additionally, the Uttar Pradesh State Road Transport Corporation (UPSRTC) will set up a 24x7 control room at every regional headquarters and run additional buses for devotees travelling to Haridwar, according to a statement issued by its Managing Director Prabhu Narayan Singh.

The announcements were made following a meeting on security arrangements, traffic management and overall preparations for the 13-day pilgrimage, which was attended by Chief Secretary Shashi Prakash Goyal, Director General of Police Rajiv Krishna and other senior bureaucrats.

According to a government note, Minister of State (Independent Charge) for Transport Dayashankar Singh has issued necessary directions to officials regarding the safe operation of corporation buses and passenger convenience. The UPSRTC will also arrange additional buses, if needed, on major routes connecting Lucknow, Ayodhya, Gorakhpur, Varanasi and Prayagraj, the MD said.

He added, "Directions have been issued to ensure that bus stations located on the 'kanwar' route provide uninterrupted facilities such as drinking water, clean toilets, seating arrangements, enquiry counters, public address systems and food stalls so that pilgrims do not face any inconvenience."

Devotees carrying Ganga water during the first day of the holy month of Sawan, in Haridwar on Thursday. PTI

T.N. moves top court against HC striking down job orders to kin of Karur victims

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK)-led Tamil Nadu government has moved the Supreme Court in appeal against a Madras High Court decision to strike down the grant of government jobs to the family members of Karur stampede victims.

The Madurai Bench of the High Court had quashed the government orders granting jobs to the victims' family members on compassionate grounds on July 27.

The State had argued in the court that the appointments were meant as a humane gesture.

The T.N. government has maintained that appointments were made on humanatarian grounds. FILE PHOTO

But the court concluded that specific guidelines covered the field of compassionate appointments, and they cannot be cast aside by the State government. The High Court had warned that the government's action, if condoned, may run the risk of opening the floodgates.

Waiting list overlooked

The High Court had pointed out that there were wait-lists in every government department for appointments on compassionate grounds.

Employment has to be granted only in accordance with seniority and not with reference to the immediate nature of relief to be granted, the Division Bench of the High Court had noted.

The High Court had reasoned that it would be in violation of the fundamental rights of equality and due of process of law, enshrined in Article 14 and 21 of the Constitution, respectively, to overlook those in the waiting list in a bid to bring relief to the family members of the Karur stampede victims.

The State had contended that these jobs were given in exercise of its executive powers under Article 162 of the Constitution. But the High Court had responded that any exercise of executive authority of power had to be within the confines of the Constitution.

The stampede occurred in September last year during a TVK roadshow addressed by now Tamil Nadu Chief Minister Joseph Vijay, who is also the party president.

BBMB share dispute: Centre proposes cashless settlement

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The long-pending demand for payment of dues to Himachal Pradesh from Bhakra Beas Management Board (BBMB) projects since 1966 is set to be fulfilled as the Supreme Court on Thursday was told by the Centre that an amicable settlement can be reached on a new cashless formula between the partner States for payment of arrears.

According to sources, BBMB is paying 7.19% share of Himachal Pradesh's electricity from Bhakra Beas projects after November 1, 2011, while Punjab and Haryana have not paid the outstanding dues of BBMB projects for the previous period, which is 13,066 million units.

Under the proposal, since no consensus was reached among the parties on the rate of electricity to be applied, the Centre has suggested payout to Himachal by Punjab and Haryana in energy terms. It was also decided that Himachal will not pay the dues of ₹420 crore to Punjab and Haryana and the amount will be adjusted from 13,066 million units of electricity.

Stone-pelting over proposed removal of Ambedkar statue

Press Trust of India
DEORIA (U.P)

Tension gripped a village in Uttar Pradesh's Deoria district on Thursday after stone-pelting broke out over the proposed removal of a statue of B.R. Ambedkar that was allegedly installed on government land without administrative permission, police said.

The incident occurred in Labakni village, where some individuals allegedly installed the statue on government wasteland on Tuesday night, an official said. The matter came to the administration's notice on Wednesday morning, following which a joint team of revenue and police officials visited the spot to assess the situation.

The dispute flared up again on Thursday when people from both sides confronted each other over the proposed removal of the statue. The argument soon escalated into stone-pelting, creating tension in the area.

Gauribazar Station House Officer Mrityunjay Rai said the situation was under control and adequate police force had been deployed to maintain law and order.

Sanitation workers' bandh hits normal life in Punjab

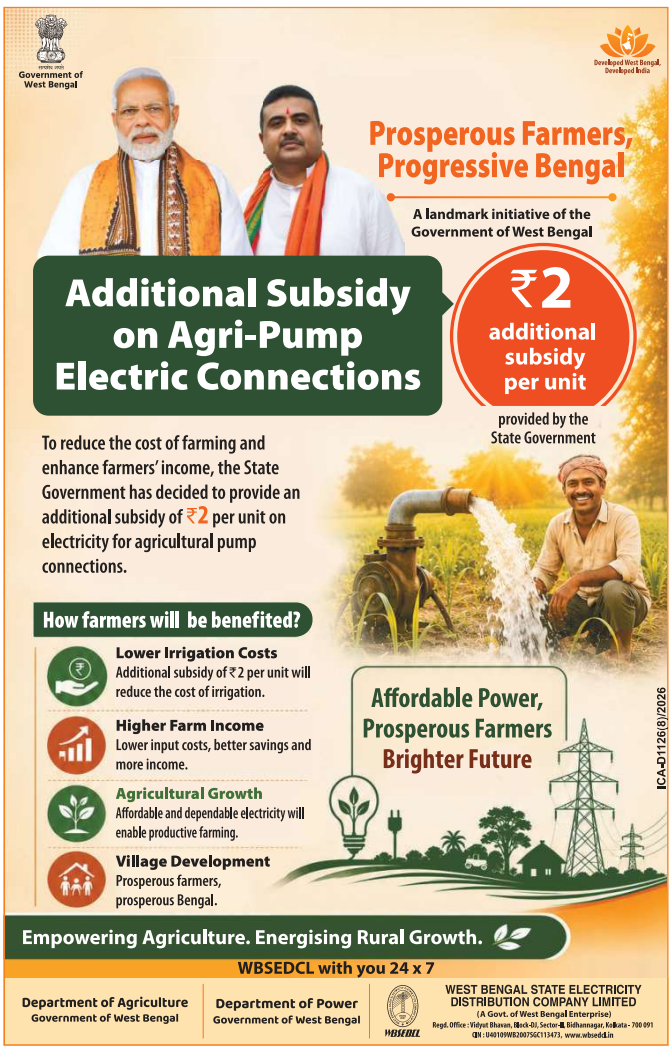
Press Trust of India
HOSHIARPUR/FEROZEPUR

Normal life was affected at most places in Punjab on Thursday with markets and commercial establishments remaining shut following a State-level 'bandh' call by sanitation workers against the Barnala lathi-charge incident.

Sanitation workers also held protests at several places against the State government, demanding action against police officials involved in the lathi-charge incident.

On July 22, police resorted to a lathi-charge on sanitation workers after they allegedly hurled stones and garbage bags at police in Barnala in an alleged attempt to thwart a cleanliness drive undertaken by the local municipal corporation and district authorities.

Almost all shops and business establishments remained closed in Punjab. However, hospitals and other emergency services remained functional.



OM SHANTI
IN LOVING MEMORY OF

Shri Ved Prakash Gupta
5 JULY 1948 – 30 JULY 2026

WITH PROFOUND SORROW, WE SHARE THE PASSING OF OUR BELOVED FATHER, SHRI VED PRAKASH GUPTA, WHOSE GENEROSITY AND JOYOUS SPIRIT TOUCHED ALL WHO KNEW HIM. AFTER A SHORT ILLNESS, HE COMPLETED HIS EARTHLY JOURNEY ON 30 JULY 2026 AND ENTERED THE DIVINE PRESENCE OF THE ALMIGHTY.

The gathering remains, but without your light,
Your music lives on, outlasting the night,
And you live on within it, beyond mortal sight.

GRIEVING FAMILY:

Krishna Gupta (Wife)
Vipul Ved Prakash (Son)
Vrinda Gupta (Daughter)
Abhishek Gupta (Son-in-law)

Chhota Rajan gets jail term in passport fraud case

R. Sivaraman
CHENNAI

A special Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) court in Chennai on Thursday sentenced notorious underworld don Chhota Rajan to seven years of rigorous imprisonment, and imposed a fine of ₹55,000, after convicting him in a passport fraud case.

The court found Rajan guilty of cheating, forgery, impersonation, and knowingly submitting forged documents to obtain an Indian passport. Rajan is currently lodged in Tihar Jail, New Delhi, where he is serving a life sentence in another case.

Forged documents

The case was registered on March 19, 2002 following allegations that Rajan had fraudulently obtained a passport from the Regional Passport Office in Chennai using forged documents, according to the CBI.

The investigation revealed that Rajan had applied for a passport in the name of 'Vijaya Kadam' by submitting forged documents, including a school transfer certificate, ration card, and demand draft. The probe established that the applicant was actually Rajendra alias Nana alias Chhota Rajan, a native of Mumbai.

The CBI said Rajan impersonated Vijaya Kadam and fraudulently obtained the passport by submitting forged documents as proof of age and residence before using the passport as a genuine document.

Kerala's UDF backs PM-SHRI citing need for federal funds

Government in power cannot undo some decisions of its predecessors due to fiscal commitments, UDF convener says, adding that govt. could ill afford to lose Central funding for school education

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The ruling United Democratic Front (UDF) on Thursday revised its vehement opposition to the allegedly pro-Hindutva New Education Policy (NEP)-linked Pradhan Mantri Schools for Rising India (PM SHRI), citing Kerala's "desperate need" for federal funding for school education.

UDF convener Adoor Prakash told a press conference that the Congress-led government could ill-afford to lose the significant Central funding, which has remained in limbo since the previous Communist Party of India (Marxist) [CPI(M)]-led government signed an MoU with the Central government, somewhat "furtively", and allegedly without "consultations" in the Left Democratic Front (LDF) or the Cabinet.

UDF convener Adoor Prakash says that LDF's opposition to the saffronisation of education intends to mislead the public. FILE PHOTO

He denied that the UDF had executed a political U-turn after accusing the CPI (M) of having a covert, mutually symbiotic understanding with the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)-led Central government, and that the LDF's vocal opposition to saffronisation of education was merely to mislead the public.

Mr. Prakash said a government in power could not undo some decisions taken by its predecessors because of the fiscal commitments involved.

He attempted to lay the blame on the CPI(M) for creating the political quagmire for the UDF government. He said the CPI(M) had clandestinely dispatched the then General Education Secretary to the Centre to sign the PM SHRI agreement, without broad-based consultations.

He said CPI(M) walked the extra mile to keep the politically touchy decision secret from the UDF, then in the Opposition, given its potential impact in the run-up to the 2026 polls.

Expansion of Karnataka Cabinet likely by August 3

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

The expansion of the Karnataka Cabinet has been put off further and is now likely by August 3, with the Congress high command expected to finalise the list of new Ministers by August 2 after more rounds of consultations in New Delhi.

The exercise of drawing up a list, on for three consecutive days, has been held up over differences within the party leadership According to party sources, discussions among Congress leaders Mallikarjun Kharge, Rahul Gandhi, K.C. Venugopal, Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar and former Chief Minister Siddaramaiah centred on ensuring regional, caste, community and gender balance.

West Bengal BJP chief writes to CM, seeks chemicals hub in Singur

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

Seeking to restore Singur on the industrial map of West Bengal, Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) State president Samik Bhattacharya has written a letter to Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari to set up a chemicals hub in Singur.

Referring to the BHAVYA Rasayan scheme, a ₹3,030-crore Central initiative to establish three dedicated chemicals hub across the country, Mr. Bhattacharya said it was a rare opportunity for the State to anchor a national-scale chemicals hub.

"Some sites that merit consideration owing to their historical and logistical compatibility with the project are Singur, Haldia, Raghunathpur, and Durgapur. Other than these, I urge the government to assess and select any other site which it deems fit for this project," the BJP Rajya Sabha MP said.

Singur has been synonymous with the "failed promise" of industrialisation in West Bengal, particularly after Tata Motors decided to move out its proposed small car factory in 2008 due to protest against forcible land acquisition led by Trinamool Congress (TMC) chairperson and former Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee.

After the BJP came to power in the State, the government is trying to put the State on industrial map of the country. Mr. Adhikari has said that since the land at Singur was re-

Bengal BJP president Samik Bhattacharya. FILE PHOTO

turned to farmers by the previous TMC regime, it has to be acquired again for setting up industry. The 997 acres of land was officially ordered to be returned to the farmers in 2016 by the Supreme Court. Farmers have found the land on which a factory shed was constructed difficult to till and grow crops on.

Mr. Bhattacharya said an estimated ₹1,500 crore or more should be invested in infrastructure development by the Centre and the State.

'Direct employment'

"There will be direct employment across construction, plant operations, logistics, and ancillary MSMEs, with strong multiplier effects for downstream sectors such as agriculture, textiles, pharmaceuticals, automobiles, and electronics," he said. Over the past few weeks, along with the Chief Minister, the BJP president was seen at events where industrial houses have promised investment in the State.

Kerala CM cleared in foreign fund case

G. Anand
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The government on Thursday dropped long-pending corruption charges against Kerala Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan, concerning the marshalling of foreign funds for rehabilitating flood victims in his constituency in Paravur, Ernakulam, when he was the Leader of the Opposition in 2019.

Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala told reporters that the previous Left Democratic Front (LDF) government's case against Mr. Satheesan was "politically motivated."

He said the Vigilance and Anti-Corruption Bureau (VACB) found no legal grounds to prosecute Mr. Satheesan. He said back-to-back inquiries by two VACB directors had "revealed no Vigilance angle" in the case.

The previous LDF government had ordered an anti-corruption inquiry predicated on Mr. Satheesan's 2019 visit to the United Kingdom at the behest of an Ernakulam-based charitable foundation, to raise funds for rebuilding flood-damaged houses and distributing sewing machines to displaced families in Paravur.

Mr. Chennithala, quoting the latest VACB report, said Mr. Satheesan had no role in the handling and disbursal of the funds that financed the Punarjani Project. The charitable society, which he identified as Manappat Foundation, a registered entity under the Foreign Contribution Regulation Act (FCRA), had transacted through legal banking channels, with the transactions audited and reflected in the non-profit organisation's financial records. "Moreover, Mr. Satheesan did not handle the funds or interfere in their utilisation at any point in time", he said.

Meanwhile, CPI(M) State secretary M.V. Govindan alleged on Thursday that Mr. Satheesan did not seek the permission of the Assembly Secretariat or the Centre to "travel to England for fund collection from foreign individuals and entities."

Judicial officer pulled up for adjudicating personal case

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

The High Court of Karnataka has censured judicial officer Gayathri for acting as "a judge in her own cause" by adjudicating the proceedings on a criminal case initiated against three persons on her personal complaint to the jurisdictional police related to a road rage incident in Kolar.

INBRIEF

Efforts on to trace tiger after it kills cattle in A.P. district

Tension mounted in the forests of the Kannapuram range in the Eluru district of Andhra Pradesh after a tiger killed two cows in the early hours of Thursday. Forest officials sounded an alert in the Koyyalagudem and Buttaigudem forests and began tracking the animal. "The tiger killed the two cows in the forests near Mangapathidevipeta village in Koyyalagudem. An alert has been sounded in the range," said the Kannapuram Forest Range Officer V. Bhanu Prakash. "We arranged CCTVs and are using drones to trace the tiger," he said.

CBI files chargesheet against 6 accused in LIFE Mission case

The CBI has submitted the preliminary chargesheet in the Wadakkanchery LIFE Mission corruption case at the Chief Judicial Magistrate Court earlier this month. It named six persons who were accused of financial irregularities in the project. Santhosh Eappen, managing partner of Unitac Builders, has been arraigned as the first accused, followed by his construction firm Sane Ventures, and the LIFE Mission project. Former UAE consulate employees Sandeep Nair, P.S. Sarith, and Swapna Suresh, are the fourth, fifth, and sixth accused respectively.

TDB to stop buying ghee from outside for Sabarimala temple

The Travancore Devaswom Board (TDB) has decided to stop the procurement of ghee from outside for the Sabarimala temple. TDB Commissioner K. Jayakumar said the decision had no connection with the ongoing controversy over Milma ghee procurement at the temple. The TDB will instead use the ghee donated by the devotees. "We had taken the decision two weeks ago when we prepared the indent for the items needed for the year, we decided not to purchase ghee from outside," he said.

Preparing to sail

Blue tapestry: Fishermen repair fishing nets at Kollam's Sakthikulangara Harbour in Kerala on Thursday ahead of the lifting of the trawling ban at midnight on Friday. C. SURESHKUMAR

Kerala is considering withdrawal of NEET protest cases: Minister

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Kerala's Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala has said the government is examining the possibility of withdrawing the cases registered during the Statewide protests held in solidarity with demonstrations in New Delhi over the alleged NEET examination paper leak.

Leader of the Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan recently wrote to Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan, seeking the withdrawal of the nearly 5,000 cases registered in connection with the demonstrations.

"I have forwarded the matter to the State Police Chief (SPC). The government has no interest in continuing such cases," he told mediapersons on Thursday.

Mr. Chennithala, however, indicated any cases involving offences of serious criminal nature, may not be withdrawn. The SPC has been asked to examine the cases and submit a report, he said.

Regarding the custodial death of Siyad, a bus driver in Kundara, allegedly due to custodial torture, Mr. Chennithala said a police officer had already been suspended over allegations that he assaulted the deceased.

YSRCP accuses govt. of imposing curbs on party chief's tours

The Hindu Bureau
VIJAYAWADA

The YSR Congress Party (YSRCP) on Thursday alleged that the Andhra Pradesh government was imposing stringent restrictions on the tours of party president and former Chief Minister Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy, claiming that the ruling alliance was "concerned about his increasing popularity among the public".

Addressing the media, YSRCP spokespersons Putha Siva Shankar, Are Shyamala and Mancha Nagamalliswari accused the government of using police restrictions, advance notices and house arrests to prevent party leaders and workers from participating in Mr. Jagan's programmes.

The leaders alleged that the authorities had limited Mr. Jagan's convoy to eight vehicles and issued notices to the YSRCP leaders ahead of his proposed visit to Srikakulam to meet former Minister Seediri Appalaraju in jail. They claimed that Mr. Appalaraju had been arrested in what they described as a fabricated case

They pointed out that when Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu was the Leader of the Opposition, the previous YSRCP government had allowed him to travel freely despite political differences.

Researchers develop low-energy system to treat biopharmaceutical wastewater

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Researchers at BITS Pilani, Hyderabad on Thursday announced the development of a low-energy wastewater treatment technology that can disinfect biopharmaceutical wastewater while recovering reusable water and methane-rich biogas, offering a sustainable solution for one of the most challenging industrial effluents.

The technology, demonstrated at the laboratory scale, is being taken forward for industrial deployment in collaboration with Biological E. Ltd., a Hyderabad-based vaccine manufacturer. The project is supported by the Department of Science and Technology (DST) under its water technology initiative programme, and the core disinfection technology has been filed for an Indian patent, said an official release.

Sustainable solution: Researchers at BITS Pilani, Hyderabad, have developed an integrated three-stage treatment system.

Biopharmaceutical fermentation wastewater is considered difficult to treat because it contains large quantities of live production microorganisms, residual antibiotics and antibiotic resistance genes. Industries currently rely on chemical treatment and steam-based autoclaving to eliminate biosafety risks, a process that is both energy-intensive and costly.

To address these challenges, researchers developed an integrated three-stage treatment system that combines electrical disinfection, biological treatment and energy recovery.

Professor Sankar Ganesh Palani of the Department of Biological Sciences said the integrated approach demonstrates that complex industrial wastewater can be disinfected using electrical pulses while simultaneously recovering water and energy resources. The research team also consisted of Professor Mithun Mondal and research scholar Ravindra Dnyanaba Kulal.

Dr. B.R. AMBEDKAR UNIVERSITY DELHI

(Established by the Act of Legislative Assembly of National Capital Territory of Delhi)

Special Drive for Admissions 2026-27 for Postgraduate Programmes of Dr. B.R. Ambedkar University Delhi

Dr. B.R. Ambedkar University Delhi, a State University established by the Government of NCT of Delhi announces a special admission drive for select PG programmes in specific admission categories (details mention on website **https://aud.delhi.gov.in/**) under different Schools of Studies in Kashmere Gate, Karampura, Lodhi Road & Qutab Institutional Area Campuses for the academic session 2026-27.

Applications are invited from applicants who have appeared for programme-specific CUET papers who had not applied earlier for these programmes, as well as from applicants who have not appeared for the CUET, to fill the vacant seats. Admissions will be offered first to eligible CUET applicants. Non-CUET applicants will be considered only if vacancies remain, with merit determined on the basis of marks (or equivalent CGPA) obtained in the last qualifying examination.

Please refer to the university website for details of programme and categories and CUET-papers for this special drive.

*** University reserves the right to not offer admission in any category where seats have already been filled.**

Dated: 31.07.2026 **www.aud.delhi.gov.in** **Registrar**

DIP/Shabdarth/Classified/0160/26-27

Directorate of Higher Education, Govt. of NCT of Delhi

NOTICE INVITING TENDER (NIT)

PNIT No.: -10/TIDC/ENGG/PNIeT/2026-27 **Dated -27/07/2026,**

The Project Director, TIDCL, Agartala, Khejurbagan Tripura (W) on behalf of the "Tripura Industrial Development Corporation Ltd.' invites **online e-tender** for the following work:

Bid No.	Name of work	Completion period for the work
GD15/ IEs/1	Design, Engineering, Erection, Testing & Commissioning of the Solar Photovoltaic Power plants of Total Capacity 910 KW (Bodhjungnagar IE-5 units of 50 KW each & 10 units of 25KW each, R K Nagar IE-3 units of 50 KW each, 4 units of 25 KW each & 5 units of 10KW each, Dewanpassa IE-2 units of 25 KW each ; and 1 unit of 10KW each in Nagicherra, Dukli, Kumarghat, Dharmanagar, Dhajanagar and Sarasima IEs) in Tripura on Turnkey Basis and Operation and Maintenance of Solar PV Power Plant(s) for Five (05) years after Operational Acceptance of the Plant (PACKAGE: 15) **(PACKAGE: 15)**	Completion Date for the whole of the Works shall be **2,742 days** (915 days for construction + 1,827 days for Defects Liability Period and Maintenance Period (from the Start Date at Bodhjungnagar,R.K Nagar Dewanpassa, Nagicherra, Dukli Kumarghat, Dharmanagar, Dhajanagar, Sarsima Industrial Estates.

1. **Bid Fee for each package: Rs 10,000/-**
2. **Date of Pre-bid meeting: 3rd August 2026, Time- 3:00 PM**
3. **Last date & time for online Bidding: 20th August 2026 up to 3:00 PM**

Note: The bid forms and other details including online activities should be done in the e-procurement portal https://tripuratenders.gov.in/nicgep/app

Project Director (ADB)
TIDC Ltd.
Agartala, Tripura (W)

ICA/C/1393/26

NORTH EASTERN RAILWAY

E-Tender Notice: EL-MWS-GKP-2026-27-09

Dy. Chief Electrical Engineer, Mechanical Workshop, N.E. Railway, Gorakhpur for & behalf of President of India invites "OPEN" E-Tender through online (e-tendering) for the following work: **Tender No. & Description of Work:- EL-MWS-GKP-2026-27-09,** POH of 30 Nos. Main Pantry and 30 Nos. Mini Pantry in Mechanical Workshop, Gorakhpur. **Approx Value:-** Rs. 2,24,61,703.30/-, **E.M.D. Money:-** Rs. 4,49,200/-, **Cost of Tender document:-** 0.00, **Completion time/period from the date of issue of acceptance letter-** 24 Months, • E-tender online will be submitted up to 11:00 Hrs on dated 20.08.2026. • For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railway IREPS official website **www.ireps.gov.in.**

Dy. Chief Electrical Engineer (WS)
CPRO/Elect.-117 **Gorakhpur**

Do Not Smoke Bidi/Cigarette in train

THE HINDU

DISCLAIMER: Readers are requested to verify and make appropriate enquiries to satisfy themselves about the veracity of an advertisement before responding to any published in this newspaper. THG PUBLISHING PVT LTD., the Publisher & Owner of this newspaper, does not vouch for the authenticity of any advertisement or advertiser or for any of the advertiser's products and/or services. In no event can the Owner, Publisher, Printer, Editor, Director/s, Employees of this newspaper/company be held responsible/liable in any manner whatsoever for any claims and/or damages for advertisements in this newspaper.

CORRIGENDUM

In the Notification related to the appointment of Vice-Chancellor to S.V. Vedic University, Tirupati published in these columns on 30-07-2026, read the heading as "S.V. Vedic University, Tirupati instead of Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams, Tirupati and issued by the Executive Officer may be read as Registrar (I/c), S.V. Vedic University, Tirupati.

Registrar (I/c), S.V. Vedic University, Tirupati.

TTD-40021(31)/1/2026-PRO SEC(Adv.No.137) Date:30-07-2026

Annexure-"A"

HIMACHAL PRADESH PUBLIC WORKS DEPARTMENT

E-PROCUREMENT NOTICE
INVITATION FOR BID (IFB)

The Executive Engineer, (B&R) Division, HPPWD, Baijnath on behalf of Governor of Himachal Pradesh, invites the percentage rate bids in electronic tendering system from the eligible class of contractors/Firms registered with HP.PWD for the works as detailed in the table.

Sr. No.	Name of work	Estimated Cost Rs.	Starting Date for downloading (09:00 Hrs)	Earnest Money	Time limit	Deadline for submission End date (10.30 Hrs)	Cost of Tender Form.
1.	Construction of Govt. Degree College Building at Multhan Tehsil Multhan Distt. Kangra H.P. (SH: Construction of Main building including Water Supply and Sanitary installation, Septic tank and Rain water harvesting system)	3,77,47,788/-	01.08.2026	7,55,000/-	Two Years	11.08.2026	7000/-

The bidders are advised to note others details of tenders from the department Website **www.hptenders.gov.in**

Executive Engineer,
Baijnath Division, HPPWD Baijnath

HP / 2266/26-27

Ministry of Women & Child Development
Govt. of India
NOTICE

This is for the information of the general public that the nomination process for the Pradhan Mantri Rashtriya Bal Puraskar (PMRBP) commenced on **01.04.2026** through the National Awards Portal (**https://awards.gov.in**). The awards are conferred on children who have demonstrated exceptional achievements in the fields of Bravery, Social Service, Environment, Sports, Arts & Culture, and Science & Technology.

Any child who is an Indian citizen residing in India, is above 5 years of age and not exceeding 18 years of age (as on 31st July, 2026), is eligible for the awards.

Nominations, including self-nominations and recommendations by any citizen, shall be accepted only through the National Awards Portal.

The last date for submission of online nominations, which has been earlier fixed as **31.07.2026**, is now being extended to **15.08.2026**. For further details, please visit the National Awards Portal at **https://awards.gov.in.**

CBC 46101/11/0012/2627

OFFICE OF THE RESIDENT COMMISSIONER
GOVT. OF MADHYA PRADESH, MADHYA PRADESH BHAWAN

PLOT NO. 29 C-D, JESUS & MARY MARG, CHANAKYAPURI, NEW DELHI-110021
Phone No. 011-26772001, 2002

Dated: 28/07/2026

CORRIGENDUM-II

The NIT for **"Hiring Agencies for Taxi Services"** for MP Bhawan & Madhyanchal, New 110021 against NIT No. 13/Hiring Taxi Services/MPB/2026 dated 06.07.2026 few Delhi modifications/ ammendments made as follow:

1. **"Minimum Amount"** mentioned in Column 1st of the 5th Row in Section-11 now to be read as **"Base Amount"**
2. **"1% of approved full day rate for per KM+Rs. 250 for Night Halt Charges"** mentioned in last Column of last Row in Section-11 now to be read as **"1% of approved full day rate for per KM+Rs. 400 for Night Halt Charges"**
3. **"For extra per Hrs. 5% of approved full day rate"** mentioned in Section-11 (Note-2) now to be read as **"For extra per Hrs. -10% of approved full day rate"**
4. **"The average annual turnover of the firm from transport services/hiring of taxi should not be less than Rs. 6.00 Crores in any three financial years of the last 4 financial years i.e. 2022-23, 2023-24, 2024-25 and 2025-26 (provisional) duly certified by Chartered Accountant"** mentioned in Section-7 Clause 7.2.5 now to be read as: **"The minimum value of average annual turnover of the firm from transport services/hiring of taxi in any three financial years of the last 4 financial years i.e. 2022-23, 2023-24, 2024-25 and 2025-26 (provisional) should be duly certified by Chartered Accountant be as mentioned below: -**

S. N.	Category	Description	Annual Estimated Amount	Average Annual Turnover
	1	2	3	4
1	Category-1 (Premium SUV)	Should have minimum 03 vehicles (Fortuner)	Rs. 6,00,000/-	Rs. 18,00,000/-
2	Category-2 (Premium SUV)	Should have minimum 12 vehicles (Innova Crysta/Innova Hycross/ Maruti Invicto)	Rs. 80,00,000/-	Rs. 2,40,00,000/-
3	Category-3 (MUV)	Should have minimum 07 vehicles (KIA Carens/ Ertiga/ Marazzo/ Rumion)	Rs. 40,00,000/-	Rs. 1,20,00,000/-
4	Category-4 (Premium Sedan)	Should have minimum 10 vehicles (Ciaz, Honda City and Verna)	Rs. 60,00,000/-	Rs. 1,80,00,000/-
5	Category-5 (Sedan)	Should have minimum 05 vehicles (Swift Dzire, Xcent, Honda Amaze, Etios)	Rs. 14,00,000/-	Rs. 42,00,000/-

If a bidder wishes to apply in more than one category of vehicles, then the bidder's average annual turnover should be the sum of average annual turnovers of respective vehicle categories. For example, if a bidder wishes to bid for categories 1, 2 & 5 then the average annual turnover should be Rs. 3.00 crore (Rs. 0.18 cr.+2.40 cr.+0.42 cr.). Similarly if a bidder wishes to bid for all the five categories, then the average annual turnover should be Rs. 6.00 crore". Others terms & conditions will remain same.

Addl. Resident Commissioner
M.P. Bhawan, New Delhi

G16467/26

GOVERNMENT OF PUNJAB
PUNJAB WATER SUPPLY & SEWERAGE BOARD

BID NO. ETENDER/EE/PWSSD/ROPAR/35/2026/Date: 30.07.2026

Executive Engineer, Pb. W/S & Sew., Divn, Ropar on the behalf of Chief Executive Officer, Pb. W/S and Sew. Board Chandigarh invites online bids for the following:-

Sr. No.	Items	Amount / Time Limit
1	Fabrication, Manufacturing, Testing, Supplying, and Commissioning of 13 Nos. of Desludging vehicles (3 Nos. of 3000 Ltr & 10 No of 6000 Ltr. Capacity) to be mounted on GVW Truck Chassis of required capacity, reputed make Drive P.T.O., Vaccum Pump PN 84 as per ISI Specifications for various town of Patiala Circle / Ludhiana Circle per DNIT Complete in all respect. (Under SBM 2.0)	As per DNIT

Closing date & Time : 17.08.2026 upto 03.00 P.M.
Opening date & Time : 18.08.2026 upto 01.00 P.M.
Prebid Meeting Date : 10.08.2026 at 09.00 A.M.

For detailed log onto https://eproc.punjab.gov.in

Note: Any Corrigendum(s), to the Tender / RFP Notice shall be published on the above website only.

Executive Engineer,
Pb. W/S & Sew. Divn.,
Ropar

1796/12/2026-27/13822

INVITATION FOR BIDS (IFB)

The Executive Engineer, B&R Division, HPPWD **Sangrah**, District **Sirmaur**, H.P. on behalf of Governor of Himachal Pradesh invites the **percentage rates bids**, in electronic tendering system from the eligible class of Contractors registered with HPPWD for the works detailed in the table.

Sr. No	Name of Work	Estimated Cost (₹)	Starting Date for Downloading Bid	Earnest Money (₹)	Deadline for Submission of Bid
1	2	3	4	5	6
1.	Upgradation of Birla to Tirmali Road Km. 2/00 to 4/00 (SH:- C/O Earth Work, Protection work, Cross Drainage work, V-Shape Drain, Metaling & Tarring, Road Safety Works in Km. 2/000 to 4/000)	20327330/-	30.07.2026	408798/-	07.08.2026

Bidders are advised to submit their bids as per instructions issued by the Engineer-in-Chief, HPPWD Shimla vide his office letter No. PW/CTR/32-20/Genl. Inst. CPWD/2020-19111-210 dated 25.10.2021 **and even file letter No. 37996-38095 dated 13.03.2023** in compliance of the Principal Secretary (PW) to the Government of Himachal Pradesh guidelines dated 07.10.2021 in continuation to notification issued by the Additional Chief Secretary (PW) to the Govt. of HP vide notification No. PBW(B)A(3)1/2020 dated 22.7.2020. Tenders are called on percentage rates as per directions of the Chief Engineer (SZ), HPPWD Shimla conveyed vide letter No. PW-CTR-29-Misc/2023-36299-329 dated 16.02.2023.The bidders are advised to note other details of tenders from the department website www.hptenders.gov.in.

Executive Engineer,
HPPWD (B &R) Division Sangrah.
Tel/Fax: 01702-248207
E-mail: ee-san-hp@nic.in

HP/2259/26-27 **him suchana avam jan sampark** **On behalf of Governor of Himachal Pradesh**

TAMILNADU INDUSTRIAL DEVELOPMENT CORPORATION LIMITED (TIDCO)

CIN-U65993TN1965SGC005327

E-Tender Notice No. TCA/Fintech/2026/05 dated 31.07.2026
E- Tender cum E- Forward Auction

TIDCO invites bids from eligible firms through e-Tender cum e- Forward Auction for selection of a Lessee to grant Long Leasing rights for 99 years of the following Developed Vacant Plot at Fintech City Nandambakkam, Chennai

S.No	Plot No	Plot Area (Acre)
1.	S12	2.37
2.	S13	2.66
3.	S15	2.13

Interested Bidders can download the tender document from https://tidco.com and https://tntenders.gov.in at free of cost.

The Scheduled for bidding process is as follows:-

1. Pre-bid meeting will be held on **14.08.2026** at **3:00 P.M** at TIDCO Office/online VC.
2. Last date and time for submission of Proposals/ Bids is on or before **31.08.2026** at **3.00 P.M** through https://tntenders.gov.in.
3. Opening of Technical Proposals / Bids on **31.08.2026** at **4.00 P.M** at TIDCO Office.
4. Any subsequent notification on the tender would be published on the above website.

CHAIRMAN AND MANAGING DIRECTOR
Tamilnadu Industrial Development Corporation Limited
19-A, Rukmini Lakshmipathy Road,
Egmore, Chennai – 600 008.
E- mail: cmd@tidco.com, it@tidco.com
Phone: +91 44 28554479
Website: https://tidco.com

DIPR/ 2409 /Tender/2026

ENTERPRISE CONNECT

A Business Initiative

KENT Launches 'Sapphire IoT' – An IoT-Enabled RO Water Purifier with Intelligent Monitoring and App-Based Control

KENT RO Systems has announced the launch of its latest innovation, the KENT Sapphire IoT, an advanced RO water purifier designed to deliver 100% pure, mineral-rich drinking water for modern Indian households. Blending advanced purification with smart connectivity, the KENT Sapphire IoT introduces nextgeneration IoT intelligence, offering users complete control and visibility over their water purification system. The purifier enables real-time display of water quality and filter life, along with automatic service call registration in case of any fault and timely notifications for filter and membrane replacement. Additionally, users can access a complete service and parts replacement history, ensuring a seamless and hassle-free ownership experience. Enhancing user convenience further is its advanced digital display, which provides real-time visibility of water purity, mineral content, and filter life. This intuitive interface allows consumers to stay informed about the purifier's performance at all times, ensuring greater transparency and confidence in the quality of drinking water. At its core, the purifier is powered by a multi-stage purification system (RO + UV + UF + TDS Control + Alkaline + Active Copper) that effectively removes harmful impurities such as arsenic, fluoride, rust, and pesticides, while eliminating bacteria and viruses and retaining essential natural minerals. A key highlight of the KENT Sapphire IoT is its ability to deliver alkaline water (pH 8.0+) infused with the goodness of copper and also features UV LED disinfection in the storage tank, ensuring that purified water remains safe over time. Designed for performance, the purifier offers a high purification capacity of up to 20 litres per hour.

REC DECLARES 1ST INTERIM DIVIDEND OF ₹4.25 PER SHARE FOR FY 2026-27 : PAT up by 23% from last quarter

The Board of Directors of REC Limited, on 24 July'26 approved the standalone and consolidated financial results for the quarter ended June 30, 2026. Despite a dynamic operating environment, REC sustained a healthy NIM of 3.34%, reflecting the strength of its lending portfolio and disciplined financial management. Consequently, the Company delivered an annualised EPS of ₹63.04 per share for the quarter ended June 30, 2026, underscoring its robust earnings performance. REC's standalone loan book stood at ₹5.90 lakh crore as on June 30, 2026 which is the largest for any CPSU-NBFC in India, demonstrating the strength and stability of its lending operation. Aided by growth in profits, the Net Worth has grown by 15% on Y-o-Y basis to ₹91,836 crore as on June 30, 2026. The renewable energy portfolio continued to witness robust traction, growing to ₹78,596 crore, constituting 13.32% of the overall loan composition. The infrastructure and logistic portfolio has grown to ₹59,289 crore, which is over 10% of the overall loan assets, the Board of Directors of the Company has declared the First Interim Dividend of ₹4.25 per equity share (face value ₹10 each).

Jagrani Hospital Lucknow, holds cancer awareness drive, honours survivors

Jagrani Hospital, in association with CORE ONCO, organised an awareness programme on World Head and Neck Cancer Day in Lucknow on Monday, emphasising early diagnosis and timely treatment while felicitating cancer survivors. Managing Director Dr. Praveen Chandravanshi said the hospital offers free cancer consultations and facilitates treatment under government healthcare schemes. Senior cancer surgeon Dr. S.K. Singh highlighted the importance of early detection, while oral cancer surgeon Dr. Akash Rajput urged people to avoid tobacco. Chief Dietitian Dr. Ritu Singh spoke on the role of nutrition in cancer care. Dr. Amitabh Gaurav, Director (Medical Administration), thanked the participants and reaffirmed the hospital's commitment to promoting cancer awareness and early screening. Cancer survivors shared their experiences and were honoured for their courage and resilience.

Galgotias University Hosts Japanese Delegation to Explore Academic and Research Collaborations Amid Growing Ties Between India and Japan

Galgotias University welcomed a high-level delegation of government officials, industry leaders and academic experts from Japan, along with representatives of the Governments of India and Uttar Pradesh, for discussions on academic and research collaboration. The talks prioritised three technologies central to the global sustainability agenda, Green Hydrogen, Electric Vehicles and Semiconductors, while keeping the door open to partnerships across a much wider range of disciplines.Galgotias University welcomes the Japanese delegation to advance India-Japan collaboration in green hydrogen, EVs, semiconductors and academic research. Speaking on the visit, Dr. Dhruv Galgotia, CEO, Galgotias University, said, "Hosting such a high-level delegation on our campus is a proud moment for the University. It also demonstrates the growing importance of Greater Noida as a critical academic, industrial and transportation hub. We intend to convert these discussions into joint research projects, exchange programmes and industry partnerships that our students and faculty can participate in directly."

3,821 Students Awarded Degrees at KIET University Annual Convocation 2026

KIET Deemed to be University conferred degrees upon 3,821 graduating students of the 2025 and 2026 batches of Dr. A.P.J. Abdul Kalam Technical University (AKTU), Lucknow, during its Annual Convocation 2026 held on 25 July'26 at the university campus. The ceremony began with the academic procession, followed by AKTU Kulgeet and formal welcome of the dignitaries by Dr. Adesh Kumar Pandey, Director Academics, KIET University. The Convocation was graced by Shri Atul Garg, Chancellor, KIET University and Member of Parliament from Ghaziabad; Prof. Nagaraj Ramrao, Vice Chancellor, KIET University; Dr. Manoj Goel, Pro Vice Chancellor, KIET University; and Prof. Virendra Pathak, Director, Institute of Engineering and Technology (IET), Lucknow, who attended the ceremony as the representative of the Vice Chancellor of AKTU. Members of the Governing Board of KIET Group of Institutions, including Shri Sunil P. Gupta, Shri G.D. Jain, Shri A.N. Gupta, Shri Neeraj Chaudhary, and Shri Rakesh Goel, were also present on the occasion.

HUDCO Sustains Exceptional Growth Momentum with Record Q1 FY2026–27 Performance

Housing and Urban Development Corporation Limited has continued its strong growth trajectory in the first quarter of FY 2026–27. The Board of Directors of HUDCO, at its meeting held on 27th July 2026, approved the financial results for the quarter ended 30th June 2026. Highlights of Financial Results for Q1 FY2026–27 (YoY): Loan Sanctions registered a remarkable growth of 91%, increasing to ₹65,485 crore from ₹34,224 crore in Q1 FY2025–26. Highest-ever quarterly Loan Disbursements stood at ₹16,377 crore, registering a growth of 28% over ₹12,812 crore in the corresponding quarter of the previous year. Profit After Tax (PAT) increased by 35.05% YoY to ₹851.11 crore from ₹630.23 crore. Commenting on the results, Shri Sanjay Kulshrestha, Chairman & Managing Director, HUDCO, stated that the company has commenced FY 2026–27 with exceptional financial and operational performance, reflecting the strength of its diversified lending portfolio, prudent financial management and sustained focus on infrastructure financing. He noted that the record growth in loan sanctions and highest-ever quarterly disbursements reaffirm HUDCO's pivotal role in financing India's urban infrastructure development while maintaining industry-leading asset quality.

कार्यालय परियोजना प्रबंधक, यूनिट–18
कन्सट्रक्शन एण्ड डिजाइन सर्विसेज
उत्तर प्रदेश जल निगम (नगरीय)
(उ0प्र0 सरकार का उपक्रम)
मकान सं.–7बी/108, बौद्ध विहार मझोला योजना सं.–4, भाग–2 (निकट संविधान साहित्य वाटिका, चन्द्रशेखर आजाद पार्क के सामने), दिल्ली रोड, मुरादाबाद–244103
E-mail: pm18mbd@gmail.com

पत्रांक– 2071/एम-18 / 597
दिनांकः 29.07.2026

अल्पकालीन ई–निविदा सूचना

उत्तर प्रदेश जल निगम (नगरीय), की ओर से अधोहस्ताक्षरी द्वारा **Construction of Govt. Inter College Ashok nagar, Bilaspur Rampur (Library room)** अनुमानित लागत ₹ 14.25 लाख, हेतु दिनांक 13.08.2026 की अपरान्ह 16:30 बजे तक ई-निविदाएं आमन्त्रित की जाती हैं। उक्त कार्य हेतु ई-निविदा प्रपत्र दिनांक 31.07.2026 से दिनांक 13.08.2026 के मध्य उत्तर प्रदेश सरकार की **e-procurement** की वेबसाइट **https:// etender.up.nic.in** से डाउनलोड किये जा सकते हैं तथा ई-निविदा दिनांक 14.08.2026 को अपराह्न 13:30 बजे कार्यालय परियोजना प्रबन्धक, यूनिट–18, सी. एण्ड डी.एस., उ.प्र. जल निगम (नगरीय), मुरादाबाद में खोली जायेंगी। ई-निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य **₹ 2,000.00+GST (18%)** अतिरिक्त देय होगा। निविदा की किसी भी शर्तों को परिवर्तित करने तथा निविदा को बिना कोई कारण बताये अस्वीकृत करने का अधिकार विभाग के पास सुरक्षित रहेगा।

निविदा से सम्बन्धित विस्तृत विवरण विभाग की वेबसाइट **www.cdsupjn.org** एवं प्रोक्योरमेन्ट पोर्टल **https://etender.up.nic.in** पर उपलब्ध है। समस्त शुद्धि पत्र **(Corrigendum) https://etender.up.nic.in** पर ही अपलोड किये जायेंगे, **इनका पृथक से कोई प्रकाशन नहीं किया जायेगा।** निविदादाताओं को सलाह दी जाती है कि वे उक्त वेबसाईट का समय- समय पर अवलोकन करते रहें।

कार्यालय परियोजना प्रबंधक, यूनिट–18
कन्सट्रक्शन एण्ड डिजाइन सर्विसेज
उत्तर प्रदेश जल निगम (नगरीय)
(उ0प्र0 सरकार का उपक्रम)
मकान सं.–7बी/108, बौद्ध विहार मझोला योजना सं.–4, भाग–2 (निकट संविधान साहित्य वाटिका, चन्द्रशेखर आजाद पार्क के सामने), दिल्ली रोड, मुरादाबाद–244103
E-mail: pm18mbd@gmail.com

पत्रांक– 2069/एम-18 / 595
दिनांकः 29.07.2026

अल्पकालीन ई–निविदा सूचना

उत्तर प्रदेश जल निगम (नगरीय), की ओर से अधोहस्ताक्षरी द्वारा **Construction of Govt. Inter College Paharigate Rampur (Library room)** अनुमानित लागत ₹ 14.25 लाख, हेतु दिनांक 13.08.2026 की अपरान्ह 16:30 बजे तक ई-निविदाएं आमन्त्रित की जाती हैं। उक्त कार्य हेतु ई-निविदा प्रपत्र दिनांक 31.07.2026 से दिनांक 13.08.2026 के मध्य उत्तर प्रदेश सरकार की **e-procurement** की वेबसाइट **https:// etender.up.nic.in** से डाउनलोड किये जा सकते हैं तथा ई-निविदा दिनांक 14.08.2026 को अपराह्न 13:30 बजे कार्यालय परियोजना प्रबन्धक, यूनिट–18, सी. एण्ड डी.एस., उ.प्र. जल निगम (नगरीय), मुरादाबाद में खोली जायेंगी। ई-निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य **₹ 2,000.00+GST (18%)** अतिरिक्त देय होगा। निविदा की किसी भी शर्तों को परिवर्तित करने तथा निविदा को बिना कोई कारण बताये अस्वीकृत करने का अधिकार विभाग के पास सुरक्षित रहेगा।

निविदा से सम्बन्धित विस्तृत विवरण विभाग की वेबसाइट **www.cdsupjn.org** एवं प्रोक्योरमेन्ट पोर्टल **https://etender.up.nic.in** पर उपलब्ध है। समस्त शुद्धि पत्र **(Corrigendum) https://etender.up.nic.in** पर ही अपलोड किये जायेंगे, **इनका पृथक से कोई प्रकाशन नहीं किया जायेगा।** निविदादाताओं को सलाह दी जाती है कि वे उक्त वेबसाईट का समय- समय पर अवलोकन करते रहें।

OFFICE OF THE DIRECTOR TRANSPORT-CUM-CHIEF EXECUTIVE OFFICER, CHANDIGARH CITY BUS SERVICES SOCIETY, UNION TERRITORY, CHANDIGARH

No.SA/DC(F&A)/CCBSS/2026/261980 Dated : 30-07-2026

CORRIGENDUM / ADDENDUM

In continuation of this office e-tender notice vide letter No. **SA/DC(F&A)/CCBSS/2026/234314** dated 10.07.2026 and Tender ID **2026_CHD_93971_1**, the Chandigarh City Bus Services Society has invited e-tender (online tender) from the Manufacturer / Authorized Dealers / Distributors from SML ISUZU for the supply of spare parts of the SML Buses for the CCBSS, Chandigarh and appeared in the leading newspapers and also displayed on the website of this Chandigarh Transport Undertaking as well as website of Chandigarh Administration i.e. **chdctu.gov.in** and **http://chandigarh.gov.in, http://etenders.chd.nic.in/nicgep/app** respectively.

Due to certain administrative reasons, the date of submission of EMD, Technical & Financial has been extended from 31-07-2026 upto 14:00 hrs. to 07-08-2026 upto 14:00 hrs.

The other terms and conditions will remain same.

Deputy Controller (F&A)
for Director Transport-cum-CEO, CCBSS, Chandigarh.

THE HINDU GROUP

Your feedback will keep us Cleaner, Sharper and Bolder

Call our toll-free number **1800 102 1878**
Or write to us at **customercare@thehindu.co.in**

Scan the QR code to register your feedback

THE HINDU · thehindu businessline. · FRONTLINE · SPORTSTAR · The Hindu Young World · THE HINDU

CLASSIFIEDS MART

TO ADVERTISE VISIT
www.thehinduads.com
CALL: 011-43579797
or Contact your nearest Authorised space sellers

LEGAL NOTICE

BEFORE THE HON'BLE 89th ADDL. CITY CIVIL AND SESSIONS JUDGE (CCH-90) BENGALURU

Comm. A.A. No. 365 of 2024

IN THE MATTER OF

M/s. CATERPILLAR FINANCIAL SERVICES INDIA PVT. LTD., Ground Floor, Prestige Shantiniketan, Crescent 1, Whitefield Road Hoodi, Whitefield, Bengaluru, Bengaluru Urban, Karnataka-560048.

...CLAIMANT

AND : Mahadev Earth Movers & ANR

...RESPONDENTS

Service of Court Summons to Respondent No. 1 & 2 through Paper Publication

R1 : MAHADEV EARTH MOVERS & ANR (Prop. of Rohit Kumar Gahlod), 66, Gram Khoka, Post Binjihawada, Seoni, Madhya Pradesh - 480 661.

R2 : 2. ARCHANA GAHLOD, W/o. Rohit Gahlod, Gram Khoka, Post Binjihawada, Seoni, Madhya Pradesh - 480 661.

Whereas the Applicant has filed the above Application against you to provide adequate security to the Applicant Company equivalent to an amount of **Rs. 34,62,069/-** so as to cover the outstanding loan amount due to the Applicant Company. Take notice that the above case is posted for your appearance **on 05.09.2026.** If you have any defence, you are required to appear before the court either in person or through advocate, duly authorised on the aforesaid date of hearing, failing which the matter will be decided on merits placing you ex-parte.

SCHEDULE OF VEHICLE
A. SCHEDULE

Equipment : Caterpillar 320D3GC
Maker's Name : Caterpillar
Model No. : 320D3GC
Serial No. : FLD01028

Given under my hand and seal on this 16th day of July 2026 at Bangalore.

By order of the Court, Senior Sheristedar, Commercial Court Unit, City Civil Court, Bengaluru.

Advocate for Applicant :
#117, Ashwin Arcade, 3rd Floor, Sanjay Nagar Main Road, RMV II Stage, Ashwathnagar, Bangalore.

PERSONAL

CHANGE OF NAME

I, RAM Kanti Baghel w/o Indra Dev Baghel born on 01/07/1969 residing at 63–A 37/2 Kirti Nagar Defence Colony Agra, have changed my name to Ram Kanti vide affidavit dated 29/06/2026 at Agra.

I, PUNKESH kumar s/o Shiv kumar singh born on 16.03.1992 residing at S–7 50–B, Arjun Nagar, Safdarjung enclave, New delhi –110029, have changed my name to Punkesh kumar singh vide affidavit dated 29 July 2026 at New Delhi

PUBLIC NOTICE

PUBLIC NOTICE

This is to inform the public at large that my clients, **Shri Bijender Singh**, son of Late Shri Ram Kumar Singh, and his wife **Smt. Manju Devi**, both residing at A-731, DDA Colony, Khyala, New Delhi, have severed all family relations with their son **Vikramjeet Singh** and his wife **Smt. Niki**, both residing separately in Bengaluru.

Due to their hostile, errant, and quarrelsome behavior, my clients hereby disown and debar both Vikramjeet Singh and Smt. Niki from all their movable and immovable properties/assets.

My clients state that they shall not be held responsible for any acts, omissions, dealings, debts, or liabilities incurred by Vikramjeet Singh or his wife. Any person dealing with them shall do so entirely at their own risk and responsibility. My clients also reserve the right to initiate appropriate legal proceedings if any harm is caused to their life, property, or reputation through frivolous litigation or otherwise.

RAJESH KUMAR LUTHRA, Advocate
Off.: 5A/168, W.E.A Karol Bagh, New Delhi

SITUATION VACANT

GENERAL

CHENNAI PORT AUTHORITY
No.1, RAJAJI SALAI, CHENNAI – 600 001.

GENERAL ADMINISTRATION DEPARTMENT

VACANCY NOTICE

File No.RC2/2035/2023/GA
Dated: 31.07.2026

Chennai Port Authority, an autonomous body under the Government of India, Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways, invites applications for filling up of **3 (Three) vacancies in the post of Pilot (Class-I) (SC-1, ST-1 & OBC - 1) in Marine Department, in the scale of pay of Rs.70000 – 200000. Eligible candidates have to apply through "Online Application Portal" (OAP) of the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways** (**http://onlinevacancyshipmin.nic.in**).

For further details, visit Chennai Port Authority's Website viz., **www.chennaiport.gov.in.** Last date for receipt of applications is **11.09.2026.** Candidates already applied for the said posts in the Port's website should apply again.

Chennai – 600 001. **Secretary**

Members of the Sanyukt Pratiyogi Chhatra Hunkar Manch, a Prayagraj-based collective of government job aspirants, holding a meeting to discuss their demands for greater transparency and accountability in recruitment examinations. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

A generation in waiting

Millions of young government job aspirants in Uttar Pradesh, who hope for stability and upward social mobility, complain of recruitment delays resulting in them losing their prime years to waiting. **Mayank Kumar** finds brewing discontent with the youth of India's most populous State

Rishabh Tripathi (name changed to protect privacy), 27, is worried. He lives in an 80-square-foot rented room in a double-storey house in Ayodhya town, its walls chipped, the floor cracked, the roof leaking. He is contemplating his next steps.

Tripathi, an ambitious State-level 10m air pistol shooter, feels his dreams are dying a slow death. He has just been on the website of the Uttar Pradesh Subordinate Service Selection Commission (UPSSSC), and is disappointed. Again.

"Every day I check the website twice. It has been two months now. The final results of the Village Panchayat Officer (VPO, or Gram Panchayat Adhikari) post have still not been posted. I have been trying for a government job, but the prolonged delay in conducting the examination is adversely impacting my life, my dreams," says a frustrated Tripathi.

The son of a street vendor, who owns less than an acre of farmland, Tripathi has two dreams: to help the family in his elder sister's marriage and to take a loan for sports equipment and academy fees. "I dream of representing India in the 2028 Olympics. If the final result of the VPO is declared, I can take the loan. Shooting is an expensive sport; my family can't afford it," he says. Now, he makes ends meet by tutoring children in Ayodhya, managing to earn ₹4,000 a month.

Tripathi is among millions of young government job aspirants in Uttar Pradesh, most of who hope for the stability of an income and upward social mobility.

Many have a similar grievance: that the recruitment commission entrusted to conduct the examinations routinely delays the process, wasting young aspirants' prime years. They allege irregularities in the process. In the past, there have been Preliminary Eligibility Test (PET) paper leaks, besides those of other exams.

Waiting for Godot

The VPO is a Group C post, an administrative role to facilitate the implementation of government schemes, among other work.

The UPSSSC is authorised to recruit group C and D posts whenever the State Government puts out a notification for hiring. On May 16, 2023, up to 1,468 VPO posts were notified. Roughly 40 times the number of candidates were shortlisted, based on their PET scores.

The PET is a State-level qualifying exam managed by the UPSSSC. It features a 100-question, 100-mark, two-hour written test, with one-fourth negative marking.

Tripathi has a BSc degree from Dr. Ram Manohar Lohia Avadh University. He is upset that the commission has also not processed the results of a Junior Assistant post, another job he had applied for.

"I sat for the exam in June last year, the results were declared in October. The typing test was done in November and December, and the results were declared in February this year," he says, adding that even his documents were verified in May.

"But the final result is pending. This was for a job notified on August 4, 2023. These delays are frustrating, not just for me but also for other people my age. Our youth is getting wasted," Tripathi adds.

> There are multiple videos being circulated on social media platforms of organised cheating in the Lekhpal Mains examination [conducted on May 21 across 861 centres in 44 districts]
>
> **PANKAJ PANDEY,** Convenor of the Sanyukt Pratiyogi Chhatra Hunkar Manch

A deep-rooted crisis

Pankaj Pandey, convener of the Sanyukt Pratiyogi Chhatra Hunkar Manch, a Prayagraj-based outfit of competitive exam aspirants that holds its meetings in a field on the banks of the Ganga. For the last two months, he has been demanding a fair investigation into alleged irregularities in the Lekhpal examination conducted by the UPSSSC.

"There are multiple videos circulating on social media platforms of organised cheating in the Lekhpal Mains examination [conducted on May 21 across 861 centres in 44 districts]. We demanded that the Uttar Pradesh government appoint a high-level Special Investigation Team to probe the allegations, but this has not been accepted," says Pandey, a government job aspirant.

The government says that the allegations of paper leak are false. According to an official statement, the exam was "fair, uninterrupted and peaceful", conducted "with full transparency". Once the government got the news of a paper leak, "competent authorities immediately verified it, and the information was found to be completely misleading and false".

There were 7,994 posts, for which 3,01,756 sat for the exam, which means 37.75 people appeared for each post.

The aspirants are not satisfied. "We organised a protest march in Prayagraj, and held demonstrations for days outside the UPSSSC office. We submitted petitions to all concerned stakeholders," says Deepak Patel, a 24-year-old from Sherpur in Ghazipur district. He adds that most recruitment takes years to complete the process. "Comprehensive reforms in recruitment boards are the need of the hour to assuage the anxiety of aspirants," he says.

A graduate in Hindi Literature, Patel's parents work as agricultural labourers in their village and do not possess any ancestral land. "When they manage to find work, they earn ₹400. I wish to improve their circumstances. I studied hard for the Lekhpal exam, but the news of irregularities is making me anxious. For generations, my family lived in a state of inferiority; the government examination represents a chance for people like us to transform our lives," he says.

Millions like him are in Prayagraj, Uttar Pradesh's coaching hub. They feel let down by the system, he says.

Patel adds that on June 22, he joined the protest march of the Sanyukt Pratiyogi Chhatra Hunkar Manch, in support of the Jantar Mantar protests in New Delhi over NEET irregularities.

"We face similar problems, but no one is listening to us, perhaps because we are not in the national capital and are poor," adds Patel.

In their representation to the authorities, the Sanyukt Pratiyogi Chhatra Hunkar Manch called for the timely completion of pending and irregular recruitments. It also sought a robust system for Trained Graduate Teacher (TGT) and Post Graduate Teacher (PGT) recruitment, along with time-bound primary and junior teacher recruitment. The group also demanded transparency in recruitment commissions, including the UPPSC, regular dialogue with stakeholders, and comprehensive administrative reforms.

The struggle for a job

Resentment is not limited to the UPSSSC. The Uttar Pradesh Education Service Selection Commission (UPESSC), established in 2023, after the dissolution of the U.P. Higher Education Service Commission and the U.P. Secondary Education Service Selection Board, faces similar questions.

The Board is entrusted with the responsibility of teacher selection for various schools and colleges, some government-aided, some minority-funded. They too are facing questions over postponement of various recruitment and eligibility tests. The notification for TGT posts came in 2022, under the previous commission, and the exam was conducted in June, 2026.

Roughly 8.6 lakh aspirants filled the TGT form for 3,539 seats in government schools.

Anurag Singh, an aspirant based in Prayagraj, says a notification for the examination was released in early 2022, with the exam to be held that year. The exam didn't take place. The dates were fixed for April 2025, after aspirants protested the delay. This too kept getting postponed, until it was held in May this year. Results were declared on July 28. "It took four years to complete the process, with the dates getting pushed five times," says Anurag.

Prabhat Verma, who works as a teacher in a coaching centre for UPSSSC exams, says those who appear for the exams are usually from smaller cities or villages. They have struggled through school education with a lack of both quality teaching and infrastructure.

The most recent paper leak was in January, when the Uttar Pradesh government cancelled the Assistant Professor examination conducted in April 2025 after a paper leak and illegal extortion racket came to light.

Allegations of a government that doesn't care

Rajat Singh, who leads the DELED Morcha, a group of Diploma in Elementary Education holders (D.El.Ed), says that vacancies for primary-level teachers haven't been advertised for over five years. "Five years is a long time," he says.

"*Hamare jaise* D.El.Ed degree *vale khud ko mara hua samajh rahe hai* (Those like me with a D.El.Ed degree feel dead)," says Rajat. The DELED Morcha has approached the government to advertise for posts, but Rajat says the government has not responded: "They are silent. What is the need for such a degree if there are no appointments. Why give aspirants hope?" D.El.Ed is a two-year, full-time certificate course to train students to teach at levels of Classes 1 to 8.

Amid the questions, Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath said at an event in May that the government has created a record by providing over 9 lakh jobs since 2017.

He alleged that recruitment was stalled by corruption before his tenure. "We have recruited over 2.20 lakh police personnel. In 2025 alone, 60,242 candidates were selected and have completed training within Uttar Pradesh," he said. Critics allege that the high number of appointments in the police force reflects a broader agenda in Uttar Pradesh, which is lax with teacher hiring but prompt with police hiring.

"The government, under the BJP (Bharatiya Janata Party), is working on the doctrine of a hard State through a heavy-handed police force and the repression of dissent, as evident from the bulldozer-centric approach in law and order," said Shahnawaz Alam, national secretary, Congress. Alam says they need a police force that will obey orders.

"Such governments are against logic, fair justice, accountability, and reasoning which are key markers of a civilised society." He says the irregular recruitment system must be understood against this background.

Anil Yadav, a senior Uttar Pradesh Congress leader, demanded a white paper on time taken to complete the recruitment examination process under UPSSSC, UPESSC, and other recruitment boards in Uttar Pradesh. "The government must answer over 5 million young people," he says.

In December 2025, when Prashant Kumar took charge as chairperson of the UPESSC he said, "My top priority is to ensure that the selection process is completely transparent and merit-based."

mayank.kumar@thehindu.co.in

A government job aspirant studying in her room in Uttar Pradesh. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Notes from the past An artist's rendition of the central jetty and arrival hall; (below) architect Hafeez Contractor. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

A voyage into history

The upcoming National Maritime Heritage Complex in Lothal blends Harappan-inspired architecture, immersive galleries, and sustainable design

Nidhi Adlakha
nidhi.adlakha@thehindu.co.in

Museums in India have long been considered a pitstop on an otherwise packed holiday itinerary. This is now changing courtesy of architects and industry experts who are looking at inclusive and interactive designs. The upcoming National Maritime Heritage Complex (NMHC) in Lothal, Gujarat, is proof.

Spread across nearly 400 acres, it is currently among the 'largest museum developments under construction in India and one of the most ambitious maritime museum projects globally'.

A project helmed by the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways, and the Government of Gujarat, NMHC is being designed by architect Hafeez Contractor as an institution dedicated to India's maritime history and seafaring legacy.

Karl Wadia, senior principal architect, Architect Hafeez Contractor, says NMHC has been conceived as a multi-phase cultural and tourism development project. "It is designed as a multi-day visitor experience that combines heritage, recreation, education, hospitality, and public infrastructure," he says, adding that Lothal was chosen as the site given that it houses the world's earliest known man-made dockyard and remains one of the most important sites of the Indus Valley Civilisation.

The project's Phase I, which is currently underway, includes a large 14-gallery maritime museum, the recreated Lothal town, a lighthouse-inspired gallery tower, public plazas, waterfront promenades, and the landscaped Bhagicha complex. Future phases will introduce eco-resorts, museotels, themed amusement parks, and State-sponsored cultural pavilions.

Karl says that from the beginning, the team understood NMHC as both a heritage project and an "urban-scale intervention with the potential to shape tourism and future regional development around Lothal"

The architecture, he says, draws from Harappan planning principles. "The archaeological remains in Lothal reveal sophisticated dock systems, elevated citadels, reservoirs, drainage networks, and organised civic spaces designed to respond to flooding and trade activity. We wanted the architecture of NMHC to engage with those principles rather than simply imitate historical forms," he explains.

Water as muse

"Like with the historic maritime settlement, water becomes both an infrastructural and experiential element throughout the project," adds Karl, "Architecturally, the museum's elevated plinths reference the raised citadels of Harappan towns that protected communities from flooding. The

material palette of honed Jodhpur sandstone and its heavy-set tapered massing draws from the solidity and geometry of excavated Harappan structures."

At the centre of the museum, the team has recreated a living-history version of Lothal that visitors can inhabit physically. "The idea was to help people understand that the Indus Valley Civilisation was highly sophisticated, globally connected, and remarkably advanced in urban planning," he says.

"We wanted NMHC to move away from the idea of history as something static. The project has been designed as an immersive learning environment where visitors engage with maritime history," says Hafeez, who is also working on the redevelopment of Siri Fort in New Delhi, and the Daman Convention Centre in Dadra and Nagar Haveli and Daman and Diu.

Karl explains that one of the most important aspects of the design emerged through an extensive study of water movement across the region. "During the monsoon, nearly the entire site floods because it lies within the catchment basin of the Bhogavo River. Instead of resisting that condition, we began to see it as an opportunity. The project was therefore designed around a large-scale water management strategy capable of creating a self-sustaining annual water cycle for the campus," he says, adding that this intervention led to the development of an urban-scale rainwater storage system comprising a 17-acre northern lake and interconnected underground southern storage tanks integrated across the site.

Karl says the buildings incorporate multiple passive and low-energy environmental strategies, including insulated RCC wall systems, radiant cooling infrastructure, thermal water bodies, and solar integration to reduce operational energy demand. "Great museums evolve over decades, constantly adapting, expanding, and reshaping public understanding over time. That changes the architect's role entirely because the focus shifts from delivering a standalone building to creating a long-term civic and cultural ecosystem capable of sustaining public engagement across generations," concludes Karl.

Beyond the byline

Journalist Jigyasa Mishra transforms years of reporting on human trafficking into art

Shailaja Tripathi

A school bag stuffed with bricks. A mother's breast still leaking milk, days after she was forced to bury her new born. An old book burnt because a 12-year-old bonded labourer dared to read a poem.

These are stories journalist Jigyasa Mishra has reported over the past eight years while covering brick kilns, trafficking-prone villages, brothels, and remote settlements across India. Only this time, they do not appear as newspaper reports or magazine features. They have transformed into paintings, photographs, and immersive installations.

The Screaming Canvases, the ongoing show at Bikaner House, is journalism that has not ended with its date of publication.

The exhibition brings together 40 works: paintings, photographs, illustrations, and installations, drawn from Jigyasa's years of reporting on human trafficking, bonded labour, child labour, and sexual exploitation. Every work emerges from field visits, interviews, and lived experiences, turning reportage into visual testimony. "I don't believe in writing about an issue today and forgetting it tomorrow while chasing another story. Art allows me to continue telling those stories. It simplifies even the most complex issues while creating conversations around people who are often invisible," she says.

For the Lucknow-based independent journalist, painting was not a hobby discovered later in life. Her father, Jaishankar Mishra, is an artist and professor of Fine Arts, while her mother, Chandana, is a Madhubani artist. "I painted before I learnt to read and write," reveals Jigyasa.

Still, writing remained her primary tool for years. That changed while working on assignments for the People's Archive of Rural India (PARI), where the emphasis on visual storytelling encouraged her to sketch and illustrate alongside her reporting. Gradually, those illustrations evolved into independent works.

Among the most moving works is an installation featuring an ordinary school bag filled with bricks. It tells the story of a 12-year-old boy trafficked with his parents to a brick kiln. One day, he paused work to read a poem from an old book to his younger sister. The contractor beat him and burnt the book.

Another series of acrylic paintings focusses on women trafficked into brick kilns during pregnancy. Forced to carry bricks until childbirth, many had no access to medical care. One painting is based on a woman from Uttar Pradesh who escaped bonded labour in Rajasthan. When Jigyasa met her, she had lost her six-day-old baby and had been forced to bury the infant inside the brick kiln. She spoke of the constant pain of lactation that kept reminding her of the child she no longer held.

Jigyasa's art is not intended to shock. Instead, it invites viewers to pause and empathise with lives marked by interrupted childhoods, stolen motherhoods, denied education, and eroded dignity.

The Screaming Canvases will be on view at Bikaner House, Pandara Road, till August 2.

Stories on canvas Artist and journalist Jigyasa Mishra. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Pour decisions

As India's appetite for premium tequila grows, specialised agave bars are introducing drinkers to the wider world of mezcal, terroir and craftsmanship

Barry Rodgers
barry.nathaniel@thehindu.co.in

Is India ready for a bar built around a single spirit? According to the IWSR, India is among the world's fastest-growing markets for agave spirits. The category recorded 31% year-on-year volume growth and 40% value growth in 2024-25, while sales more than tripled in just four years. Driven by premiumisation and an increasingly sophisticated cocktail culture, tequila has evolved far beyond the sugary shots that once defined it.

Yet agave remains widely misunderstood. Tequila, made exclusively from Blue Weber agave, can only be produced in designated regions of Mexico under a geographical indication (GI). Mezcal, also protected by a denomination of origin, can be distilled from dozens of agave species across specific Mexican states and is often characterised by its smoky profile. Agave itself is the umbrella category – a family of more than 200 species from which tequila, mezcal and other spirits are distilled.

Today, the programme at Agave Lounge at the Ritz Carlton, Pune, is overseen by beverage manager Damian Goes. "I believe agave has the potential to become a sophisticated post-dinner drink, much like a fine whisky or cognac, as more consumers begin to appreciate its complexity and depth," he says.

Across India, a small but growing number of bars are moving beyond simply serving tequila to teaching drinkers about the wider world of agave. Among them is Quinta Cantina in Goa. Opened in September 2025 as a 35-seat space in Panjim by beverage expert Pankaj Balachandran and restaurateur Puru Agarrwal, Quinta was designed as an educational bar exploring the shared heritage of Goa's feni and Mexico's agave spirits. Everything was intended to move guests into

Spirited! At the Agave Room. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

conversations about provenance, terroir and craft. Through Quinta Caravan – a travelling series of masterclasses, tastings and guest shifts across four to five Indian cities, including Delhi, Mumbai, Kolkata and Bengaluru – Pankaj is taking the concept on the road.

Producers are beginning to see that interest translate into demand. Among the earliest movers is Maya Pistola Agavepura, launched in 2022 as Asia's first aged 100% agave spirit. Crafted from wild *Agave americana* grown on the Deccan Plateau, the brand has sought to establish a distinct identity for Indian agave rather than positioning itself as tequila. For founder Rakshay Dhariwal, the biggest shift is how Indians are drinking the spirit.

Consumers, he believes, are paying closer attention to provenance, production methods and authenticity, with premium 100% agave spirits steadily replacing mixto tequilas among discerning drinkers. Maya Pistola has also invested heavily in bartender training, blind tastings, blending workshops and its Secret Agave Club. The goal is to encourage consumers to see agave as a sipping spirit rather than simply a cocktail ingredient. The strategy appears to be paying off. Maya Pistola recorded 68% volume growth and 95% growth in net sales value in the last financial year, with Gurugram, Chandigarh and Goa emerging as its strongest markets. "Tier-I cities and five-star standalone venues are leading the charge," says Rakshay.

> ***People are no longer just asking what tequila they're drinking — they're asking which agave it comes from***
>
> **VIJAY PRAKASH**
> Co-founder, Agave Room

When Agave Room opened in New Delhi in 2024, it was conceived as a destination dedicated to agave spirits, built on the belief that tequila and mezcal deserve the same reverence long afforded to whisky, gin and wine. Co-founder Vijay Prakash says the ambition was never simply to open another cocktail bar.

"It was to redefine how people experience spirits. For years, Delhi's premium bar scene celebrated whisky, gin and fine dining, while tequila remained largely misunderstood, reduced to quick shots and predictable margaritas."

Rather than treating education like a lecture, Agave Room encourages discovery through conversation, guided tastings and carefully crafted cocktails. Says Vijay, "People are no longer just asking what tequila they're drinking – they're asking which agave it comes from, whether it's additive-free and how it differs from mezcal."

While tequila remains the best-known Latin American spirit, the growing availability of premium labels has encouraged bars to build entire programmes around the category rather than treating it as another bottle on the back bar.

Clearance in reverse

Top court nod for post facto approval must not be read as support for amnesty

India's environmental impact assessment (EIA) regime rests on a single sequencing rule: a project must be appraised before the pickaxe pierces the ground, not after the building is operational. The Supreme Court of India's July 29 order, from a Bench led by the Chief Justice of India, Surya Kant, on post facto clearances, reaffirms that rule even as it hollows it out. By quashing the 2021 Office Memorandum while leaving the door open for the Centre to legalise violations through a statutory notification, the Court's distinction between an administrative order and a notification, is effectively a fig-leaf – a procedural nicety dressed up as respect for environmental norms. The deeper problem that the judgment does not confront is the dissonance between the State-level appraisal machinery and the Centre's law. When State EIA authorities, expert committees and pollution boards routinely discover violations only after a highway, port or steel plant is built, post facto clearance stops being an exception and becomes the design. Large projects are now appraised as a *'fait accompli'*, their ecological cost weighed only once demolition would cost more than absolution. The Court reasons that governments may frame environmental amnesty schemes much as they do for tax defaults. But the logic that justifies regularising an unauthorised colony for electoral gain cannot be transposed onto works that carve into forests and floodplains. Environmental science exists as a discipline precisely to insist on interconnectedness – that plant, animal, human and microbial systems are bound together, and that damage to one propagates through all. A wetland is not an unregistered plot to be regularised on payment of a fee. Even the argument that these are hospitals and airports meant for public good cannot automatically justify the environmental cost.

Worryingly, that transactional logic now has legal cover. The existing retrospective clearances do exact a fine from those who bypassed the norms – but the Jan Vishwas amendments stripped away the threat of imprisonment for environmental lapses altogether, leaving only monetary penalties thus converting compliance into a 'cost of doing business' entry, which a well-capitalised proponent can budget for. The latest judgment does not examine this shift, but endorses its premise, treating environmental harm as a debt that can be settled after the fact. The Court insists that reducing violations to civil penalties does not weaken the precautionary principle. But a principle meant to prevent irreversible harm cannot be honoured by pricing the harm and collecting the cheque. The consequences are incidents of infrastructure projects getting flattened by serious monsoon activity. The Centre would be well advised to read this order not as a licence to multiply amnesty schemes, but as a mandate to repair the clearance apparatus.

Temporary respite

June's strong industrial performance is not a sign of things to come

The June 2026 data for the Index of Industrial Production has come as a pleasant surprise. The 23-month high growth rate of 7.3% of the overall index was unexpected given the significant economic headwinds from the West Asia crisis and a deficient monsoon. Some of the growth was due to a low base, since the performance last June was the worst in nearly a year, but the numbers nevertheless indicate resilience. The manufacturing sector accelerated due to a dual push from the domestic and the external sectors. Consumer durables growth remained above 7% for the second consecutive month, and the non-durables sector saw growth quicken to a six-month high. At the same time, data from the Commerce Ministry showed that merchandise exports grew 15.5% in June, revealing demand from abroad. The capital goods sector also saw double-digit growth. The sector has grown in double digits in eight out of the last 10 months. This bodes well for the economy, but also reveals some risks. Capital creation, primarily by the government, has been the single consistent engine of growth in the post-pandemic years. It needs to keep firing. There are too many uncertainties and headwinds for other engines such as exports and domestic consumption to consistently take up the load. Other areas of growth are also far too seasonal. The electricity sector grew at a 25-month high in June, largely in response to a heat wave in several parts of the country. The mining sector, too, snapped a four-month streak of contraction and grew in June. Yet, this will likely be temporary since the progressing monsoon will disrupt mining activities.

Economists have also warned that the monsoon's deficiency will inevitably hit rural demand in the months ahead, which will see the consumer-facing sectors slumping again. Hopes of a ceasefire in West Asia are also evaporating. This is leading to considerable volatility in oil prices, which is sending ripples of uncertainty through the economy. This will play out over the coming months. Planned investments will remain pending, purchases will be deferred, and savings will increasingly overshadow consumption. The economy has displayed resilience so far, but this resilience will be strained as its duration increases. Further, people's needs are such that simple resilience will not suffice for long. If the external environment is going to remain unfavourable, the government will need to think radically about how to jumpstart the domestic economy. In the meantime, it will have to keep pumping money into capital expenditure even as other fiscal pressures mount.

The next DPI — how India can commoditise AI

Srivatsa Krishna

IAS officer

India made identity, payments, and data free. Intelligence is next. No other country has deliberately built all three as a digital public infrastructure (DPI) stack at India's scale. Others have developed only pieces of this. Estonia has a world-class digital identity system, but nothing comparable to UPI. Brazil's Pix is an excellent free payments rail, but it stands alone. Singapore has Singpass and SGFinDex, while Europe has open banking and data portability. India's genuine claim to global leadership in public digital infrastructure lies in this unique combination. Its distinctiveness is not any single component, but the integration of Aadhaar, the Unified Payments Interface (UPI), and DEPA/Account Aggregator as interoperable public digital rails.

Between September 2016 and 2019, the cost of a gigabyte in India fell from about $4 to under 30 cents, making it among the cheapest in the world. The result was not a telecom story. It was a civilisational one: 500 million people came online in half a decade, powering India's digital economy such as payment volumes, the startup ecosystem, the direct-benefit transfers reaching the last village. Aadhaar enrolled 1.4 billion people and turned identity verification from an expensive paper process to a low-cost API call. UPI made digital payments effectively free, processing around 20 billion transactions a month at near-zero cost. India made data free not by subsidising it, but by letting one player absorb the fixed costs of a nationwide 4G network, price at marginal cost, and force every incumbent to match or die.

India should not be in the capital race to the bottom which we would lose to hyperscalers, and it is the intelligence equivalent of nationalising the telecoms. India crashed the price of data by engineering conditions and competition. So, the target is inference, not training: relentlessly drive down the cost of using a model. It released spectrum, created a demand shock, and let ferocious competition do the rest. The state built the road and set the rules; the market crashed the price. A billion people came online not because data was gifted, but because its cost fell below the threshold of thought. And the case for making it free – or as close to free as a gigabyte of data – is not utopian. It is the same case, run on the same playbook that worked three times before.

This is the model India should now apply to its fourth foundational utility: intelligence itself. Intelligence is no longer a luxury software product; it is foundational infrastructure.

> Making Artificial Intelligence affordable and ubiquitous should become India's next transformative public infrastructure revolution

The trade running against India

The global artificial intelligence (AI) race is currently operating under an extractive economic model, and India – despite its immense demographic dividend – is on the losing side of the trade. India serves as the world's digital quarry. India supplies an outsized share of the world's raw intelligence. Its engineers build and fine-tune the frontier models of Silicon Valley. Its digitised public life – languages, documents, transactions, behaviour – becomes training data.

Its universities and diaspora furnish a disproportionate slice of the research talent behind every major laboratory. Each day, Indians generate vast data; Indian engineers build Silicon Valley's frontier models; and Indian workers label datasets to make them safer. Yet, Indian startups must rent that intelligence back as dollar-priced API tokens, subject to export controls and hosted on distant servers. India exports talent, data, and usage, then imports the finished intelligence at high-margin, per-token prices on terms set in San Francisco. The pattern is familiar. Ship out the cotton, buy back the cloth. India recognised that trap in textiles centuries ago. It should recognise it in intelligence now.

India's AI token economy

India's national AI token economy should be built on the following pillars. First, making intelligence free is raw compute power. Through the IndiaAI Mission, backed by an outlay of about ₹10,372 crore, the government is building a public-private partnership model – not a state-run data centre monopoly. By empanelling private cloud providers and aggregating demand, it has onboarded over 38,000 GPUs, with plans to scale to 1,00,000. Eligible startups and researchers can access compute for about ₹65 per GPU hour, a fraction of global market rates.

India's grid planning does not yet treat AI load as a category. The single highest-leverage intervention available to the government is boring: fold compute into the National Electricity Plan, fast-track transmission to data-centre clusters, and dedicate renewables generation, including nuclear, to inference the way it once dedicated coal linkages to steel. Cheap electrons are the new cheap spectrum.

Second, cheap compute is useless without models to run on it. Currently, the most capable foundation models are closed source and owned by western tech giants. If Indian startups build their businesses on top of these proprietary APIs, they remain economically subservient. A single pricing change or policy shift in San Francisco can wipe out an entire sector in Bengaluru. India must mandate that foundational AI models become public goods.

The government must leverage its most valuable asset: linguistic and demographic data. The state should aggregate anonymised public data (legal rulings, agricultural data, educational curricula in all 22 official/scheduled languages) and make them available exclusively to researchers building open-source models. Further, any AI model developed using state-subsidised compute or public datasets must be released under an open-weights license. This mirrors the UPI philosophy: the government builds the rails, makes the protocol free, and lets private companies (Google Pay) compete on the user experience. By flooding the market with highly capable, open-source Indic LLMs (Large Language Models), India commoditises the "intelligence" layer. When foundational models are free and open, the economic value shifts from the model creators to the application builders – exactly where India's strength lies.

Third, the unified intelligence interface (UII) or distribution. How does a rural farmer or a Tier-3 developer access this free intelligence? An API gateway built on the principles of DPI, a UPI for AI. UPI's genius was not free payments as such; it was interoperability. A common protocol let any app talk to any bank, and switching costs fell to zero. Intelligence needs the same: an open, standardised interface through which any application can call any model – sovereign or private, open or proprietary – with shared standards for identity, consent, billing and safety.

Just as UPI abstracts away the complexity of inter-bank transfers, a national API gateway would abstract away the complexity of AI inference. Startups, government agencies, and educational institutions could plug into this gateway to access a suite of open-source models (translation, vision, text generation) for fractions of a penny.

To kickstart the ecosystem, the government could offer a national "freemium" model. Verified Indian startups or students through Aadhaar-linked digital identity could get monthly free API tokens, subsidised by the state. When startups scale and become profitable, they move to a commercial tier, paying slightly more for compute, which subsidises the free tier.

Additionally, a tenth of the fertilizer subsidy could be diverted to tokens for research and development institutions and schools. When intelligence becomes nearly free, sectors constrained by scarce human capital transform. A rural doctor, aided by AI trained on Indian data, can treat more patients with fewer errors; India's 300 million students get 24X7 personalised AI tutors in local dialects; a Karnataka farmer can settle a crop-insurance claim by voice in Kannada, with AI accessing land records.

The next great equaliser

In sum, free identity and cheap data did not make Indians rich; they made mass participation frictionless. Free intelligence can do the same. Nobody foresaw that near-free data would create the world's largest payments system, short-video platforms, and QR-code vegetable vendors.

Near-free intelligence could be just as generative if the state primes it with token entitlements for students and teachers, citizen services in local languages, and affordable tools for 60 million small businesses. India's leadership in the AI economy is contingent on developing an open-source ecosystem with open weights no-kill switch models that expand competition, choice, opportunities and innovation. The goal is not better chatbots; it is making cognition no longer a class privilege.

The views expressed are personal

The Bay of Bengal as India's SHANTI anchor

Rajeev Ranjan Chaturvedy

Associate Professor at the School of International Relations and Peace Studies, and Coordinator of the Centre for Bay of Bengal Studies at Nalanda University, Rajgir, Bihar

Raghvendra Kumar

Post-Doctoral Fellow, Nalanda University, and a Non-Resident Fellow with the Africa Program at the Foreign Policy Research Institute, Philadelphia

The Bay of Bengal region, one of the world's most disaster-prone regions, lacks coordinated mechanisms to respond to natural disasters. Non-traditional threats such as climate-induced disasters, illegal fishing, cyber vulnerabilities, and supply chain disruptions require regional cooperation beyond bilateral aid or maritime power. This gap – growing capacity without shared norms – highlights the need for stronger maritime security.

On July 13, External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar introduced Securing Holistic Advancement through Norms, Trust and Integrity (SHANTI) while launching India's candidature for the UN Security Council (UNSC) for the 2028-29 term. Building on Security and Growth for All in the Region (SAGAR) and Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions (MAHASAGAR), SHANTI provides a normative framework for shared maritime spaces, with the Bay of Bengal serving as the ideal region to operationalise it before expanding it across the wider Indo-Pacific.

The Bay's centrality

In recent years, the Bay of Bengal has moved from the margins to the centre of India's strategic thinking. Historically, it connected South and Southeast Asia through trade, culture, religion, and the exchange of ideas long before the Indo-Pacific entered diplomatic vocabulary.

Today, it links India's Act East policy with the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN), provides access to the strategically vital Malacca Strait, and connects the eastern Indian Ocean to major global trade and energy routes. China's heavy reliance on the strait – often described as the "Malacca dilemma" – has driven its expanding regional presence through ports and infrastructure projects, intensifying geopolitical competition. As economic connectivity, maritime governance, and strategic rivalry converge in the Bay, SHANTI offers a framework that places norms, trust, and integrity – not tonnage – as the currency of durable advantage.

> The Bay of Bengal is an ideal testing ground for SHANTI's security vision

A maritime security evolution

As such, SHANTI can be best understood as a logical evolution of its maritime outreach. SAGAR, articulated in 2015, supplied the vision of 'equity in development' and MAHASAGAR, announced in 2025, expanded that vision's scope recognising the interconnectedness of security (both vertically among nations and horizontally in threat perception) in the wider Indo-Pacific and the Global South. SHANTI offers the grammar of maritime security framework, the norms, trust and integrity in cooperation through which vision can be translated into tangible action that is well received and reciprocated. It shifts the emphasis from competition to demand driven cooperation, from influence to non-prescriptive institution-building, and from episodic crisis management to long-term resilience. This shift – from protecting maritime spaces to governing shared maritime commons – reflects India's new security mantra. If SAGAR was a statement of intent and MAHASAGAR a statement of reach, SHANTI is a statement of method to situate India as the "preferred security partner" and "first responder".

Because the Bay of Bengal is a single interconnected system, its cyclones, fish stocks, shipping lanes and pollution cross national boundaries almost by default, and its littoral states face remarkably similar challenges and concerns – disaster risk reduction and response, coastal erosion, fisheries management, port resilience, undersea cable protection and climate adaptation.

Unlike the western Indian Ocean, which is marked by active conflict, fragile economy and contested spaces, the Bay of Bengal's strategic geography encourages cooperation. Yet, the region suffers less from a lack of institutions than from institutional fragmentation. What is missing is a common framework to align existing mechanisms. SHANTI fills this gap by providing principles to strengthen cooperation in maritime security, disaster response, the blue economy, and environmental resilience. India's geography gives it a natural convening role, but its centrality should rest on regional stewardship – not dominance – through trust-based, rules-based cooperation among states with shared challenges and opportunities.

Principles to practice

Taken together, these conditions make the Bay of Bengal India's most governable maritime sub-region – a natural laboratory where SHANTI can move from principle to practice before shaping wider cooperation across the Indian Ocean. This was reflected at the July 2026 BIMSTEC National Security Advisers' meeting in New Delhi, where member-states adopted common principles for maritime law enforcement and humanitarian assistance and disaster relief. BIMSTEC also agreed to hold its first joint maritime security exercise in the Bay, in November 2026, while a white shipping information-sharing agreement remains under discussion. These initiatives reflect the norm-building and trust-based cooperation that SHANTI seeks to promote. Its lasting contribution, therefore, will not be another acronym in India's maritime lexicon, but a redefinition of security – from deterrence to resilience, from rivalry to shared responsibility, and from crisis management to governance of the shared maritime commons.

The views expressed are personal

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Have constructive debate

As a citizen, it is disheartening to witness repeated disruptions, heated exchanges, and political confrontations in Parliament during debates that could have been devoted to very constructive discussions on issues of national importance. Valuable time has been consumed by arguments, interruptions, and procedural disputes instead of addressing pressing concerns such as the challenges students face, examination irregularities, the quality of education, and unemployment. While differences of opinion are natural in a democracy, they should be expressed with dignity and mutual respect. Both the government and the Opposition share this responsibility. I sincerely hope that our elected representatives will rise above political differences and make Parliament a platform for constructive debate, thoughtful policymaking, and public welfare.

Parry Garg,
Ludhiana, Punjab

Alleged excesses, remarks

Reports from various sources indicate that brutal force was unleashed against the protesting students in Delhi. Visuals purportedly showing police manhandling young women and using pellet guns, rubber bullets, and spiked lathis, causing bleeding injuries, have gone viral on social media. In this context, some government sources dismissing all this as "normal" only serves to further inflame public sentiment. There have already been objectionable statements describing the young women who participated in the protest in utterly deplorable terms. Any attempt to brush aside these serious allegations is unfortunate.

A.G. Rajmohan,
Anantapur, Andhra Pradesh

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Have fast-track courts delivered on the promise of speedy justice?

Bharat Chugh
Delhi-based advocate and former civil judge

Shruthi Naik
Senior resident fellow at Vidhi Centre for Legal Policy, Delhi

PARLEY

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's announcement to set up fast-track courts to hear paper leak cases has once again revived the debate over whether these specialised courts are the silver bullet to India's chronic judicial delays. Following the announcement, the Delhi High Court has constituted a fast-track court at the Rouse Avenue Courts Complex to exclusively hear cases under the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024. However, stakeholders have cautioned that fast-track courts also struggle with mounting pendency and resource constraints. So, have fast-track courts delivered on the promise of speedy justice? Bharat Chugh and Shruthi Naik discuss the question in a conversation moderated by **Aaratrika Bhaumik**.

How effective have fast-track courts been?

Bharat Chugh: Fast-track courts have succeeded in delivering speed, but only for the limited category of cases assigned to them. That is because, in most instances, a fast-track court does not entail the creation of additional judges or judicial capacity. For example, take the proposed fast-track courts for exam leak cases. The judges presiding over these courts are typically drawn from the existing judicial system and reassigned from the cases they were already handling to hear these priority matters instead. Rather than expand the judiciary's capacity, fast-track courts redeploy existing judicial resources. As a result, while the designated cases move through the system more quickly, the matters those judges were previously handling are pushed further down the queue.

Shruthi Naik: The larger problem is that we rarely consider, at a structural level, what establishing a fast-track court actually requires. While funds may be allocated for judicial officers, support staff, and operational expenses, the real constraint is judicial capacity. If all we are doing is reallocating existing judges rather than expanding the system, we are simply shifting the backlog elsewhere. Equally important is whether the procedural reforms needed to support these courts are in place. Are witness depositions taking place in a timely and predictable manner? Are all stakeholders coordinating to ensure cases progress without unnecessary adjournments? Without these systemic changes, it is difficult to assess whether fast-track courts are truly delivering on their promise of speedy justice.

The Union Law Ministry recently said that Fast-Track Special Courts (FTSCs) are burdened with a backlog of nearly 2.45 lakh cases. What explains this pendency?

Prayer for justice: A child lights a candle after a march on the NEET paper leak issue in Shimla on July 25. PTI

SN: The Law Ministry's data includes the number of cases instituted, disposed of, and pending over the past three years. A closer look at those figures shows that the case clearance rate (the number of cases disposed of compared with the number of cases instituted) has remained below 100% each year. In other words, the system has consistently failed to keep pace with the volume of new cases being filed. In 2025, around 1.4 lakh cases were instituted, but only about 66,000 were disposed of. The remainder inevitably added to the backlog.

More importantly, if we want to assess whether fast-track courts are truly delivering speedy justice, we need robust data on the time taken to dispose of cases. While the National Judicial Data Grid provides pendency and disposal timelines for courts generally, it does not offer comparable data for FTSCs. Without that degree of transparency, it is difficult to evaluate whether these courts are fulfilling the objective for which they were established.

BC: The pendency in fast-track courts cannot be viewed in isolation. It has to be seen in the context of the overall burden on the justice system. Trial courts across the country are currently grappling with nearly 4.8 crore pending cases, of which roughly 74% are criminal matters. That is an enormous caseload, particularly when viewed alongside the limited judicial strength available to handle it. Every year, crores of fresh cases are instituted, spanning offences from acid attacks and chain-snatching to cybercrime and murder. That is the scale of the challenge confronting the justice system. Without addressing these systemic constraints, it is difficult to expect fast-track courts alone to bring about lasting improvements in the delivery of speedy justice.

> Ideally, we should be striving for a justice system that does not require fast-track courts at all. The very demand for specialised courts suggests that people have lost confidence in the ability of the regular justice system to deliver timely justice
> SHRUTHI NAIK

The Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026, requires investigations into paper leak cases to be completed within two months and sets a three-month timeline for trials. Should laws prescribe such rigid timelines?

BC: The Supreme Court has repeatedly cautioned against prescribing rigid timelines for criminal proceedings because every case presents its own complexities. Criminal trials often involve chargesheets and evidence running into thousands of pages. Forcing proceedings into a rigid timeline may deprive the defence of a meaningful opportunity to prepare its case, thereby compromising the right to a fair trial. It can also leave courts with less flexibility to effectively manage witnesses, whose testimony is often crucial to the outcome of a case. Therefore, the objective should be to strike a careful balance between expeditious justice and procedural fairness, without sacrificing one in pursuit of the other.

SN: Before prescribing strict timelines, we need to ask whether the necessary institutional capacity actually exists. Do we have enough investigators, forensic laboratories, and judicial resources to complete investigations within the prescribed time? Can forensic reports be generated quickly enough? Can witnesses always be traced and examined without delay? While everyone wants cases to be concluded expeditiously, that objective cannot come at the cost of the quality of justice being delivered. Setting aspirational timelines to encourage the expeditious disposal of cases is one thing, but making them mandatory is quite another.

The Supreme Court has cautioned that arbitrarily designating cases for fast-track courts may violate the right to equality under Article 14 of the Constitution. What considerations should guide the selection of cases for fast-track courts?

SN: Ideally, we should be striving for a justice system that does not require fast-track courts at all. The very demand for specialised courts suggests that people have lost confidence in the ability of the regular justice system to deliver timely justice. More often than not, the decision to assign certain categories of cases to fast-track courts is driven by public sentiment. If individuals are entitled to equal protection of the law, they should also have an equal opportunity to access justice. These are difficult policy choices, and any decision to assign cases to fast-track courts must rest on a rational basis consistent with the guarantee of equality.

In 2019, FTSCs were constituted to ensure the time-bound trial of rape cases and offences under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act. Have these courts lived up to the purpose?

BC: A major challenge facing FTSCs is the acute shortage of resources. Strengthening the prosecution has never received the attention it deserves. Even in Delhi, it is not uncommon for a single public prosecutor to appear before multiple courts in a day, simply because there are not enough prosecutors. This is particularly concerning in complex criminal cases, where prosecutors often face teams of defence lawyers with far greater legal and research support. The same resource deficit is evident in forensic infrastructure. Paper leak cases, for instance, often hinge on digital evidence recovered from electronic devices, making cyber forensics critical. Yet forensic laboratories are severely understaffed and overburdened. Unless we strengthen the prosecution, expand forensic capacity, and fill judicial vacancies, FTSCs alone cannot deliver speedy justice.

What institutional reforms are required?

BC: A fast-track court is only as effective as the investigation that precedes it. If the objective is to deliver timely and well-reasoned judgments, the process must begin with a credible investigation. That requires adequately trained investigators, timely forensic assistance and the support necessary to gather reliable evidence.

SN: Lawyers, witnesses, investigators and prosecutors should know well in advance when they are required to appear so that hearings can proceed without disruption. Equally important is reducing avoidable delays. That means minimising adjournments and ensuring court directions are complied with promptly.

To listen to the full interview
Scan the code or go to the link
www.thehindu.com

NOTEBOOK

Newspaper archives still trump answers generated by AI

In-depth archival research shows AI's lack of fact-checking, limited access to older news reports, and failure to remain unbiased

Suchitra Karthikeyan

As I typed in the words, "First Indian leader to visit the Prambanan temple", in Google search for an article this week, the answer flashed *Prime Minister Narendra Modi is the first Indian leader to visit the historic temple*. However, I felt a nagging sense of doubt as India and Indonesia have collaborated since the 1940s, both militarily and culturally. To verify, I checked *The Hindu*'s semantic search which browses through newspaper archives spanning over a century. As reported by *The Hindu*, on December 14, 1958, India's President Dr. Rajendra Prasad drove down to Prambanan temple during his official visit to Indonesia. The article titled 'Monument of Buddha' noted how Dr. Prasad was impressed by the sight and that he had paid tribute to the renovation work, which was underway with the help of the Archaeological Survey of India.

I asked the same question to various Artificial Intelligence (AI) tools such as ChatGPT, Gemini and Grok, and got the same answer – that Mr. Modi was the first Indian leader to visit the shrine.

To further analyse the extent of AI's handicap, I questioned both ChatGPT and Gemini about the "first Indian Prime Minister to visit Palestine"; it answered – *Narendra Modi on February 10, 2018, when he visited Ramallah in the West Bank and held talks with Palestinian President Mahmoud Abbas*. However, a look into *The Hindu*'s archives shows that Jawaharlal Nehru was the first Indian Prime Minister to visit the Gaza Strip on May 19, 1960. In an article dated May 20, 1960, *The Hindu* recounts how Mr. Nehru made a one-day trip to the United Nations Emergency Force and Palestinian refugee camps during his official visit to the United Arab Republic (UAR) (a short-lived union of Egypt and Syria). His visit was marred by Israeli Super-Mystere fighter jets circling over the United Nations flight carrying him to Gaza – a violation of the airspace of Palestine which had then been under the UAR's military control.

A look into the results given by the AI tools shows that in spite of several newspaper reports of Mr. Nehru's visit, AI challenged its veracity as Mr. Nehru's visit was to Gaza – then occupied by the UAR. It chose to classify Mr. Modi's visit to Ramallah as the first instance as it was governed by the Palestinian Authority. However, India had recognised both Palestine (comprising the Gaza Strip and the West Bank) and Israel in 1948 itself. With the changing nature of the governing authority in both the West Bank and Gaza throughout the years, a visit to either territory by a state head has to be taken into account.

A final example which highlights AI's limitation came when I posed this query to Gemini and ChatGPT: "Have U.S. senators or Congressmen visited Ram temple in Ayodhya". Gemini stated that *there is no public record or official confirmation of any current or former U.S. Senator or U.S. Congressman having physically visited the temple*, while ChatGPT erroneously stated that a U.S. Congressional delegation visited the temple in 2024.

The Hindu's archival search shows that a nine-member delegation of U.S. Senators visited the Ram Janmabhoomi complex on November 3, 1993, almost a year after the Babri Masjid was demolished. Accompanied by leaders of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), the delegation led by Steven Morse visited the make-shift tent at the site housing Ram Lalla. Mr. Morse clarified that their visit was "to study the democratic functioning and culture of the country" and not for political purposes.

In spite of AI's continued learning, archives of century-old newspapers like *The Hindu* present facts without the filter of an algorithm tailored around the user's preferences, political ideology and search patterns. The above examples show AI's lack of fact-checking, limited access to older news reports, and failure to remain unbiased. It stresses the need for legacy newspapers to provide more digital reports highlighting its old journalism in order to set the record straight.

suchitra.k@thehindu.co.in

PICTURE OF THE WEEK

A holy bounty

Mountain of offering: The coconuts broken by devotees, as part of a traditional ritual before commencing the annual 32-km Giri Pradakshina, at the Tholi Pavancha near the foothills of Simhachalam in Visakhapatnam on July 29. The sacred pilgrimage witnessed an overwhelming turnout of around six lakh devotees this year. V. RAJU

FROM THE ARCHIVES — The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO JULY 31, 1976

T.Nadu raffle to be revived

Madras, July 30: The raffle scheme which was discontinued in Tamil Nadu from September last year is to be revived shortly.

The State Government has decided to allot the first one crore of rupees from the net proceeds of the scheme during the current year for provision of drinking water supply in drought hit areas. The balance will go to acquisition of house-sites for Harijans.

In the coming years also, the proceeds of the State raffle will be earmarked to appropriate welfare and development projects in the State.

The revival of the scheme will provide employment to about 2,500 agents and supplemental income to a large number of others, according to an official press release. Authorised agents as on September, 1975 will be given an opportunity to re-register themselves before new agents are appointed.

The Finance Secretary Mr. S. Guhan, said that as in the previous scheme the tickets would be value of one rupee each and draws would be held every month. The first draw would be conducted in about two months as time was required to print the raffle tickets and organise the machinery for their sale.

The raffle scheme was first introduced in the State in August 1968.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO JULY 31, 1926

Indian university degrees

The following is from "The Times Educational Supplement" of July 3rd:–

At the forthcoming Congress of British Universities at Cambridge, the question of the recognition of the degrees of Indian universities by Oxford and Cambridge will be considered. At the second annual meeting of the Inter-University Board of India held at Delhi in February Sir Philip Hartog, who took a prominent share in the establishment of the board and is to be its representative at the conference, was requested to submit the case of the Indian universities. It was reported at the first session held at Bombay that Cambridge was unwilling to consider individual applications from Indian universities for affiliation.

Text&Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Central scholarship funding gap in Jharkhand

700 in ₹ crore. Jharkhand CM Hemant Soren has claimed a funding gap of over ₹700 crore in central scholarship support over the last two financial years, saying it has affected scholarship payments. He urged the Prime Minister to intervene. PTI

European Union disbursement to Ukraine for defence

3.47 in € billion. The European Union has disbursed €3.47 billion to Ukraine to finance the procurement of drones, missiles, air defence systems and fighter jets, the European Commission said. The payment is part of a €90 billion loan approved earlier this year. REUTERS

Pharmaceutical facilities facing enforcement action

90 in per cent. India has taken enforcement action against about 90% of inspected high-risk pharmaceutical facilities under a nationwide quality drive, according to the drug regulator. Since late 2022, regulators have conducted more than 960 risk-based inspections and audits. REUTERS

Urban Challenge Fund projects approved by Lok Sabha so far

33 The government has approved or accorded in-principle approval to 33 projects under the Urban Challenge Fund, Housing and Urban Affairs Minister Manohar Lal said. The fund envisages ₹1 lakh crore in central assistance over the mission period to support urban infrastructure projects. PTI

Number of candidates recommended by SSC for government jobs

3.6 in lakh. As many as 3.61 lakh candidates have been recommended by the Staff Selection Commission (SSC) for government jobs in the last four years, Union Minister Jitendra Singh said on Thursday. PTI

COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

Follow us facebook.com/thehindu X.com/the_hindu instagram.com/the_hindu

How common are cloudbursts in India?

What counts as a cloudburst under the IMD's definition? How do they form over mountainous regions? Why are they so difficult to forecast? Can the term obscure the role of poor planning, inadequate infrastructure? What is India doing to improve forecasting and early warnings?

EXPLAINER

Vasudevan Mukunth

The story so far:

When a wall of water suddenly crashes from the sky and sweeps away homes and roads within minutes, one of the first words officials and the media in India reach for is 'cloudburst'. However, the term is often misused in a way that can distract from poor planning and crumbling infrastructure.

What counts as a cloudburst?

According to the India Meteorological Department (IMD), a cloudburst occurs when a small area, around 20-30 sq. km, receives 10 cm or more of rain in an hour.

To put this in perspective, Indore receives 1,062 mm of rain every year on average. A cloudburst could dump nearly 10% of this in 60 minutes.

Heavy rains are a common feature of the southwest monsoon, but a cloudburst is still an extraordinary amount of rainfall and much rarer. Because the water falls so quickly over a relatively small area, the ground cannot absorb all of it, leading to rapid and voluminous flooding.

Some scientists have also advocated for a category called 'mini-cloudburst', for 5 cm of rain in an hour over the same area, as, depending on the local topography, this can be devastating as well.

How common are cloudbursts in India?

Although cloudbursts are relatively rare, global warming, in particular as the atmosphere warms and can hold more moisture, is making them more frequent.

In response to a question, former Union Earth Sciences Minister Harsh Vardhan told Parliament in 2019 that between 1970 and 2016, the IMD had recorded only around 30 such incidents. However, many experts believe this number is an underestimate.

Counting them is not straightforward because most cloudbursts occur in remote, high-altitude regions, where rain gauges and weather stations are sparse.

Debris lies scattered after a cloudburst triggered flash floods, at Pahalgam in Anantnag, on July 12. PTI

In fact, if a cloudburst occurs a few kilometres from a monitoring station, it may not be officially recorded as a cloudburst even if it causes large-scale destruction downstream.

Uttarakhand, Himachal Pradesh, and Jammu and Kashmir have, of late, reported a surge in events that locals have described as cloudbursts, especially in July and August.

How does a cloudburst form?

A cloudburst typically begins with convection, when warm, moist air rises rapidly into the atmosphere. In mountainous areas, this is called orographic lifting, where monsoon winds are forced upwards by steep slopes.

As the air rises, it cools and condenses into towering cumulonimbus clouds, which can be up to 15 km tall.

Water droplets begin to form inside these clouds and, as they get heavier, they would normally fall as rain. However, if the currents of warm air moving upwards are very strong, they can keep raindrops suspended in the air for longer.

Eventually, the weight of the water droplets becomes too great for gravity and the updrafts to hold, or the updrafts weaken, sending the water plummeting down like an ocean descending on the ground.

Can the label obscure accountability?

By calling a heavy downpour a 'cloudburst', authorities can turn it into a singular and unforeseeable act of nature, obscuring the role of human negligence.

That is, if the cause of a tragedy is said to be a 'cloudburst', the blame can be written off, which is harder to do when the real cause is "heavy rain combined with poor drainage".

In 2025, during the Dharali floods in Uttarakhand, initial reports blamed a cloudburst. However, meteorological data later showed that the actual rate of rainfall was much lower than the threshold for a cloudburst.

The underlying causes were illegal construction on riverbeds, deforestation that had left soil vulnerable to erosion, and the absence of drainage infrastructure along new "all weather" roads.

Had the downpour indeed been a cloudburst, officials may have been able to avoid questions about why the State had allowed buildings to be constructed in high-risk zones and why early warning systems failed.

Last week, the IMD rejected reports that Assam and Nagaland had experienced cloudbursts over the preceding few days and that they were responsible for the Upper Assam floods.

Are cloudbursts hard to forecast?

Cloudbursts are very difficult to forecast. Meteorologists can usually say whether a region is at risk of heavy rain but cannot say precisely which patch of land will experience a cloudburst.

First, most weather models study the atmosphere in grids and estimate the average weather for each cell.

A cloudburst, on the other hand, occurs over an area smaller than the size of each grid cell. To detect one, scientists need very high-resolution models, which in turn require immense computing power that is not always readily available.

Because of the mechanism through which cloudbursts form, they also develop and occur quickly. Cyclones and monsoon systems, on the other hand, can be tracked for weeks or even months, giving scientists more data to work with.

Finally, mountains are challenging environments for weather monitoring, and cloudbursts have a greater propensity to occur there. For instance, Doppler weather radars work by emitting and receiving radar beams, which mountains can block, creating blind spots over many areas where cloudbursts are also more common.

Because the terrain is so rugged, there are also fewer automatic weather stations. If there are no sensors on the ground to tell a computer what is happening at a given moment, it cannot reliably predict what could happen in the next hour.

That said, the IMD is currently working on 'nowcasting', a technology that issues short-term alerts every few hours.

Under the government's new 'Mission Mausam', India also plans to more than double its radar network, from the current 40 or so, and use AI to better predict hyperlocal events.

That said, even with the best technology, a cloudburst is likely to remain more difficult to predict than a typical rainstorm.

THE GIST

- A cloudburst is a highly localised weather event in which at least 10 cm of rain falls over 20-30 sq. km in an hour, making it difficult to forecast despite advances in nowcasting and radar coverage.
- The term is often incorrectly used for heavy rainfall events, even though many disasters are exacerbated by poor drainage, deforestation, construction in high-risk zones and other human factors.

Why did Cauvery panel order Karnataka to release water?

What factors did the committee consider before fixing the quantum of release?

T. Ramakrishnan

The story so far:

The Cauvery Water Management Authority (CWMA), at its meeting on Thursday in New Delhi, endorsed the Cauvery Water Regulation Committee's (CWRC) order, issued on July 28, that Karnataka release 3,500 cubic feet per second (cusecs) to Tamil Nadu for 15 days, starting from July 29. If the quantity of 3,500 cusecs is available throughout the day for 15 days, the quantum of water is about 4.5 thousand million cubic feet (tmc ft).

What is the brief for the CWRC in tackling the Cauvery dispute?

The CWRC functions within the ambit of the Cauvery Water Management Authority (CWMA), which constitutes the implementation mechanism for the final award (2007) of the Cauvery Water Disputes Tribunal as modified by the Supreme Court in 2018.

The committee is headed by the Member (Water Resources) of the CWMA, Vineet Gupta, and has as its members the Chief Engineers of all the basin constituents and a representative each of the India Meteorological Department, Central Water Commission, and Union Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers' Welfare.

According to a notification issued by the Union Jal Shakti Ministry in June 2018, the committee monitors daily water levels, inflows and storage at each of the reservoirs – Hemavathy, Harangi, Krishnarajasagara (KRS) and Kabini (all in Karnataka), Mettur, Bhavanisagar and Amaravathy (Tamil Nadu), and Banasurasagar in Kerala. It is to ensure 10 daily releases of water on a monthly basis from the reservoirs as directed by the authority. It is also to prepare seasonal – southwest monsoon (June-October 15); northeast monsoon (October 16-January 31) and hot weather (February-May) – and annual reports of the water account.

During either of the monsoons, the CWRC ordinarily holds meetings once every 15 days in a hybrid mode. As there has been scanty rainfall in the Cauvery catchment this time and Tamil Nadu pressing its demand for the release of its share of water, the CWRC met on July 28 to review the situation. It will meet again on August 11.

How does the committee arrive at decisions in times of distress?

The hydro-meteorological conditions prevailing in the Cauvery basin, including the rainfall recorded and the forecast or outlook for the ensuing fortnight, live storage position, inflows into and outflows from the eight reservoirs, and the realisation of flows at Biligundulu are reviewed and deliberated upon in detail.

Compliance with the decision and directions issued during the previous meeting is also reviewed at the next meeting.

What else was considered by the CWRC?

The committee took into account net inflow to the four reservoirs in Karnataka during the current season and compared it with 30-year data. Mr. Gupta, in a conversation with *The Hindu* on Wednesday, said the shortfall suffered was to the extent of 60%.

The CWRC considered the flow of river water at Biligundulu and in the intermediate catchment – between KRS-Kabini and Mettur, both of which presented a gloomy picture. At Biligundulu, the deficit was 90%.

Given that the Meteorological Department did not give an optimistic outlook for the subsequent weeks, the CWRC, according to its chief, had arrived at the decision that would make Karnataka comfortable to release the water. As on July 30, the combined storage of the four reservoirs in the upper riparian State was 65.34 tmc ft against a total capacity of 114.57 tmc ft.

What were the reactions?

As Karnataka has not commenced water supply for irrigation this time in view of deficient rainfall, it is naturally upset at the decision. At the meeting of the CWMA, it filed an appeal against the CWRC's order, but this was rejected. Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar, now in New Delhi, subsequently announced that an all-party meeting would be held in Bengaluru on August 2 to seek the advice of the parties on the next move.

In Tamil Nadu, where the authorities have not commenced the water release for irrigation in the Cauvery delta, there are no takers for the Committee's move. The quantum is viewed as insufficient. There is a view that the CWRC should have ordered Karnataka to release the entire deficit of 9.8 tmc ft, as worked out by it. According to an estimate, the State's water requirement for the ongoing and short-term *kuruvai* cultivation season is at least 30 tmc ft, given the current coverage of 3.5 lakh acres. But the storage in Mettur is around 36 tmc ft, of which 10 tmc ft has to be kept apart for drinking water needs and dead storage. However, Tamil Nadu would require much more water for the next *samba-thaladi* cultivation season, which facilitates livelihood opportunities to lakhs of agricultural labourers in the delta. It needs a minimum of 180 tmc ft.

What is the way forward?

The States, as Mr. Gupta also pointed out, have to evolve a distress-sharing formula. This issue can be covered in the proposed visit of Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay to Bengaluru to persuade the Karnataka government to release his State's share of the Cauvery river water.

BIBLIOGRAPHY

Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Uttar Pradesh CM Yogi Adityanath during the roadshow before the 2024 Lok Sabha election, in Ghaziabad. FILE PHOTO

The rise of the cow belt and the politics of majoritarian power

An excerpt from *Heartland Rising: The Making of Majoritarian India* examines the cow belt's growing political weight and its role in shaping majoritarian politics; it explores the intersections of demography, education, religion and electoral power

Javed Gaya

'The Rise of the Cow Belt'
Page 94-96

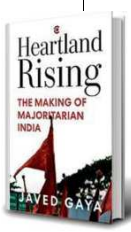
It is relevant that Uttar Pradesh and Bihar have consistently been privileged, that their chronic failure to develop is concealed under a carapace of opacity, hiding important aspects of State development in order to enhance the weightage it would receive under the Finance Commission. The Union government has deliberately manipulated and diluted the data for this purpose. To take one example, there is the matter of literacy rates. In Uttar Pradesh, the literacy rate appears to have increased substantially from 1951 to 2011, from around 12 per cent to 68 per cent. However, one must be wary of such figures, as the definition India employs to define a literate person is an outlier. To be considered literate in India, one only has to be able to read and write their own name; this requires a very limited notion of the alphabet. If your name is Shiv, for example, you only need to know four letters. The Annual Status of Education Report (ASER) released in January 2024 shows that more than 50 per cent of fourteen-to eighteen-year-old children in rural India are unable to solve a simple three-digit division problem that is taught in class III. Literacy skills are not much better, as from the same sample over 25 per cent were unable to read class II level textbooks and just shy of 50 per cent could not read sentences in English. Of those who could read, 26.5 per cent did not understand what they were reading. These are very damning statistics and point to population growth being an impending disaster rather than the much-vaunted demographic dividend envisaged by economists and politicians.

In this context, the priorities of State governments, and particularly that of Uttar Pradesh, are relevant.

In 2022, a new session commenced in Uttar Pradesh, but school children had no books as the government alleged it had insufficient funds to float a tender. School teachers complained that in the absence of new books, they had to collect books distributed to children in the previous school session.

However, the Uttar Pradesh government seems to have ample funds for spending on religious affairs. The Department of Religious Affairs had forwarded a budget of 1,100 crores for FY 2022-23. This is to be contrasted with the more parsimonious allocations of previous years – a paltry 32.5 crores was spent in 2017-18, which rose to 604.88 crores in 2021-22.

These priorities have to be seen in light of the vainglorious narrative that the Union government seeks to project regarding the incipient digital and knowledge economy. This seems rather fanciful given the absence of any desire to impart basic skills of literacy and numeracy; post-COVID, some 51,000 government schools have shut down without there being any express intention of replacing them. There is much excitement about digital learning, but this disregards the fact that only around 50 per cent of Indian households have access to the internet, and that figure is only 37 per cent in rural India. So, it is evident that education is not a priority and whatever resources the Uttar Pradesh government has are directed towards promoting greater religiosity, a fact that portends the future of the cow belt. With the grandiose consecration of the Ram temple at Ayodhya, the theme of religious tourism is being projected as the 'desideratum' for Uttar Pradesh in terms of business and employment generation, but it is something that even the electorate of Faizabad roundly rejected in 2024.



This is the preparatory ground for the emergence of a significant politician from the cow belt, a national leader who would lead post the present Prime Minister, someone like Yogi Adityanath who has shown great fidelity to the principles of Hindutva. Post the 2024 general elections and, with rumours of there having been a falling out between Yogi and the Centre, this trajectory does not seem as self-evident as it once was, and much will hinge on the Uttar Pradesh elections in 2027.

With the emergence of the cow belt as the cynosure for the new nationalism, and with the prospect of delimitation looming, one discerns a new and unsettling diffidence amongst public intellectuals as well as politicians from the South, on the inviolability of the formula of 'One Man, One Vote', the signature tune of majoritarianism. In fact, what Gopalkrishna Gandhi has urged is postponing delimitation until the cow belt's population growth comes under control (which may never happen). Clever contrivances suggested by him, such as the 'Cambridge Compromise', look suspiciously like the concerns Ivor Jennings, the constitutional lawyer, had alluded to in the 1950s, that in a post-colonial society, 'a narrow franchise, indirect elections, tribal representations may all be [seen as] quite sensible.'

(Excerpted with permission from Heartland Rising: The Making of Majoritarian India by Javed Gaya, published by Context-Westland Books)

THE DAILY QUIZ

Please send in your answers to dailyquiz@thehindu.co.in

Kavinsky, one of the defining sounds of the French electro scene, died this week at 50. Test your knowledge of the late artist

Mohammed Hidhayat

QUESTION 1
Name his 2010 cult hit track that was also performed at the 2024 Paris Olympics.

QUESTION 2
Guy-Manuel de Homem-Christo co-produced [1]. He was one half of _____, the iconic former French electronic duo. Fill in the blank.

QUESTION 3
Kavinsky was a stage persona of Vincent Belorgey. What is the character's backstory?

QUESTION 4
Many fans associate Kavinsky's work as part of an electronic music microcosm that evokes nostalgia for the 1980s culture. Identify the retro genre.

QUESTION 5
What was the title of Kavinsky's second and final studio album, released in 2022?

Visual Question:
This 2011 neo-noir thriller, starring Ryan Gosling in a scorpion jacket, introduced Kavinsky to a broader audience. Name the film. FILMDISTRICT

Questions and Answers to the previous day's daily quiz: 1. In which Swedish city was Ingmar Bergman born in 1918? **Ans: Uppsala**
2. Which Bergman film won the Academy Award for Best Foreign Language Film in 1961? **Ans: *The Virgin Spring***
3. Identify the two Bergman films for which cinematographer Sven Nykvist won the Academy Award for Best Cinematography. **Ans: *Cries and Whispers* (1972) and *Fanny and Alexander* (1982)**
4. Despite sharing a surname and Swedish heritage, iconic actress Ingrid Bergman appeared in only one film directed by Ingmar Bergman. Name the film. **Ans: *Autumn Sonata* (1978)**
5. Ingmar Bergman died on July 30, 2007, the same day as which fellow European cinema giant? **Ans: Michelangelo Antonioni**
Visual: Ian McKellen plays Death in the Arnold Schwarzenegger starrer, Last Action Hero. Which Bergman film is this scene paying homage to? **Ans: *The Seventh Seal* (1957)**
Early Birds: Prem Nath Tiwari | Sunil Madhavan | Pulkit Sathe | Dodo Jayaditya | Arun Kumar Singh

FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

"What are all those old magazines doing on the table?"

"My cousin from Delhi is here. He couldn't sleep last night. So he spent his time reading. He is a voracious reader."

"Vor...what?"

"V..o..r..a..c..i..o..u..s. The 'o' in the first syllable is like the 'a' in 'china'. The 'a' in the second syllable is pronounced like the 'ay' in 'ray', 'bay', and 'say'."

"The final 'iou' is like the 'a' in 'china' again, right?"

"Exactly! The 'c' by the way is like the 'sh' in 'sheet', 'sheep', and 'ship'. And the stress is on the second syllable. Any idea what the word means?"

"Voracious! Doesn't it mean truthful?"

"No, you are thinking of another word. When you say that someone is a voracious reader, it means that the person loves to read lots of books."

"How does this example sound? Mohan is a voracious reader of mystery novels."

"Sounds good. The word can be used to refer to one's appetite as well. For example..."

"...it probably means someone who loves to eat."

"That's exactly what it means. When you say that someone has a voracious appetite it implies that he/she eats large quantities of food. He/she is greedy to eat. For example, though Karthick looks skinny he has a voracious appetite."

"How about this example? Some of the kids in my class have voracious appetites."

"That's a good. Now, tell me..."

"...what was the word that I was thinking of?"

"What?"

"Well, when I said voracious means truthful, you said that I was thinking of another word. Which word...."

"....oh that! The word that you probably had in mind was 'veracious'. This word is spelt v..e..r..a..c..i..o..u..s. According to many dictionaries it's pronounced the same way as 'voracious'."

"It is? Then how does a listener know which word the speaker is...."

"....the context will tell you whether the speaker means 'voracious' or 'veracious'."

"I see. But tell me, what does the 'veracious' mean?"

"When you say that someone is 'veracious', it means the person is habitually truthful. It's a word that is generally used in formal contexts."

"Someone who tells the truth all the time! I don't think I have met such a person. It's definitely not a quality that we expect in our politicians."

"An honest politician is a bit of a contradiction."

"We listened to the testimony of my veracious cousin."

"Politicians are not known for their veracity. And..."

"....before you start giving me a lecture on politicians, any news about your neighbour's son?"

"Yes, they found him at the city bus stand. He was trying to run away from home."

"Why?"

"He said that he wanted to be independent from his parents. He wanted to be independent from them because...."

"....independent of, not from."

"I see. Most teenagers want to be independent of their parents."

"I don't want to be independent of my parents at all. In fact, I think I will be dependent on my father as long as possible."

"That's a good idea. I am not really sure if your father will put up with you for long."

Published in The Hindu on June 19, 2001

Word of the day

Vainglory: the fact of being too proud of your own abilities or achievements

Synonyms: vanity, pride, confidence

Usage: *Her vainglory often annoyed her friends.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/vainglory

International Phonetic Alphabet: /veɪnglɔːri/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Text & Context'

From Page One

'Pellet guns part of graded police response'

The police have to be prepared with a graded response, which includes the use of force, to every possible turn of events while dealing with a restive crowd, the court said.

"We are completely in agreement with pleas of no-violence principle when it comes to agitation of students or persons expressing dissatisfaction with a government policy... But there is also the question of elements hijacking students' protests. A protest must have started with a bona fide purpose, but it may end up as a vehicle for various ulterior purposes... The hijacking may even be intended to sabotage the bona fide protests," Justice Bagchi said.

Protective gear

Justice Bagchi sounded out the government on the need to arm the police with protective gear. This, he said, would give police personnel the confidence of a precious few seconds to pause and think before unleashing violence on protestors. "The best way is to arm your police with defensive gear. That gives them the confidence to ponder... Everyone is a human being. If someone comes with a lathi at you, whether it is a policeman or other, if you wear a helmet, you would take a few more seconds to gauge the situation before deciding the course of action. These aspects must also be included in this debate here," Justice Bagchi said.

The court said the prayer was "vague", and asked advocate Vrinda Grover to amend the petition to challenge the rules which allow the use of pellet guns. Ms. Grover said she could not find any standing orders of the Delhi Police mandating the use of pellet guns. The court turned to Solicitor-General to place on record any protocol followed by the police in controlling unlawful assemblies.

Women face doxxing, threats after protests

The Hindu found that several accounts involved in sharing such content have, in recent days, amplified videos alleging that protesters abused public authorities or assaulted police personnel.

Soon after the Jantar Mantar protest ended, a 23-year-old student posted a seven-second reel on her Instagram account, which has 3.78 lakh followers. Within an hour, the video had crossed a million views before she deleted it. Five days and two apologies later, she says she is still receiving rape and death threats.

Harassed in a market

Another protester, a 22-year-old woman who requested anonymity, said her photographs were included in a collage circulated online seeking the arrest of 12 women accused of "abusing" Mr. Modi and taking an "anti-India" stance.

"My posts are filled with abusive comments and rape threats. I have a right to express myself," she said. "I was in a market with my mother when two men approached and started harassing me. Relatives are calling my parents after seeing these videos. But I will neither deactivate my account nor delete my posts," said the content creator, who has over 3 lakh followers.

Posts targeting women participants were amplified by accounts including The Jaipur Dialogues, Hindutva Vigilant, and others, across social media platforms. In one post, Instagram user Rohit Sharma said a list of individuals had been prepared and called on followers to share their locations. Another account, Indic Matrix, claimed to know a participant's address and phone number.

In response to queries from *The Hindu*, Hindutva Vigilant said, "I only shared videos posted by the person who filed the complaint and tagged Delhi Police requesting appropriate legal action. I do not possess anyone's personal information."

CWMA upholds order on Cauvery water to T.N.

Karnataka argued that while the southwest monsoon is the mainstay for the State, the forthcoming northeast monsoon would benefit Tamil Nadu.

It argued that Tamil Nadu, therefore, had the "dual advantage" of benefiting from the southwest monsoon in Karnataka in the form of water release and also from the forthcoming northeast monsoon.

Historical trend had shown that in distress years, northeast monsoon had significantly augmented Tamil Nadu's storages, Karnataka argued. Karnataka also contended that Tamil Nadu already had a substantial quantum of carryover storage from its earlier releases.

It expressed concern that though the CWRC had ordered it to release water at a rate of 3,500 cusecs a day, in reality, it may have to step this up to 7,000 cusecs considering the transmission losses due to dry hydrological conditions on the river bed till the Biligundlu measuring gauge, located on the inter-State border. The stipulated quantum of water has to be realised at the gauge, it pointed out.

Tamil Nadu, on its part, stepped up its demand and urged the CWMA to direct Karnataka to increase the rate of daily releases beyond 3,500 cusecs while highlighting the prevailing hydrological distress in its basin and sought a release of 9.45 tmcft under the distress formula in the next 15 days at a rate of 7,000 cusecs a day.

Centre defends CEC panel without CJI

Union govt. says if the decision of the Prime Minister cannot be trusted, then an 'outsider' or a former judge must sit in to advice on the appointment of Cabinet Ministers too; Supreme Court says that it is not about 'lack of faith' in the PM, but about 'justice not only being done, but shown to be done'

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Union government questioned in the Supreme Court on Thursday the insistence on having the Chief Justice of India (CJI) on the Prime Minister's panel which selects the Chief Election Commissioner (CEC), saying if the decision of the Prime Minister cannot be trusted then an "outsider" or a former judge must sit in to advise on the appointment of Cabinet Ministers too.

The Centre's submission came while hearing petitions challenging the Chief Election Commissioner and other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service, and Term of Office) Act of 2023.

The petitions have contended that the Act "defeated" a Constitution Bench judgment in the Anoop Baranwal case, which had constituted a CEC selection panel chaired by the Prime Minister and including the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha and the CJI. The 2023 Act, passed within months of the judgment, had replaced the Chief Justice with a Cabinet Minister nominated by the Prime Minister.

'Lack of neutral person'

A Bench headed by Justice Dipankar Datta had, in past hearings, questioned the lack of even "one absolutely neutral person" on the Prime Minister's committee. The court had remarked that a Cabinet Minister would hardly defy the Prime Minister. The court had said the "dominant" presence of the Executive in the selection panel would send wrong signals to the public.

"If the Prime Minister's decision is not to be trusted, why not have someone from outside or a former judge to select the Ministers also," Solicitor-General Tushar Mehta, for the government, asked on Thursday.

> The appointment procedure should be shown to be fair... The issue is that the composition of this committee tilts in favour of one side. There is a two versus one here, two of the Executive and one of the Opposition. Should there not be a show of fairness in the appointment to one of the most important offices of this country?
>
> **JUSTICE DIPANKAR DATTA**
> Supreme Court judge

Mr. Mehta, quoting from a 2014 apex court judgment in the Manoj Narula case, said the Prime Minister's office held constitutional trust and high sanctity.

The law officer asked if a constitutional court, while deciding the composition of a committee in a statute, could presume abuse of power, bad faith and *mala fide* intention on part of the constitutional functionaries.

Justice Datta said the question was not about "lack of faith" in the Prime Minister, but about the principle of "justice not only being done, but shown to be done".

"The appointment procedure should be shown to be fair... The issue is that the composition of this committee tilts in favour of one side. There is a two versus one here, two of the Executive and one of the Opposition. Should there not be a show of fairness in the appointment to one of the most important offices of this country?" Justice Datta asked the Union government.

Baranwal judgment

Mr. Mehta queried whether the Anoop Baranwal judgment could really restrict the wisdom of Parliament to replace the CJI with a Cabinet Minister on the CEC selection panel. Like independence of the judiciary, the Constitution has also envisaged independence for the Legislative and Executive, the Solicitor-General said.

Justice Datta referred to the government's oft-repeated complaint about the Collegium system of "judges selecting judges".

"We wonder whether judges are really selecting judges nowadays," Justice Datta said in a veiled comment about Executive interference in judicial appointments to the highest courts.

The court reserved judgment on the point whether the case should be referred to a five-judge Constitution Bench. Advocate Kaleeswaram Raj, on the petitioners' side, said a reference was uncalled for as no novel question relating to constitutional interpretation has been identified or framed, other than the ones already dealt with in the Anoop Baranwal judgment.

The judgment by a Constitution Bench in March 2023 had declared that the CEC should be a person of "fierce independence, neutrality and honesty". It had called for an end to government monopoly and "exclusive control" over appointments to the highest poll body.

₹700-cr. fund deficit in scholarships for Jharkhand: CM to PM

Press Trust of India
RANCHI

Jharkhand Chief Minister Hemant Soren on Thursday wrote to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, alleging that a funding gap of more than ₹700 crore in central scholarship support over the last two financial years has adversely affected lakhs of students, and sought his intervention to resolve the issue.

Mr. Soren also urged the Prime Minister to enhance the Centre's allocation for pre-matric and post-matric scholarships and resume scholarship assistance for students from minority communities.

In his letter, the Chief Minister claimed that while Jharkhand sought ₹370.87 crore for post-matric scholarships in 2025-26, the Centre released only ₹58.22 crore.

"Similarly, against the State's demand of ₹353.21 crore in 2024-25, only

CM Hemant Soren

₹33.57 crore was sanctioned," he said.

Mr. Soren alleged that the funding shortfall has delayed scholarship payments to lakhs of students, jeopardising their education.

Highlighting the State's financial constraints, he said Jharkhand sought ₹66.14 crore under the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment's pre-matric scholarship scheme for Backward Class students in 2024-25 but received only ₹12.61 crore from the Centre.

For 2025-26, the State requested ₹45.91 crore, but only ₹3.95 crore was released, he claimed.

PTSD, depression continue to haunt pellet victims in Kashmir for years

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

At the peak of the 2016 protests in Jammu & Kashmir, Javeed Khan (name changed) was protesting on the streets of Srinagar's old city when a shot from a pellet gun hit him. Everything went blank, a feeling Mr. Khan described as having "hot iron" inside his eyes, and he lost vision in one eye.

Ten years later, Mr. Khan vividly remembers that day. "I still get flashes of the day when I lost vision in one eye. It felt like hot iron inside my eye, setting a fire-like sensation. I am still under the supervision of psychiatrists in Srinagar," he said.

Mr. Khan is one of those thousands of pellet gun victims who carry the scars and visit psychiatrists and ophthalmologists in Kashmir for treatment.

With the use of pellets against protesters during the NEET protests in Delhi

A study found that among 380 victims, 161 sustained grievous injuries such as fractures and the loss of eyes or ears. FILE PHOTO

grabbing the headlines, a 2018 study on pellet victims in Kashmir is back in focus. The study throws light on the psychological effect of the weapon, which impacted around 6,000 locals in 2016.

Substance abuse, PTSD

According to the study done by the Government Medical College, Srinagar, 30.38% pellet victims who suffered eye injury reported depression, 16.92% adjustment disorder, 13.08% panic disorder and 10.77% post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD).

Out of 380 cases, 219 (57.63%) had suffered simple pellet gun injuries while 161 (42.37%) had grievous injuries. Grievous injuries were defined as those involving loss of eyes, ears, joints, fractures, disfigurement and emasculation as per Section 320 of the now-replaced Indian Penal Code. All other minor injuries defined by Section 319, 321 and 323 were defined as simple, it said.

"It was found that out of 161 cases with grievous pellet gun injury, the majority (65) had depression followed by PTSD, adjustment disorder, panic disorder," the study said.

It said that the majority (260) suffered eye injuries and 100 others reported injuries on their limbs.

"In patients with limb injuries 29% cases had no psychiatric illness and the rest of the cases were diagnosed with mixed anxiety with depression, specific phobias, hypomania, PTSD, substance abuse, GAD, panic disorder, adjustment disorder and depression comprising of around 2% to 16% each," it said.

The research paper, published in 2018, studied 380 pellet victims. Most of the cases were in the age group of 10-20 years, comprising 155 (40.79%), followed by 21-30 years, comprising 154 (40.53%) cases.

Attacks on Indian sailors unacceptable: Jaishankar

Kallol Bhattacherjee
NEW DELHI

Attacks on commercial vessels and Indian seafarers are "absolutely unacceptable", External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar said on Thursday , after a round of telephone discussions with Ukrainian Foreign Minister Andrii Sybiha.

The conversation was held against the backdrop of continued attacks on civilian vessels in the Black Sea and nearby regions by both Ukraine and Russia, which have led to fatalities and injuries to several Indian seafarers over the past fortnight.

"Discussed attacks on commercial shipping and Indian seafarers in the Black Sea. Such attacks by any party are absolutely unacceptable and India condemns them unequivocally," Mr. Jaishankar said.

Mr. Sybiha has pointed at Russia for the escalation of attacks in the Black Sea , which have emerged as the maritime front of the Russia-Ukraine war.

PM reviews impact of West Asia conflict in CCS meet

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday chaired the fourth special meeting of the Cabinet Committee on Security (CCS) to review the evolving situation arising from the conflict in West Asia and assess the preparedness of various Ministries and departments to mitigate its impact on India.

According to sources, the Prime Minister was concerned over the safety and welfare of Indian seafarers in conflict zones. Mr. Modi directed the establishment of a dedicated mechanism to provide timely information, emergency assistance and counselling to seafarers and their families.

Emphasising the need to protect Indian citizens, the Prime Minister instructed all agencies to continue efforts to safeguard them from the consequences of the regional conflict.

The Cabinet Secretary briefed the CCS on the pre-

Narendra Modi

vailing geopolitical situation and outlined measures taken to ensure uninterrupted supplies of petroleum products, including crude oil, LNG, LPG and fertilizers.

LPG, PNG and fertilizer

According to the government, India has diversified its LPG import sources, while the overall stock and supply position of major petroleum products remains adequate.

Adequate crude oil availability has enabled Central Public Sector Enterprise (CPSE) refineries to operate at utilisation levels exceeding 100%, ensuring uninterrupted production of petrol, diesel and other petroleum products.

The CCS was informed that the government has significantly expanded Piped Natural Gas (PNG) connections. The Centre is also promoting industrial substitution of LPG through the expansion of the National Gas Grid, augmentation of LNG import and regasification infrastructure, expansion of City Gas Distribution networks, and time-bound approvals for pipelines and last-mile connectivity under the Pipeline Infrastructure Order, 2026.

The meeting also reviewed fertilizer availability for the upcoming Rabi season. Alternative fertilizer sources were discussed, and the Prime Minister directed all concerned ministries to ensure uninterrupted availability for farmers.

Mr. Modi also stressed the importance of accelerating India's energy independence by increasing the adoption of renewable energy, particularly non-fossil fuel-based sources.

Facing own people tougher than tackling terror, says CBI chief

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

The Director of the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), Praveen Sood, said on July 27 that dealing with agitations involving citizens is often more challenging than tackling terrorism.

"Sometimes I feel that facing terrorists in Jammu & Kashmir or dealing with any insurgency is perhaps even easier than when we have to face our own people, because using force against them is very difficult," he said while addressing the 88th Raising Day event of the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) as the chief guest.

His remarks follow the July 20 march to the Parliament organised by the Cockroach Janta Party.

"CRPF will have to prepare itself to effectively deal with emerging threats and to protect the interests of our country," he said.

"We will have to expand our training programmes, use technology, and strengthen our intelligence to prepare our force to face all these new challenges," he said.

APPEAL

Baby of Shabana, Manipal Hospital No.MH018750825, 14 days is Diagnosed to be suffering from Congenital Heart Disease, TGA large mid Muscular VSD with multiple additional lower muscular VSD'S, Swiss Cheese BD small PDA L-R small ASD L-R severe PAH, He requires to undergo early arterial switch operation with VSD closure. The Estimated cost of the surgery is Rs.6,50,000/-.

Please send donation however small by Cheque/D.D/M.O Fav. **Save Poor Lives** A/c Baby of Shabana, **Our A/c Details:** S/B A/c No. 20000913487, S.B.I., R.A.Puram, IFSC CODE:SBIN0001855, Please Donate by G-pay No,9884607377, UPI Id: savepoorlives@oksbi, Donations are exempted under 80G of I.T. ACT.

SAVE POOR LIVES, Flat No. A1, Ceebros Garden, Door No.14/76, Kamarajar Salai, Raja Annamalaipuram, Chennai-600028, Ph. No. 044 42044165 / 9884607377, Email: savepoorlives@gmail.com, Our website: www.savepoorlives.com

Parliament passes paper leak Bill as Opposition walks out of Rajya Sabha

Jitendra Singh says the govt. has made efforts to free medical education from management quota malice; during debate in Upper House, Kharge demands SC-monitored high-powered panel to probe NEET leaks, police action against protesters

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Rajya Sabha on Thursday passed the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026. The Lok Sabha had passed the Bill on Wednesday.

The Opposition members belonging to the Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) walked out of the House before the reply by Minister of State for Personnel, Public Grievances and Pension Jitendra Singh to the seven-hour debate. The Upper House considered the Bill after the government listed it as supplementary agenda.

Replying to the debate, Mr. Singh questioned the Opposition's contention that there had been 152 examination paper leaks under the Narendra Modi government. "They could not authenticate it," he said, adding that the government has made efforts to free medical education from management quota malice.

He said the government increased the number of All India Institutes of Medical Sciences and both undergraduate and postgraduate seats in medical education.

He said the government's approach laid emphasis on democratisation of education.

Earlier, moving the Bill, Mr. Singh said the Bill reflected the Centre's commitment to safeguarding the interests of students and youth while ensuring merit, consistency, transparency and credibility in the public examination system.

Initiating the debate, Opposition leader Mallikarjun Kharge demanded a Supreme Court-monitored high-powered committee probe into the NEET paper leaks and the police action on protesters. He demanded the resignation of Union Home Minister Amit Shah and warned that people's power would drag him "out of his forts" and make him answerable.

"You are the Home Minister, and despite so much unrest, you are not opening your mouth. Has someone stitched it? He should have spoken openly. In the interest of the nation, he should have borne that insult," he said. Criticising the Centre's intention, he said the Bill was much-delayed and failed to address how to prevent paper leaks.

The DMK did not walk out with the INDIA bloc members, but moved amendments to the Bill, which were defeated.

Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge speaks in the Rajya Sabha during the Monsoon Session of Parliament, in New Delhi on Thursday. ANI

PM says passage of Bill will make system more robust

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday took to Instagram again and said the passage of the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026 would make the examination system more robust. Addressing young students as "*sathiyon*" (compatriots), Mr. Modi said the passage of the Bill was part of many steps taken by his government to address the issue of leak of examination papers.

Amid uproar, Parliament passes Bill making insult to National Song punishable

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Lok Sabha on Thursday passed amid din the Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026, making intentional insult to *Vande Mataram* a punishable offence. With the Rajya Sabha having cleared the legislation earlier, both Houses have now passed the Bill amid continuing Opposition protests that have repeatedly disrupted the Monsoon Session.

The legislation was cleared after a symbolic debate lasting barely 15 minutes. The Bill was passed by voice vote after the Opposition's amendments were rejected, with only two members participating in the brief debate.

DMK member A. Raja, who had moved an amendment to the Bill, protested against the legislation and later tore a document and threw it towards the Well of the House as Opposition members continued to raise slogans after the Bill was passed.

"Today is a very dangerous day for the Parliament of this country," he said.

DMK member Kanimozhi opposed the Bill, calling it a "Hindutva agenda" being brought in under the guise of nationalism. She said the legislation was "against federalism".

"You cannot impose nationalism by bringing a law, the song goes against the secularism of the country. The founding fathers had the wisdom to stop only with two stanzas, but today you are trying to polarise the country by making it compulsory and making it a criminal offence if we do not sing all the six stanzas," Ms. Kanimozhi said.

Replying to the debate, Minister of State for Home Nityananda Rai said the legislation would accord *Vande Mataram* a status on a par with the national anthem, *Jana Gana Mana*.

The existing Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act prohibits intentionally preventing the singing of the national anthem or causing disturbance to an assembly engaged in such singing. Such offences are punishable with imprisonment of up to three years, a fine, or both.

A second and subsequent conviction attracts a minimum one-year jail term. The amendment extends these provisions to *Vande Mataram*.

Kanimozhi

E20 can reduce fuel economy by 2%-6%, says Nitin Gadkari

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Petrol blended with 20% ethanol (E20) can reduce fuel economy by 2% to 6% depending on the vehicle category and vintage, Road Transport and Highways Minister Nitin Gadkari informed Parliament on Thursday, citing a study commissioned by the Centre.

In a written reply to the Lok Sabha, Mr. Gadkari said that "tests for engine durability on dynamometer and vehicle tests on road have not shown any failures due to E20".

The study for evaluation of the effect of E20 on BS-III, BS-IV, and BS-VI E10 (Gasoline) two-wheelers and four-wheelers was carried out jointly by the Automotive Research Association of India (ARAI), Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers (SIAM), and Indian Oil Corporation Ltd. (IOCL).

This study also found that E20 fuel provides better acceleration, improved ride quality, and approximately 30% lower carbon emissions compared with E10 fuel. "Higher ethanol blends also enable cleaner and more complete combustion," Mr. Gadkari's reply stated.

The replies were given in response to questions raised by Lok Sabha member Chandra Sekhar. However, the Minister did not answer queries on why the study has not been placed in the public domain.

Nitin Gadkari

Opposition protests police action on students, Ram Temple donation theft

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Stepping up its attack on the Narendra Modi government over the alleged donation theft at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya and the police excesses during the recent student protests against the NEET paper leak, the Opposition MPs on Thursday staged a protest at the Makar Dwar, the main entrance to the Parliament House.

Congress general secretaries K.C. Venugopal and Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, Samajwadi Party leader Dharmendra Yadav, Trinamool Congress leader Sagarika Ghose, and Jharkhand Mukti Morcha's Mahua Maji were among those who participated.

The MPs raised slogans such as "*chadhawa chor, gaddi chor*", "*Grih Mantri sadan mein aao*" (Home Minister come to the House), and "who gave the order?", demanding an explanation for the use of force against protesting students.

They also carried a large banner reading "who gave the order" and displayed a donation box, into which they placed money to symbolically highlight their allegations regarding temple donations.

In a post on X, Mr. Venugopal questioned the absence of Home Minister Amit Shah from Parliament, referring to him as "MIA (missing in action)", and asked who had ordered the use of pellet guns against students. He also alleged that the government had prevented Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi from speaking in the Lok Sabha on Wednesday.

The protest was also used to reiterate allegations of irregularities in the management of donations at the Ram Temple. The space outside Makar Dwar also saw a sharp exchange between Ms. Vadra and suspended Trinamool Congress MP Kalyan Banerjee, who was holding a separate demonstration over his suspension.

Mr. Banerjee was wearing a poster carrying photographs of 20 Trinamool MPs who have joined the NCPI and describing them as "traitors from Bengal". Seeing the poster, a visibly amused Ms. Vadra told the suspended MP that many of the leaders had left the Congress to join the Trinamool.

Mr. Banerjee told Ms. Vadra that the Congress would not be in its current position had Mamata Banerjee not been expelled from the party in 1997.

Responding to his remarks, Ms. Vadra recalled that former Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi had extended "love and respect" to Ms. Banerjee during her time in the Congress.

Opposition leaders stage protest over the alleged embezzlement of donations at Ayodhya's Ram Temple, in New Delhi on Thursday. PTI

Academics criticise Priyanka's remark on IIT-Madras Director

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A collective of 215 citizens, scholars, and intellectuals, including Vice-Chancellors of leading universities and Directors of IIMs and IITs, issued an open letter to Congress MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra on Thursday, condemning her remarks about IIT-Madras Director V. Kamakoti.

The letter criticised her jibe in the Lok Sabha on July 28, reportedly referring to Professor Kamakoti as a "*gaumutra* expert", during a discussion on the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026.

"To dismiss a scholar through a label rather than engage with the substance of his views risks undermining the very scientific temper that our Constitution calls upon every citizen to develop," the letter said. The signatories include R.S. Dubey, Chancellor, National Institute of Educational Planning and Administration; V.K. Malhotra, Chairman, Madhya Pradesh State Food Commission; Sachin Chaturvedi, Vice-Chancellor, Nalanda University; Rajiv Kumar, former Vice-Chairman, Niti Aayog; Alok K. Rai, Director, IIM-Calcutta; and Rajat Moona, Director, IIT-Gandhinagar.

BJP leader files privilege notice against Rahul Gandhi

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

BJP MP and former Union Minister Anurag Thakur on Thursday submitted a notice of breach of privilege and contempt of the House against Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi in the Lok Sabha.

Mr. Thakur submitted the notice to Speaker Om Birla against Mr. Gandhi for the "use of unparliamentary and derogatory language and levelling grave and unsubstantiated allegations" against Home Minister Amit Shah.

Mr. Thakur said Mr. Gandhi violated Rule 352 of the Lok Sabha Rules of Procedure.

On Wednesday, during the debate on The Public Examination (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026, Mr. Gandhi had launched a scathing attack on the government over the students' protest in the capital last week.

'SC clean chit for Singh must trigger reform of criminal justice system'

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court's "decisive and merited vindication" of former Prime Minister Manmohan Singh in an "utterly untenable" criminal prosecution should prompt a wider reckoning with the country's criminal justice system, senior advocate and former Union Law Minister Ashwani Kumar said on Thursday.

The court on Wednesday provided Manmohan Singh posthumous relief by agreeing with two back-to-back closure reports filed by the CBI in 2014 giving him a clean chit, while highlighting there was no "sufficient material or good reason" to register a corruption case against him in connection with the coal block allocation scam.

Calling the order a "vindication of truth", Mr. Kumar said the case underscored the dangers of a system in which the process of prosecution itself could become punishment, particularly when allegations were amplified through a media trial.

Ex-Union Law Minister Ashwani Kumar

Former Information and Broadcasting Minister Manish Tewari recalled Singh's press conference in January 2014 in which he had said history would be kinder to him than the media and his contemporaries.

"The Supreme Court's decision to close a completely spurious case against him vindicates the honour of a gentleman who steered the ship of the Indian state through some of its most turbulent times," he said, adding, "It came a little too late, as Dr. Manmohan Singh had already left us."

Mr. Kumar said the verdict should trigger reforms to effectively curb media trials, which threaten the fundamental rights to reputation, privacy and dignity.

STATE URBAN DEVELOPMENT AGENCY (SUDA)
(UD&MA Deptt., Govt. of West Bengal)
ILGUS Bhavan, HC - Block, Sector III, Salt Lake, Kolkata -106
e-mail ID: wbsudadir@gmail.com, Tel: (033) 66366600

:: EXPRESSION OF INTEREST (EOI) ::

Applications are invited from agencies/startups/NGOs/Social enterprises/ organizations interested in the below mentioned works-

SN	Work details	Memo No.
1	Design, Supply, Installation, Commissioning, Operation and Maintenance of Agarbatti Manufacturing Units for Processing of Waste Puja Flowers with Employment Generation for Women Self-Help Groups (SHGs)	SUDA-15014(17)/ 80/2026/6078 dated 29.07.2026
2	Supply, Installation, Operation and Maintenance of Reverse Vending Machines (RVMs) with Cloth Bag Dispensing System.	SUDA-11014(24)/ 1/2026/6079 dated 29.07.2026

- Interested organizations are requested to submit their profile, experience, proposed business model, and implementation plan to **wbsudatenders@gmail.com** only.
- Last date for submission of application is **06.08.2026** (05:30 evening). Other details are available at website **https://www.sudawb.org** and **https://www.wburbanservices.gov.in**
- For further details or submission-related queries, interested organizations may contact Sri S. K. Mishra (Mob.: 98367 23252) or Sri K. Mahata (Mob.: 79083 70124).

Sd/-
Director, SUDA

TAMIL NADU NEWSPRINT AND PAPERS LIMITED
Kagithapuram – 639 136, Karur Dist, Tamil Nadu
Ph: 04324-277001 (10 Lines).

NOTICE INVITING TENDER

Tender No	Material Description	Due Date
262713 002853	Re-covering of Suction Press Roll Shell in Paper Machine no.1	13.08.26
262713 002860	Procurement of Stretch Film 50 Microns 50CM Width 50/24CM Dia for Unit-I	12.08.26
262713 002894	Procurement of Hydrogen Peroxide 50% for Unit I and Unit II	13.08.26

Corrigendum if any will be issued in TNPL Website & NIC Portal only. Detailed Terms & conditions are available in tender document at our websites: www.tnpl.com / www.tenders.tn.gov.in, www.tntenders.gov.in/nicgep/app

DIPR/ 2391 /Tender/2026

PUNJAB STATE WAREHOUSING CORPORATION
SCO 74-75, BANK SQUARE, SECTOR-17B CHANDIGARH
PBX: 0172-5197847, 5197846

NOTICE INVITING TENDER

PSWC invites online tenders through GeM Portal for creation of 1.95 LMT godown capacities at 05 locations in the State of Punjab for guaranteed lease of 10 years on Build, Own and Operate / Lease basis for storage requirements of FCI under two bid system 'Technical Bid' and 'Financial Bid'

NIT (alongwith GeM Bid IDs) is available on Department's website i.e. **https://pswc.in**

PSWC reserves the right to scrap the tender at any stage without assigning any reason and PSWC will not be held liable for any costs and consequences incurred by the intending bidders.

Note: Any corrigendum(s) / Notification(s) to this Notice Inviting E-Tender shall be published Department's website & GeM Portal.

1004/12/2026-27/13828 Managing Director, PSWC

WATCO
OFFICE OF THE MANAGING DIRECTOR, WATCO
Ground Floor, Unnati Bhawan,
H.B.Colony, Satyanagar, Bhubaneswar-751007, Odisha, India
Telefax: - +91-674-2571444; E-mail – mdwatcoodisha@gmail.com ;

INVITATION FOR BID (IFB) - Bid Identification No. WATCO(W)-12/2026-27, Dtd.29.07.2026

WATCO No. 9102 / Date: 29.07.2026

- Name of the work :-
  1. Water Supply to Football Training Centre at Mandalia Ground, Sambalpur.
- Estimated Cost : Rs.158.13 Lakhs
- Period of completion : 09 (Nine) Months
- Date & Time of availability of bid document in the portal. : From 5.00 PM of Dt.03.08.2026 to 5.00 PM of 18.08.2026
- Last date / time of receipt of bids in the portal : 5.00 PM of 18.08.2026
- Date & Time of opening of technical bids : 12.30 PM of 20.08.2026
- Name and Address of the Officer Inviting Bid : MD, WATCO, Telefax:- 0674-2571444. E-Mail : mdwatcoodisha@gmail.com
- The bidders have to participate in ONLINE bidding only.

Further details can be seen from the web site www.tendersodisha.gov.in .

Sd/-
(Managing Director), WATCO

13001/1335/2627 DIPR-13001/13263/1/26-27/0012

राष्ट्रीय स्वास्थ्य मिशन, राजस्थान
स्वास्थ्य एवं परिवार कल्याण विभाग, स्वास्थ्य भवन, तिलक मार्ग,
राजस्थान, जयपुर फोन न. 0141-2225736, E-Mail ID: cemhraj@gmail.com

No:- 1938 Date:- 21.07.26

E-NIT No-17/2026-27 on EPC MODE

राजस्थान के राज्यपाल महोदय की ओर से भवन निर्माण कार्य हेतु उपर्युक्त श्रेणी में राजस्थान में पंजीकृत संवेदकों एवं राज्य सरकार / केन्द्र सरकार के अधिकृत सगठनों / केन्द्रीय लोक निर्माण विभाग / डाक एवम् दूर संचार विभाग/ रेलवे इत्यादि में पंजीकृत संवेदकों, जो कि राजस्थान सरकार के ए, एए श्रेणी के संवेदकों के समकक्ष हो, से निर्धारित प्रपत्र मे भवन निर्माण कार्य के लिए **EPC Mode** पर ई-प्रोक्युरमेन्ट प्रकिया से ऑन लाईन निविदायें आमंत्रित की जाती है।

कुल कार्यों की संख्या	01
निविदा की कुल लागत (राशि रु. लाख में)	2300.00
ऑनलाईन निविदा आवेदन डाउनलोड एवं अपलोड करने की तिथि	22 जुलाई 2026 से 09 अगस्त 2026 सायं 6:00 बजे तक
ऑनलाईन निविदा खोलने की तिथि	10 अगस्त 2026 पूर्वाह्न 11:00 बजे

निविदा से सम्बन्धित विवरण वेब साईट http://dipr.rajasthan.gov.in, http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in व https://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in पर देखा जा सकता है । सम्पूर्ण निविदा प्रक्रिया http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in पर ऑनलाइन सम्पादित की जायेगी।

UBN:-

S.No.	UBN Number
1	MHS2627WLOB02756

मुख्य अभियंता
चिकित्सा एवं स्वास्थ्य
राजस्थान, जयपुर

DIPR/C/13098/26/A/E

IN BRIEF

Tejpal acquittal: HC reserves order on Goa govt.'s appeal

The Bombay High Court on Thursday reserved its order on the Goa government's appeal against the acquittal of journalist Tarun Tejpal in a 2013 sexual assault case. Justices Dr. Neela Gokhale and Amit Jamsandekar of the Goa Bench reserved the order after hearing arguments from both sides which mainly dwelt on whether the former Tehelka editor's "apology e-mail" to the complainant amounted to an admission of guilt. The Bench did not specify when the order will be pronounced. A court in Mapusa, Goa, acquitted Mr. Tejpal of all charges in 2021, following which the State filed an appeal. PTI

Rajnath felicitates all women crew for sailing expedition

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Thursday felicitated nine women officers of the Indian Army, Navy, and Air Force for successfully completing the country's first-ever Tri-Service all-women circumnavigation sailing expedition – 'Samudra Pradakshina'. He described their achievement as a shining example of Nari Shakti and jointness among the armed forces. Mr. Singh spoke to the officers in New Delhi and commended them for completing the 314-day voyage aboard the Indian Army Sailing Vessel (IASV) Triveni. They sailed nearly 25,500 nautical miles across four oceans.

No plans to reopen higher pension window: EPFO CEO

Ramesh Krishnamurthi says EPF Scheme, 2026 is focused on continuity; Social Security Code has introduced a very harmonised definition of wage, giving govt. flexibility to change wage ceiling

A.M. Jigeesh
NEW DELHI

Allaying concerns raised by the trade unions that the Social Security Code and the newly drafted schemes of the Employees Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO) and its schemes will further shrink the social security ambit, the Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of the EPFO, Ramesh Krishnamurthi, said the EPF Scheme, 2026 is focused on continuity.

He said the core provisions of the EPS Scheme 1952, which was there for nearly seven decades, have not been touched. "The contributions remain at 12%. The wage ceiling as of now is also as per the earlier wage ceiling notified in 2014, which is ₹15,000. Earlier also this concept of voluntary PF contributions existed. Irrespective of the wage or the salary, most employers used to offer provident fund as a 12% of your wages. It's not a new provision. There's nothing which has changed. It's always existed," Mr. Krishnamurthi said.

EPFO CEO Ramesh Krishnamurthi speaks during an event of "The Hindu MIND Series", in New Delhi on Tuesday. SHIV KUAMR PUSHPAKAR

Maintaining that PF is one of the best avenues for retirement savings, he hoped that most employers are not going to change their entire contractual terms because the new scheme has now come. "Of course, if any new employer or any new employee wants to have a different approach, the scheme does provide that flexibility," he said when asked about the reports that employers can keep their share of contributions to the PF at the bare minimum.

He said the Social Security Code introduced a very harmonised definition of wage. "It has provided the expansion of social security coverage to unorganised workers, and to gig and platform workers. EPFO is changing," he said. He added that the Code on Social Security gives the government the flexibility to change the wage ceiling. "As far as minimum pension and wage ceiling are concerned, these are policy decisions determined by the government based on budgetary support. So this is for the government to take a hold," he added.

When asked if the EPFO will open the window for higher pension again, he declined and said the employee pension scheme is a pooled fund, which is formed by the contribution of each one of the members of the pension scheme. "We have processed almost all applications, nearly 4.4 lakh demand letters were issued. Every payout for a member earning higher pension is costing the pension fund nearly ₹25 lakh. It's a defined benefit scheme and the money is coming out of the same pool. It is not a corpus which is funded by the government. If I drain that corpus to fulfil the pension for a few people now, what happens when the time comes when the current members retire? So, it can't be a Ponzi scheme," the CEO said.

"EPS is meant for the poorer sections of formal sector workers. There is a very serious apprehension that there is a lot of money. But higher pension for a few out of this is going to deprive 10 more people or 20 more people of their of the corpus, which is meant for their retirement," he added.

Bhojshala case: SC asks M.P. to consider allocation of land

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

SC said the State's duty extends to ensuring that communities are free to perform their rites.

The Supreme Court directed the Madhya Pradesh State administration on Thursday to meet with the Muslim side to consider allocation of a specific piece of land reportedly near a dargah located adjacent to the disputed Bhojshala-Kamal Maula mosque complex for offering Friday namaz.

The court emphasised that the State's constitutional duty, along with maintenance of law and order, extends to ensuring communities are free to perform their religious rites. A three-judge Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant said its order would not stop the State from suggesting alternative and better-located land agreeable to the Muslim petitioners.

Appearing for the State of Madhya Pradesh, Additional Solicitor-General K.M. Nataraj said the State did not want to go into the rights of the two competing sides and merely wanted an amicable solution.

The previous hearing had witnessed senior advocate Huzeifa Ahmadi, representing the Muslim petitioners, urging the Madhya Pradesh government to "not succumb to bullying" from "one particular side" while considering the allotment of land for namaz.

The court was considering an application alleging that the land currently allotted was 1.3 km away from the disputed complex. On July 14, the court had directed the State authorities to identify an open space near the disputed complex where the Muslim community could offer Friday namaz between 1 p.m. and 3 p.m. as an interim arrangement.

On May 15, the High Court had ruled that the disputed Bhojshala-Kamal Maula mosque complex was a temple dedicated to goddess Saraswati.

Man 'working in Australia' for two years found buried in Jamnagar; wife, 2 others held

Abhinay Deshpande
AHMEDABAD

A family's repeated attempts to obtain the address of a relative they believed had moved to Australia led the police to a grim discovery in Jamnagar in Gujarat. Investigators say the man was allegedly murdered and buried beneath a shed floor, with the crime remaining concealed for over two years.

The police exhumed the remains, believed to be those of Jignesh Mavadiya, on Thursday from a pit around 12 feet below the floor of a shed in the Dared GIDC industrial area. They have arrested the man's wife, Prithvi, alias Bhumiben; her alleged lover, Nilesh Kachhatia; and their associate, Balveer Verma, on charges of murder and destruction of evidence, among others.

The body was buried in 12-foot-deep pit, which was covered with concrete

Assistant Superintendent of Police Pratibha said power tools had to be used to drill through the concrete layer covering the burial site. "To ascertain the identity of the deceased, the remains have been handed over to forensic experts. The victim's wife, her alleged lover, and one of their associates have been arrested," she said.

According to the police, Jignesh, who had a love marriage and was the father of two daughters, had been out of contact with his family for nearly two years. His wife allegedly maintained that he had travelled to Australia for work and could not be contacted because his employer did not permit phone calls.

The alleged cover-up began to unravel when one of Jignesh's cousins, who was planning to travel to Australia, asked Prithvi for his Australian address and contact details.

When she did not provide the information despite repeated requests, Jignesh's brother Ashok Mavadiya lodged a complaint with the City 'B' Division police station on July 26, reporting him missing.

Investigators alleged that on May 31, 2024, the accused lured Jignesh to the industrial shed in the Dared GIDC area on the pretext of a liquor party. After he consumed the cyanide-laced liquor and then died, they allegedly dug a pit of about 12 feet, buried the body, and sealed the spot with a concrete layer nearly one-foot thick.

SC tells States to set up prison oversight boards in four weeks

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday directed all States and Union Territories to constitute a board of visitors for prisons in every district, as required under the Model Prison Manual, 2016, within four weeks. The oversight body, comprising official and non-official members, conducts regular inspections of prisons, monitors the welfare of inmates and reviews living conditions in correctional facilities.

A Bench headed by Justice J.B. Pardiwala passed the direction while hearing a *suo motu* case initiated to address discrimination inside prisons following the apex court's judgment in October last year directing the removal of provisions and practices in prison manuals that perpetuated caste discrimination in the allocation of prison work and other aspects of prison administration.

Senior advocate S. Muralidhar, who is assisting the court as *amicus curiae*, pointed out that despite the mandate under the Model Prison Manual, none of the States had constituted district-wise boards of visitors. He submitted that these oversight bodies were essential for ensuring accountability and effective monitoring of prison administration.

Mr. Muralidhar also apprised the Bench that, despite the court's clarification, several States had stopped furnishing caste-wise data on their prison population to the National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB). Accordingly, the Bench directed all States and Union Territories to furnish caste-wise prison data to the NCRB using a uniform methodology.

Hopeful that Mahanadi water dispute will be resolved within three months, says Odisha CM

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

Odisha Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi on Thursday expressed confidence that the long-standing Mahanadi river water dispute between Odisha and Chhattisgarh would be resolved within the next three months.

An important meeting held in New Delhi was attended by Union Jal Shakti Minister C.R. Patil, Chhattisgarh Chief Minister Bishnu Deo Sai, Mr. Majhi, and senior officials from both States and the Centre.

"We strongly presented Odisha's case, highlighting our rightful share of the river, the future of our farmers, and the need to protect water resources. Discussions have begun to find a permanent solution," Mr. Majhi told presspersons.

Union Jal Shakti Minister C.R. Patil, centre, with Odisha CM Mohan Charan Majhi, right, and Chhattisgarh CM Vishnu Deo Sai. PTI

He said follow-up meetings involving senior officials of the Central Water Commission and both States would carry the momentum forward over the next three months. "I am hopeful that, as agreed by the Chhattisgarh government, issues relating to the distribution, management, and preservation of Mahanadi waters will be resolved within this timeframe. By Diwali, the dispute should be settled," he added.

Mr. Majhi noted that the Chhattisgarh Chief Minister also favoured a negotiated settlement.

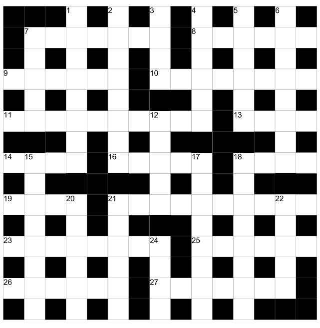
In April, the Mahanadi Water Disputes Tribunal (MWDT) had expressed dissatisfaction after both States failed to submit a concrete proposal for settlement, warning it would impose its own formula if they did not act.

TH CROSSWORD + 14860

(set by Saral)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at *https://thehindu.com/crosswords*

SCAN TO PLAY



ACROSS
7. Old boy rejecting noisy town (7)
8. Rogue caught after a crash (6)
9. Lifts metals reportedly (6)
10. Piece of object next to parking (8)
11. Threaten private holding papers (10)
13. Round bowl over almonds, say (4)
14. Jack covering strong pale gem (4)
16. Worms and flying bugs circling a bit of rasgulla (5)
18. Dividend from a stock finally (4)
19. Met nationalist hiding in hot place (4)
21. At home I have rotating counter that's necessary (10)
23. Each day doctor leading treatment of flu. Terrible! (8)
25. Requests seafood around lunchtime (6)
26. God! Perhaps vanquisher killing a queen without hesitation (6)
27. At first cutting awfully hard, half of edam cheese (7)

DOWN
1. Pamphlet from party is with direction (8)
2. Suppressing question with anguish sadly (8)
3. Fried potato in college over (4)
4. Intense fire spreading near church (6)
5. Possibility of quietly moving back old drink (6)
6. Carver creating top curls (8)
7. Primarily big and thick original neem stick (5)
12. Last letter covered in gold, again in blue (5)
15. New radio set for space traveller (8)
17. Controls son scratching head of jerks (8)
18. Scheme mainly to get vehicle with extremely dubious advertisements (8)
20. Lack of enthusiasm in a course ending in May (6)
21. Arrival of nine having new disease (6)
22. Primate catching bird in both hands (5)
24. Key partner inside blocks (4)

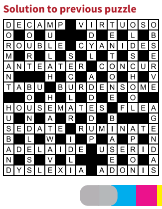
SUDOKU

					8			
9					5	2		3
2	1	5		7			8	
				4		5		
7		9				6		2
		6		3				
	5			2		4	6	8
4		2	8					9
			6					

No.SS6958 Distribution: www.knightfeatures.com

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★☆☆

Solution to previous puzzle



Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

5	8	1	2	3	6	9	4	7
3	7	2	9	5	4	8	1	6
9	6	4	7	8	1	2	3	5
8	3	5	6	4	9	1	7	2
2	4	6	3	1	7	5	9	8
1	9	7	8	2	5	4	6	3
4	1	8	5	6	3	7	2	9
7	5	3	4	9	2	6	8	1
6	2	9	1	7	8	3	5	4

FAITH

God tests our faith

Often our devotion is intense only until we get what we want from God. We then slowly turn our thoughts towards other things. In the case of asuras such as Ravana and Soorapadman, they were ardent devotees of Siva. But once Siva gave them the boons they sought, they not only turned their thoughts towards worldly pleasures, but became evil. Rare are those who are grateful to God for His mercy, said Sumathi Sri in a discourse.

The Vaigai river does not join the sea, because the kings of the region used its water for irrigation, not letting it reach the sea. But a Tamil poet cleverly uses his imagination to compliment the Vaigai for this, and sees this as a sign of the river's devotion to Siva. During the wedding of Lord Siva and Meenakshi, Gundodaran, an attendant of Siva, ate a lot. To quench his thirst, Siva created the river Vaigai. So the river is grateful to Siva, says the poet. The ocean, when churned, yielded amrita, but Siva ended up having the Halahala poison. Vaigai does not want to join the ocean which had given poison to Siva, and so it never enters the sea, says the poet. Even those with bhakti often face difficulties in life. If we look at the lives of the Nayanmars, we find that Lord Siva tested their bhakti by making them face many crises in their lives. But they were steadfast in their belief in Him. Patience and the belief that Lord Siva will never let us down are necessary for us to attain mukti. Arunagirinatha was destined to die by jumping off the tower of the Thiruvannamalai temple. But Lord Murugan changed the fate that Brahma had fixed for Arunagirinatha, and saved him. So, Lord Murugan is One who can rewrite our destiny, provided we believe in Him.

INBRIEF

Hansalpur unit now Suzuki's biggest output facility globally

Maruti Suzuki India Ltd. (MSIL) has cumulatively invested ₹25,288.7 crore in Hansalpur-based manufacturing facility in Gujarat, which has attained 10 lakh annual production capacity, making it Suzuki's largest passenger vehicle production site globally and enabling it to meet the growing domestic and export markets. With start of production at the plant, Maruti Suzuki's total manufacturing capacity across Haryana and Gujarat has risen to 29 lakh units/year. PTI

Tata Steel Q1 net profit rises 12% to ₹2,318 crore

Tata Steel reported a 12% year-on-year growth in net profit to ₹2,318 crore for the June ended quarter on strong product prices. Consolidated revenue grew 14% YoY at ₹60,794 crore. Earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation and armotisation (EBITDA) stood at ₹9,908 crore. The company spent ₹3,579 crore on capital expenditure during the quarter. Net debt stood at ₹84,173 crore. The board approved capacity expansion by 4.8 MTPA at Neelachal Ispat Nigam Ltd. at an estimated capex of ₹33,873 crore.

Dr. Reddy's Srikakulam facility gets 3 U.S. FDA observations

Dr. Reddy's Laboratories has been issued three observations by the U.S. Food and Drug Administration (U.S. FDA) after an inspection of its facility in Srikakulam, Andhra Pradesh. The U.S. FDA has completed a Pre-Approval Inspection (PAI) and Good Manufacturing Practices (GMP) inspection at the FTO-SEZ Process Unit-02 in Srikakulam. The inspection was conducted between July 20 and July 29, the Hyderabad-based generic drugmaker said in a filing on Wednesday. "We have been issued a Form 483 with three observations, which we will address within the stipulated timeline," it said.

Sun Pharma gets Brazilian regulator nod for Semaglutide

Sun Pharmaceutical Industries has received Brazilian Health Regulatory Agency ANVISA's approval to manufacture and market semaglutide injection in the Latin American country. The generic drugmaker plans to unveil the product in the next few days in partnership with Hypera Pharma, a pharmaceutical company in Brazil. It would be available as a pre-filled, multi-dose injectable pen in two strengths (2 mg/1.5 mL and 4 mg/3 mL) allowing flexible, once-weekly dosing. The semaglutide injectable market in Brazil is about $413 million, Sun Pharma said citing IQVIA, MAT June 2026 data.

Debit cards becoming costlier for customers

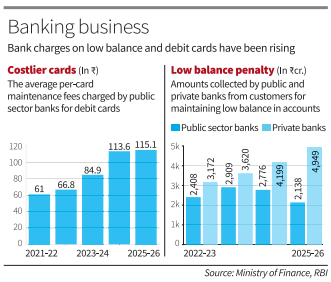
Analysis shows debit card charges levied by PSBs have increased nearly 90% over the last 5 years; low-balance charges collected by both PSBs and private banks rose 27% in 2025-26 from 2022-23

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

Having a bank account in India and owning a debit card are becoming increasingly expensive for customers, data presented by the government to Parliament shows.

An analysis by *The Hindu* of the data presented by the Ministry of Finance to the Rajya Sabha, along with separate data held by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), shows that the average per-card amount public sector banks (PSBs) are charging for simply owning a debit card grew nearly 90% in the last five years.

Simultaneously, the average per-account amount collected by both PSBs and private banks for low balance increased 21% over the last four years. This increase was, however, due to the charges by private banks.



Higher charges

The data presented by the Ministry of Finance shows that the 12 PSBs collected ₹3,905.5 crore as debit card charges in 2021-22. Debit card charges, according to the note, are "annual maintenance charges for debit cards".

This amount increased to ₹7,563.8 crore by 2025-26, a 93.7% growth over 2021-22. However, this increase could also have been because of the increase in the number of debit cards themselves.

To analyse whether this was the case, *The Hindu* mapped the maintenance charges collected to the RBI's data on the number of debit cards issued by the PSBs. This analysis shows that the PSBs collected an average maintenance charge from customers of about ₹61 per debit card in 2021-22, which grew to ₹115.1 per card by 2025-26, an increase of 88.8%.

Low balance alert

The Finance Ministry's reply, to a question posed by Rajya Sabha member Abdul Wahab, also provided data on the charges levied by both PSBs and private banks for 'non-maintenance of minimum average balance'

In total, both categories of banks collected ₹7,086.6 crore under this charge in 2025-26, up 27% over what they collected in 2022-23. But here, too, an increase in the total number of bank accounts could potentially have led to the increase in total charges collected.

These charges are not collected on Basic Savings Bank Deposit Accounts, including those opened under the Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana (PMJDY).

A rough analysis of the low-balance charges collected by both PSBs and private banks mapped to the non-PMJDY accounts shows that the per account charge increased from ₹31 in 2022-23 to nearly ₹38 in 2025-26.

However, the data also shows that this increase was due to the charges by private banks rather than public ones. The per account charge for low balance by private banks increased by nearly 45% in 2025-26 over 2022-23, while the same charge by the PSBs fell nearly 14%.

"Of the 12 PSBs, 10 have discontinued penal charges for non maintenance of minimum average balance in savings accounts, while two have rationalised such charges, in accordance with their board approved policies and commercial considerations," the Finance Ministry's reply said.

It added that, in cases of non-maintenance of the minimum balance in bank accounts, banks have been advised by the RBI to notify customers through SMS, email, letter or other appropriate means.

"Customers are generally provided time to restore the required minimum balance before penal charges are applied," the government said.

Jewellery loses sheen; gold ETFs glitter, says WGC

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

India's penchant for gold in the form of jewellery weakened, even as the yellow metal's appeal as investments gained traction with Gold exchange traded funds (ETFs) witnessing increased demand in April-June (Q1) 2026, according to the World Gold Council (WGC) data.

Owing to high gold prices and excess volatility witnessed in the past months following the West Asia conflict, the overall demand for gold in India fell 6% to 131.4 tonnes in Q1FY27 from 139.7 tonnes in the year-ago period, WGC said.

India's gold demand (in value) for the quarter was ₹1,98,100 crore, up by 50% year-on-year (YoY) . Total jewellery demand in India for the quarter decreased by 15% YoY to 75.1 tonnes . However, the value of jewellery demand increased to ₹1,13,210 crore compared with ₹84,200 crore a year ago, as per WGC.

Total Bar and Coin demand increased 9% YoY to 50.3 tonnes and in value terms it was 73% more at ₹75,750 crore.

ETF push

As per WGC data, total gold ETF demand for the quarter was at 4.2 tonnes, up 49% YoY. In value terms,

In India, the average quarterly price of gold during April-June was ₹1,50,744.8 REUTERS

gold ETF demand was ₹6,300 crore, up by 136% YoY.

Total gold recycled in Q1 fell 17% YoY to 19.2 tonnes. Total gold imports reduced by 23% YoY to 98.1 tonnes.

The US$/oz average quarterly price for the quarter was $4,506.3 in comparison to $3,280.4 in the year-ago period. INR/10g average quarterly price for the quarter was ₹1,50,744.8 against ₹94,875.9 a year ago (without import duty and GST).

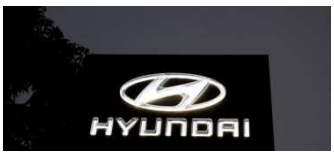
Sachin Jain, Regional CEO, India, WGC , said consumers kept prioritising gold amid high-price environment. "They are adapting their purchasing decisions to balance affordability with long-term value. Although volumes fell to around 75 tonnes, jewellery demand in value terms grew 34% to ₹1,13,210 crore, supported by seasonal buying."

Hyundai Motor India Q1 net dips 35% on output curbs, West Asia

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Production constraints and West Asia conflict impacted Hyundai Motor India Ltd. (HMIL) performance as consolidated net profit slid 35% year-on-year (YoY) to ₹888.6 crore in Q1 of FY27 even as the firm expects recovery from the second quarter.

Revenue dipped a tad to to ₹16,335 crore from ₹16,413 crore. HMIL said temporary output disruptions limited domestic volume growth in Q1 to 5.4% YoY while exports were hit by the West Asia conflict.



Off road: The logo of Hyundai Motor India Limited seen outside a car showroom. REUTERS

Tarun Garg, MD & CEO, said, "Q1 FY27 was a challenging quarter affected by multiple headwinds impacting volumes and profitability. With 100% normalisation of production, coupled with healthy demand t and upcoming product pipeline, recovery is likely to gain pace from Q2 across domestic and export businesses."

Govt. launches Protection & Indemnity cover for mariners

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The Department of Financial Services under the Ministry of Finance on Thursday launched India's first sovereign-backed Protection and Indemnity insurance product under Bharat Maritime Insurance Pool (BMIP), designed by the New India Assurance Company.

On this occasion, Financial Services Secretary Sanjay Lohia handed over the first Protection and Indemnity insurance policy document to Shipping Corporation of India Ltd.

The insurance provides financial protection against third-party liabilities, including Crew and Cargo liability, pollution liability, wreck removal, 24x7 port correspondent network with an indemnity limit up to $1.5 billion, through the combined capacity of the pool, the finance ministry said in a statement.

The event was attended by Director General of Shipping Shyam Jagannathan, senior officers from the Department of Financial Services including Additional Secretary Debasish Prusty and CMD, General Insurance Corporation of India Hitesh Joshi, CMD, New India Assurance Company, Girija Subramanian, and CMD Shipping Corporation of India Binesh Kumar Tyagi.

Since the operationalisation of BMIP by DFS on May 12, backed by sovereign guarantee, the pool demonstrated substantial market acceptance and has successfully met its primary objective of providing uninterrupted war risk insurance capacity to Indian stakeholders, it said.

NTT DATA Payment eyes M&A for lending

NTT DATA, Japan's Shinichiro Nishikawa (L), NDPS India CEO Takeo Ueno (R) with NDPS India, CFO, Rahul Jain. ANI

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI

NTT DATA Payment Services (NDPS), a Reserve Bank of India-licensed payment aggregator, is eyeing entry into lending business and has kept options on merger and acquisition (M&A) route as it looks to diversify beyond payments after scaling its core payment services business.

Speaking on the sidelines of the launch of Adaptis–a unified service brand for payment and commerce solutions–Take Ueno, CEO and director of NDPS, said the priority in India is now on payment processing via partnerships with licensed firms.

"The first step is to provide a service. If the volume is increasing, we need to invest to buy the licensing, in another way," Mr. Ueno told *The Hindu*.

"If we like the business and if we do it, we can go through an M&A route," said Rahul Jain, CFO, NDPS India Pvt. Ltd.

India is the fifth country in which NTT launched the Adaptis brand.

Mahindra Q1 net profit rises 34% to ₹5,455 crore

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Auto major Mahindra & Mahindra Ltd (M&M) has reported 34% year-on-year (YoY) growth in consolidated net profit to ₹5,455 crore in the first quarter (Q1) ended June 30 on strong operating performance across the board.

Consolidated revenue grew 28% to ₹58,188 crore.

Auto and farm sector businesses continued to deliver on growth and margins with profits up 18%, it said. During the quarter the company sold a total of 3,04,000 vehicles, registering a growth of 23% YoY with sport utility vehicle sales touching 1,75,000.

Financial services Assets Under Management (AUM) grew at 13%. Tech Mahindra saw margin expansion with Earnings Before Interest and Taxes (EBIT) improving 330 basis points (bps). Mahindra Logistics showed strong revenue momentum with a 23% growth.

COCHIN PORT
Cochin Port Authority
Applications are invited from prospective candidates for the following posts on Regular Basis.
1. Dy. Director (Research) – 1
2. Marine Engineer - 5
For details visit : www.cochinport.gov.in
SECRETARY
0484-258-2113

KERALA STATE IT MISSION
DEPARTMENT OF ELECTRONICS & IT, GOVERNMENT OF KERALA
Website: http://www.itmission.kerala.gov.in/
TENDER NOTICE
1. Tender for the Appointment of TPA for IT Infrastructure projects of KSITM. Tender ID: 2026_KSITM_862431_1, Tender Reference No. SDC/17/2017-KSITM
2. Tender for the renewal of Red Hat Openshift Platform Subscriptions at State Data Centers. Tender ID: 2026_KSITM_860522_1, Tender Reference No. SDC/25/2020-KSITM
3. Tender for the purchase of 200 TB capacity for HPE XP8 Storage at State Data Center. Tender ID: 2026_KSITM_861802_1, Tender Reference No. DDFS/nSDC/648/2014-KSITM
4. Tender for supply, installation and commissioning of batteries for the UPS at State Data Centers. Tender ID: 2026_KSITM_862765_1, Tender Reference No. SDC/18/2016-KSITM
5. Re tender for supply, installation and commissioning of WAF with SLB at State Data Centers. Tender ID: 2026_KSITM_862932_1, Tender Reference No. SDC/14/2025-KSITM
Detailed Notification and RFP documents can be downloaded from https://etenders.kerala.gov.in/
D3/437/2026I&PRD

DEFENCE INSTITUTE OF ADVANCED TECHNOLOGY
(Deemed to be University under Section 3 of UGC Act 1956)
Girinagar, Pune – 411 025. Tel No. 020 2460 4411 E-Mail:- jr@diat.ac.in
ADMISSION NOTICE
M. Tech in Industrial Systems Engineering For Working Professionals – 2026
Application Deadline: 23/08/2026
Defence Institute of Advanced Technology is an autonomous organization, fully funded by the Department of Defence Research & Development, Ministry of Defence established with the objective of imparting Post Graduate Education in Engineering and Applied Sciences on thrust area relevant to Defence, Industries, R&D and to conduct research in the Core areas of Defence Technologies.
DIAT invites applications for the M.Tech in Industrial Systems Engineering for Working Professionals.
1. M.Tech in Industrial Systems Engineering (Model Based Systems Engineering)
2. M.Tech in Industrial Systems Engineering (Radar Systems and Technologies)
The M.Tech in Industrial Systems Engineering for Working Professionals is a weekend program that does not affect regular working hours. Details of the programme, application form and other terms and conditions are available on the website www.diat.ac.in

BENGALURU EAST CITY CORPORATION
Senior Assistant Director of Horticulture
(Mahadevapura Zone) Bengaluru East City Corporation, Vengaiahan Lake ECO Park, KR Pura, Bengaluru-560036.
No:SADH(MDP/KRP)TENDER/145/2026-27 Date: 30-07-2026
LETTER OF INVITATION FOR SHORT TERM TENDER (IFT)
(TWO COVER SYSTEM)
(Through GOK KPP Portal https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in only)
The Senior Assistant Director of Horticulture (Mahadevapura/KR Pura), BECC (Referred to as Employer in these documents) invites tenders to Implement in accordance with KTPP rules 2000, from eligible and experienced Person/Agencies/Firms (Referred to as Tenderers in these documents) registered in Labour Departments for development of Parks. (Standard tender documents KW-3)

Sl No.	Name of the works
1.	Beautification, landscape development, water facility and other civil works including borewells digging in Hoody Lake in Ward No.29. Amount put to tender: ₹. 1,50,00,000 EMD Amount: ₹. 2,25,000/-
2.	Landscape Development and Borewell drilling and other civil works of Byrathi in Ward No. 28 (in Byrathi Wards 3 parks) Amount put to tender: ₹. 1,50,00,000 EMD Amount: ₹. 2,25,000/-
3.	Beautification, landscape development, water facility and other civil works including borewells digging in Sadaramangala Lake in Ward No. 29 Amount put to tender: ₹. 1,50,00,000 EMD Amount: ₹. 2,25,000/-
4.	Beautification, landscape development, water facility and other civil works including borewells digging in Nagenahalli Lake in Ward No. 28 Amount put to tender: ₹. 1,00,00,000 EMD Amount: ₹. 2,00,000/-

Calendar of Events : (1) Date of Notification on 30-07-2026 (2) Tender can be downloaded from 30-07-2026 (3) Last Date for Queries on 03-08-2026 (4) Pre bid Meeting on 05-08-2026 (5) Tender Closing Date 07-08-2026 (6) Technical bid opening date 10-08-2026 (7) Financial bid opening date: After Approval Technical Bid
Sd/- Senior Assistant Director of Horticulture (Mahadevapura/KR Pura Zone), BECC

Posing a query: An audience member asking a question to the panellists at the summit in Chennai on Thursday. R. RAVINDRAN

Closer look: Participants looking at various displays at *The Hindu* Real Estate and Urban Infrastructure Summit, 2026. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

Rapt attention: Members of the audience listening to a panel discussion. R. RAVINDRAN

Capturing a memory: An attendee poses for a photo at a stall set up for summit participants. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

Sangeetha Kandavel, Senior Assistant Editor, *The Hindu* with Navin Kumar, MD, Navin's; Habib W.S., MD, RWD; Jerry Kingsley, Head of Research, India, and City Lead for Capital Markets, JLL Chennai; and Gautam Agarwal, Chief Operating Officer, Casagrand. R. RAVINDRAN

Infrastructure development should precede real estate growth: experts

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Infrastructure growth in an area usually follows real estate development, but it should be the other way around, with development following infrastructure, said Habib W.S., Managing Director of RWD, on Thursday.

He was speaking at a panel discussion titled "Beyond city limits: why peripheral Chennai is becoming the new investment destination" here.

Speaking at the session moderated by Sangeetha Kandavel, Senior Assistant Editor, *The Hindu*, Mr. Habib said that approach roads, water availability, drainage, and electricity remain key challenges in peripheral areas. "I see the future as integrated development," he said.

Gautam Agarwal, Chief Operating Officer, Casagrand, said that cities and regions with greater employment opportunities tend to grow faster. In Hyderabad, infrastructure was planned and developed before the real estate sector expanded. He said integrated townships would be self-sustaining, adding that Chennai's next phase of growth would be more seamless if it had more integrated townships.

In the past six or seven years, end-user purchases have been on the rise, and for most of them, it is their first home. Many of them are moving from the city to the peripheral areas because they want to live closer to their workplace, he said.

Jerry Kingsley, Head of Research, India, and City Lead for Capital Markets, JLL Chennai, said that 65% of all residential project launches in Chennai in the last quarter were in the outskirts of the city. The city is growing towards the periphery, and these areas will be the engines of growth. The southwest, south, west, and north are seeing growth because of the infrastructure activities taking place in these areas.

Cities such as Singapore have seen growth led by infrastructure and a master plan. Shanghai has seen the development of industrial cities. When infrastructure is retrofitted after an area has grown, the cost is higher. "Transit-oriented development is important as we prepare for the next master plan," he said. The availability of quality education and healthcare along industrial corridors is important. When zones are developed, the focus should be on holistic growth with supporting infrastructure, as livability is important for all stakeholders, he said. According to Navin Kumar, Managing Director of Navin's, while the average age of property buyers in the peripheral areas of Chennai is 35, irrespective of the age group of the property buyer, lifestyle and amenities are among the factors that drive decisions to move to the peripheral areas of the city. The government should provide infrastructure well ahead of time, and master plans should be implemented properly, he said.

The Real Estate & Infrastructure Summit 2026 is presented by Casagrand in association with Adissia Developers. The event is supported by:

- **Associate Partners:** Navin's and Mindspace REIT
- **Banking Partner:** State Bank of India
- **Insurance Partner:** United India Insurance
- **Academic Partner:** Saveetha College of Architecture & Design
- **Industry Partner:** CREDAI Chennai
- **Television Partner:** Puthiya Thalaimurai
- **Digital News Partner:** The Federal

T.N. offers policy stability, transparent governance for urban growth: Minister

Speaking at *The Hindu* Real Estate and Urban Infrastructure Summit, 2026 in Chennai, Rajkumar says the govt. is committed to building cities that provide every citizen with better quality of life; the Housing Minister lays stress on green buildings, better water security and waste management

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu offers policy stability, skilled manpower, excellent infrastructure, industrial strength, and a transparent governance framework for growth and development of cities, B. Rajkumar, Minister for Housing and Urban Development, Tamil Nadu said on Thursday.

Speaking at *The Hindu* Real Estate and Urban Infrastructure Summit 2026 in Chennai, he said, "Our government, under the visionary leadership of our Chief Minister [C. Joseph Vijay], is committed to building cities that provide every citizen with a better quality of life. Housing is not just about owning a home; it is about dignity, security, and opportunity. Urbanisation is not merely about constructing buildings; it is about creating cities that are inclusive, sustainable, resilient, and economically vibrant."

L.V. Navaneeth, CEO, The Hindu Group, presenting a memento to B. Rajkumar, Minister for Housing and Urban Development after the inauguration of *The Hindu* Real Estate and Urban infrastructure Summit 2026, on Thursday. (from left) M.V. Manikandan, Founder and CMD, Adissia Developers; Arun M.N., Managing Director, Casagrand; and Sundar Kondur, Chief Revenue officer, THG are present. R. RAVINDRAN

He added that Tamil Nadu had always been one of India's most urbanised and industrialised States. "Today, more than half of our population lives in urban areas. Every year, lakhs of our people migrate to towns and cities seeking better opportunities, education, healthcare, and employment. The government is committed to making urban governance more transparent, technology-driven, and citizen-friendly."

"We are working towards faster planning approval, improved infrastructure, integrated mobility, better storm water management, enhanced water security, scientific waste management, affordable housing, and sustainable urban development," Mr. Rajkumar further said. "Green buildings, energy-efficient construction, water conservation, climate-resilient infrastructure, and smart urban planning will be integral to Tamil Nadu's future growth," he added.

Role of private sector

Pointing to the significant role played by the private sector in urban growth and development, Mr. Rajkumar said, "The government alone cannot build world-class cities. We welcome responsible investments that generate employment while improving the quality of urban life. Today, Tamil Nadu is witnessing unprecedented investments in manufacturing, global capability centres, logistics, electronics, automobiles, renewable energy, and emerging technologies. We firmly believe that development should not come at the cost of the environment."

L.V. Navaneeth, CEO, The Hindu Group; Sundar Kondur, Chief Revenue Officer, The Hindu Group; Arun M.N., Managing Director, Casagrand; and M.V. Manikandan, Founder and CMD, Adissia Developers, also took part.

'People should be prioritised while planning development of an area'

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

People should be the priority while planning for the development of an area, according to panellists who spoke on a session on "Building economic cities, not just real estate: the future of integrated urban development" in Chennai on Thursday.

At a panel discussion moderated by Prince Frederick, Civic Affairs Editor of *The Hindu*, Jothilakshmy Nagammal, Principal of Saveetha College of Architecture & Design, said there are several concepts and models of development such as pedestrian-friendly, 15-minute cities, workable areas, and transport-oriented development. In any of these, people should be the focus, she said. Pavithra, Co-Founder of Design Co Lab, said people are curious when there is an event in their area. Further, facilities such as footpaths are not just brick and mortar structures.

Prince Frederick, Civic Affairs Editor, *The Hindu* with Arun Bharathi, MD of GTB Urban Developers; Jothilakshmy Nagammal, Principal, Saveetha College of Architecture and Design; Pavithra, Co-Founder Design Co Lab and B.L. Ravi Kumar, General Manager - Network - 1, State Bank of India at the summit on Thursday. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

There is a character for a footpath based on the area where it is located, she said.

Arun Bharathi, Managing Director of GTB Urban Developers, said there are several instances of integrated townships. In Chennai, extent of land available for such development is a challenge. If the development is on just one-two acres, there cannot be many supporting facilities. The developers and the government should work together for the development of an area, he said.

B.L. Ravi Kumar, General Manager - Network - 1, State Bank of India, spoke on the multiple funding options available for developers and builders.

'As a major industrial hub, Chennai can draw global capability centres'

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Chennai is a promising city as the Radial Road corridor already hosts several Fortune 500 companies, said N. Venkat, Senior Vice President (Head, Asset and Facilities Management) of K. Raheja Corporation, Mindspace REIT, which manages more than 30 commercial portfolios in the country, said on Thursday.

He was speaking at a fireside chat on "Why Tamil Nadu is emerging as India's next GCC powerhouse". The chat was moderated by Jerry Kingsley, Head of Research, India, and City Lead for Capital Markets, JLL Chennai. Mr. Venkat said that the city, having earned a reputation as an industrial hub because of the large number of automobile companies operating there and its good engineering colleges, has the potential to attract global capability centres (GCCs).

N. Venkat, Senior Vice President of K. Raheja Corporation, Mindspace REIT and Jerry Kingsley, Head of Research, India, and City Lead for Capital Markets, JLL Chennai. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

"Chennai has evolved on both the residential and commercial fronts, with several amenities coming up," he added. He said the expectations of office-space tenants are high, and last-mile connectivity has become a necessity for a large office-going population.

On interest in Chennai

Regarding the suggestion on whether the Raheja Group, which has been involved in several policy initiatives in Hyderabad, would be interested in Chennai, he said they would definitely be happy to come to Chennai. However, the growing working population is not willing to travel for one or one-and-a-half hours to the workplace, he said.

Affordable cooling will be a pressing issue, says panellist

Kunal Shankar, Deputy Business Editor, *The Hindu*; Anson Sando, Co-Founder and Director, Elementech Circle, IIT Madras; and C.S. Santoshraj, Managing Partner of KeyStone Space. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Smart technologies using AI will help in efficient use of electricity and bring down usage, he says

Smart technologies using AI are making inroads in helping efficient use of electricity even while bringing down the electricity usage, said Anson Sando, Co-Founder and Director, Elementech Circle, IIT Madras.

Speaking at a panel titled "Building the future: how AI and emerging technologies are transforming construction" here, Mr. Sando said the single most pressing issue in the future will be making affordable cooling available to all. He said smart technologies using AI for efficient cooling have been tested in Andhra Pradesh by his company with savings of nearly 30% in energy bills.

Regarding the impact of AI in the construction industry, C.S. Santoshraj, Managing Partner of KeyStone Space, said AI has become part of life for all activities. Mr. Santoshraj said the perspective of job loss because of AI is real but not on the execution side, where construction automation is yet to happen. However, scaling down on the administration side due to crunching of data is a possibility, he said. He said that engaging the service personnel including plumbers, electricians and masons, would become pricier in the coming days.

Talking about the perception that home buyers will not welcome the additional costs when builders adopt smart technologies for residential use, Mr. Santoshraj said that the State government should become the catalyst for making people install the technology by giving tax benefits similar to the subsidy given for roof top solar panels.

Kunal Shankar, Deputy Business Editor of *The Hindu*, moderated the final session of the summit.

REAL ESTATE SUMMIT 2026

‘Today’s buyers are exposed to global amenities, they expect better homes’

Casagrand founder Arun M.N. says there is still a large number of first-time homebuyers in India and the trend may continue for two more decades; gated communities have grown in size and interact more, and the future of urban living will be high rise, he says, adding ‘it is far more healthier’

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Arun M.N., Founder and Managing Director of Casagrand, during a fireside chat with L.V. Navaneeth, CEO of The Hindu Group, at the summit in Chennai on Thursday. R. RAVINDRAN

Today our residential communities are, in many ways, the size of a village,” said Arun M.N., Founder and Managing Director of Casagrand. What was once a village of 500 to 5,000 homes was now being recreated within a single gated development, he added.

“We ensure the whole community [whole village] interact during events and festivals and we even go and organise things for them,” he said during a fireside chat with L.V. Navaneeth, CEO of The Hindu Group, on the topic “Building the next decade: the new growth blueprint for real estate”.

‘Emotional purchase’

Mr. Arun said that at Casagrand, communities were not standalone residential units which were islands. “We have ensured that residents interact through thoughtfully designed common corridors, shared spaces, seating areas, and seating corners across the community. Today, we do much larger balconies. Earlier, a balcony was simply a place to step out and stand. Now, we ensure there is enough space for a coffee table,” he said.

Mr. Arun also spoke about buyer profiles and said there was still a large number of first-time homebuyers in India today, and this trend was likely to continue for the next couple of decades.

“Buying a home is an extremely emotional purchase for people. But today’s buyers are exposed to international amenities, specifications, and great homes. They want greater comfort, lifestyle, prestige, and pride....all of which have become an integral part of the home-buying journey,” he added.

‘Larger aspiration’

Mr. Arun pointed out how different each city was. Each city had its own culture. Though Chennai, Bengaluru, and Hyderabad were cities from the South, they were all different from one another, according to him. “Chennai does not have to show off, Hyderabad shows off everything. Pune is more of business...it is a miniature version of Mumbai. Bengaluru has so much of flashiness,” he said. Though Chennai had been the backbone for the company, Mr. Arun said: “We have a larger aspiration and we have to move to bigger cities. We have moved into cities such as Bengaluru, Hyderabad, and Pune. We have set offices in Delhi, Mumbai, and Dubai. And this will offer larger volumes for us. We have added more verticals like warehousing,” he said.

To a query on the future of urban living in the country, Mr. Arun said it would be high rise. “It’s far more healthier,” he said.

Architecture student Subhapradha presenting a case for skyscrapers integrated with urban farming, carbon sequestration, and cooling landscapes. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

‘Need vertical forest cities with integrated urban biodiversity corridors’

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

As the concrete jungle in Indian cities such as Chennai has outgrown green cover and increased heat stress, these cities need vertical forest cities, integrating skyscrapers with urban farming biodiversity corridors, carbon sequestration, and cooling landscapes.

According to data compiled for *The Hindu* Real Estate and Urban Infrastructure Summit 2026 by final-year architecture student Subhapradha, Saveetha College of Architecture and Design, dense, built-up areas in Chennai showed rising surface temperature, creating persistent heat spots, as the city’s vegetation declined from 25% in 2014 to 10% in 2024 and built-up area expanded from 36% in 2014 to 67% in 2024.

“We need vertical forest cities in India, integrating skyscrapers with urban farming biodiversity corridors, carbon sequestration and cooling landscapes. Chennai already has a built example of vertical greenery at scale with 15,000 sq.ft. of landscaped gardens,” said Ms. Subhapradha.

“Future high-rise developments should move beyond treating greenery as an amenity. Instead, architecture and ecology need to be designed as one integrated system, where vegetation, water management, and building performance work together. Rather than replicating international examples, my proposal adapts these principles to suit India’s climate, ecology, and urban conditions,” she said.

Water-positive cities

“Approvals reward built-up areas over retained open space. Green space and water body norms exist on paper but lack enforcement in many parts of Chennai. No mandated maintenance budget is followed once a green project is inaugurated,” she said.

In a presentation on “Water-positive cities solving urban water crisis through architecture”, B.Arch. student Aldrich Bennet said they have started a study on old temple tanks in Chennai. “We explored the concept of water positive cities and demonstrated how architecture and urban design can help address Chennai’s growing water crisis. It begins by explaining India’s traditional water systems – temple tanks, lakes, *eris*, and canals, which historically captured monsoon rain, recharged groundwater, controlled floods, and supported community life,” he said.

“We examined how rapid urbanisation, impervious surfaces, and the loss of interconnected water bodies have led to flooding, groundwater depletion, and the disappearance of public water commons, particularly in George Town, Chennai. Using the 300-year-old Krishnappa Tank as a case study, we proposed a water-sensitive urban regeneration strategy that includes rainwater harvesting, greywater treatment and reuse, permeable streets, wetlands, groundwater recharge, and the ecological restoration of the tank. Reviving historic water bodies as multifunctional blue-green public spaces can reduce flooding, improve microclimate, enhance biodiversity, strengthen community life, and provide a scalable model for creating climate-resilient water-positive cities,” Mr. Bennet said.

Developer looks to expand frontiers beyond Coimbatore

M.V. Manikandan, Founder of Adissia Developers, speaking at a session moderated by M. Soundariya Preetha, Deputy Chief of Bureau (Coimbatore), *The Hindu*. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Adissia Developers, a relatively new player in the market which started its journey in Coimbatore, is aiming to be a ₹1,000 crore firm in the next two years. “Currently, our turnover is ₹520 crore and we will be a ₹1,000 crore company in two years. We expect our turnover to be around ₹2,500 crore in 4-5 years,” M.V. Manikandan, Founder and CMD of Adissia Developers, said.

Mr. Manikandan, who is a first generation entrepreneur, said that in two years, Adissia has managed to have a significant presence in Coimbatore and Tiruchi. “Now we are going to shift our headquarters to Chennai,” he said during a fireside chat with M. Soundariya Preetha, Deputy Chief Of Bureau (Coimbatore), *The Hindu*, on the topic “Land as the next asset class: Why plotted developments are leading Tamil Nadu’s Growth”.

“We were into real estate 6-7 years back also in a very small way. And we knew that plots would work. We do residential plots. We do commercial layouts too. In the next 10 days we are launching in Madurai,” Mr. Manikandan said. The firm aims to be in all Tier-2 towns of Tamil Nadu. Talking about emerging trends, he said farm plots are witnessing strong demand in Tamil Nadu. Adissia is now foraying into premium apartments. “We are looking at apartments above ₹5 crore. This will happen in Chennai,” he said.

T.N. govt. must create land banks to boost commercial realty: experts

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

M. Soundariya Preetha, Deputy Chief of Bureau (Coimbatore), *The Hindu* with Julian Pradeep Francis, Associate Director, RMZ; Kanchana Krishnan, Commercial Head, ANAROCK; Arun Prasad, Principal Architect, Arun & Associates, Coimbatore; and M. Sabareeswaran, Senior Vice-President, Leasing Business Development, Casagrand Commercial at the summit on Thursday. R. RAVINDRAN

While cities in Tamil Nadu are witnessing robust demand for commercial real estate, high land costs are constraining the supply of commercial spaces. To address this and sustain the momentum, the State government needs to create large land banks, speakers at the Real Estate and Urban Infrastructure Summit, 2026, organised by *The Hindu* and held at ITC Grand Chola in Chennai on Thursday, said.

Discussing the topic “The new growth triangle: manufacturing, GCCs and real estate”, the speakers pointed out that while there is no single solution to the land supply issue, Gujarat’s land pooling model and land leasing mechanisms could help overcome high land costs that dictate the supply of land for commercial real estate development.

Arun Prasad, Principal Architect, Arun & Associates, Coimbatore, said the State should follow the example of Gujarat, which has made land pooling a success. Mr. Prasad said that by pooling 1,000 to 2,000 acres of land from various landowners, Global Capability Centres (GCCs) have been created. The land pooling model has been a success because landowners retain ownership of their land even as development takes place, creating value for their property.

Long-term lease of land

Julian Pradeep Francis, Associate Director, RMZ, wanted the State government to create large land parcels and give them on long-term lease to developers for commercial infrastructure development, which would pave the way for the city’s development. He said sustainable development has been ingrained in RMZ, which develops commercial real estate, and that it is slowly being adopted in the residential sector as well. He said that, with regard to GCCs, Pune and Gurugram have already crossed the 100 million sq.ft. mark, while Chennai has slowed down.

Kanchana Krishnan, Commercial Head of ANAROCK, pointed out that the country has become a value creator as it has moved from business process outsourcing (BPO) centres to research and development (R&D) hubs. While Hyderabad and Bengaluru are doing well in terms of GCCs, Chennai continues to witness good supply in certain pockets. She said all the city’s extended areas are bound to witness significant commercial space development.

M. Sabareeswaran, Senior Vice-President, Leasing Business Development, Casagrand Commercial, said integrated construction development, encompassing theme parks, malls, and hotels, has been happening in China, and this needs to be replicated in all the cities of the State, including Tiruchi and Madurai. Mr. Sabareeswaran pointed out that Thoothukudi is emerging as a promising destination for the hospitality sector.

The talk was moderated by M. Soundariya Preetha, Deputy Chief of Bureau (Coimbatore), *The Hindu*. Ms. Preetha said Tiruppur is an example of energy sustainability, where renewable energy generation far exceeds consumption and helps evacuate excess power to the State grid.

‘Insurance penetration remains low despite rapid growth in real estate sector’

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Insurance penetration in India remains low despite the rapid growth of the real estate sector, with non-life insurance penetration at less than 1%, V.N. Sandeep, Deputy General Manager, United India Insurance, said here on Thursday.

Speaking at a session moderated by Kunal Shankar, Deputy Business Editor, *The Hindu*, Mr. Sandeep said, “General insurance penetration is only 1%. And life insurance is hardly 2.7%.” He added that while insurance had “penetrated into the urban areas, especially when we talk about projects, big projects, infrastructure projects, or factories and plants”, awareness of home insurance remained low.

Over 200 products

Mr. Sandeep said United India Insurance, headquartered in Chennai, offered more than 200 retail and commercial insurance products, including home, cyber, health, event and wedding insurance.

“The main challenge is how to create awareness among the general public,” Mr. Sandeep said, adding that the company was expanding its reach through micro-offices, insurance agents and brokers. He also referred to the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India’s “Insurance for All by 2047” programme.

Drawing a distinction between insurance and e-commerce purchases, Mr. Sandeep said insurance “should not be purchased” like products on Amazon or Flipkart. “Insurance is based on trust,” he said, adding that buyers should consider a company’s experience, claim settlement capacity and claim settlement ratio. United India Insurance published a claim settlement ratio of 95% every year, he added.

V.N. Sandeep, Deputy General Manager, United India Insurance, and Kunal Shankar, Deputy Business Editor, *The Hindu*. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

General insurance penetration is only 1%. And life insurance is hardly 2.7% in the country, says Deputy General Manager of United India Insurance

On climate risks, Mr. Sandeep said, “Climate has become totally unpredictable,” with weather events becoming increasingly uncertain.

He said conventional property insurance covered “Act of God” perils such as earthquakes, floods, landslides, inundation and lightning, with claims settled after assessment of damage.

He said United India Insurance had also introduced parametric insurance, under which payouts were linked to predefined weather parameters rather than physical damage.

“The damages are not mandatory. What is important is the event, the parameter,” he said. “If the parameter is breached, you will get the money,” he added.

‘Premium calculations’

Referring to premium calculations, Mr. Sandeep said construction materials, building design and risk mitigation measures such as fire protection systems influenced premiums. He advised developers to assess risks before commencing projects and obtain adequate insurance cover.

For construction projects, he recommended Contractors All Risk (CAR) policies, while Erection All Risk (EAR) policies were suited for industrial projects involving plant and machinery. He described insurance as “one of the options or best options for risk management”, calling it “financial risk transfer”.

BUNIA

Congo says toll in fastest-growing Ebola outbreak has passed 1,500

REUTERS

The fastest-growing Ebola outbreak has killed more than 1,500 people in eastern Congo, official data released on Thursday showed, marking a 50% increase in around a week that shows the emergency continuing to outpace response efforts. As of Tuesday, 3,442 cases had been recorded, with 1,521 deaths. AP

BRASILIA

'Brazil denied visas to U.S. officials over election meddling concerns'

AFP

Brazilian President Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva confirmed his government had denied visas to two U.S. officials who planned to travel to the country, accusing them of seeking to interfere in October's election. A U.S. State Department spokesperson rejected any suggestion of a "ploy" to undermine Brazil's elections. REUTERS

QUETTA

Coal mine blast in Pakistan kills at least 11 miners and traps 31 others

AP

An explosion inside a coal mine in southwest Pakistan killed at least 11 miners on Thursday and trapped 31 others underground in what officials believed to be life-threatening conditions as rescuers raced to reach them. The blast was reportedly triggered by a buildup of methane gas and occurred on the outskirts of Quetta. AP

DUBAI

Drone strike at Egypt's Damietta port raises threat near Suez Canal

AFP

A drone strike on gas vessels in Egypt's Mediterranean port of Damietta signalled a potential new front in the U.S.-Iran war, raising the prospect of threats to navigation through the Suez Canal, a last remaining safe export route for Saudi oil. The Egyptian Cabinet said on Thursday that no party had claimed responsibility. REUTERS

Russian attacks kill 10 in Ukraine; NATO says a missile fell in Poland

The attacks hit cities including Kyiv, where many residents sheltered in subway stations as Ukraine faced a shortage of air defences; NATO, Polish leaders call the incident 'serious' and 'reckless', add that no evidence Poland was the intended target

Associated Press
KYIV

A Russian ballistic missile and drone barrage across Ukraine overnight killed at least 10 civilians, including children, and injured more than 50 others, officials said on Thursday, and NATO scrambled its warplanes after one of the missiles crossed the country's western border into Poland.

The Polish armed forces crew visited the probable impact site in a farming area in Lublin province and found a 10-metre crater.

The blitz expanded Russia's almost daily bombardment of Ukrainian cities, including the capital of Kyiv where tens of thousands spent the night sheltering in subway stations, as Moscow apparently looked to exploit Kyiv's critical shortage of Western-supplied anti-ballistic missile defences.

People take shelter inside a subway station during an overnight Russian missile and drone strike in Kyiv, Ukraine. REUTERS

NATO said a Russian missile entered Polish airspace during the onslaught and landed in a rural area. It caused no injuries or damage but could deepen tensions between the military alliance and Moscow, as wary European countries fear the four-year-old war could spill into their territory.

NATO Secretary-General Mark Rutte called it "yet another reckless act by Russia and a dangerous consequence of its war against Ukraine".

Polish Prime Minister Donald Tusk said it was "a very serious incident", but added: "There are absolutely no reasons to believe that Poland was the target."

Russia's barrage struck areas of Ukraine where weapons are believed to be stored and manufactured. Ukrainian long-range drones and missiles have battered Russia's oil sector, causing a fuel crisis.

The attack came two days after Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy met with U.S. President Donald Trump and representatives of American defence companies as he pleads for swifter and bigger deliveries of Patriot air defence systems to stop Russia's ballistic missiles.

Russia launched more than 70 missiles, a significant number of them ballistic missiles, Mr. Zelenskyy said, and over 280 attack drones, of which more than 260 were intercepted.

U.S., Iran trade strikes as Pakistan says talks ongoing

Agence France-Presse
TEHRAN

Mediator Pakistan insisted on Thursday that negotiations between Iran and the United States were ongoing, even as Washington carried out a "heavy wave of strikes" on its foe in retaliation for fresh attacks targeting Jordan.

The military's Central Command said in a social media post that the U.S. struck dozens of targets belonging to Iran's Revolutionary Guard, including military command centres, missile and drone facilities, and coastal surveillance and defence sites.

IRGC in the northwestern province of Zanjan said three of its members were killed in a U.S. attack there.

The last two days have seen Saudi Arabia join the U.S. in striking militant groups in Iraq, and Egypt come under fire for the first time with a drone attack at a Mediterranean port.

Smoke rises in the city after reports of multiple U.S. strikes on Ahvaz, Khuzestan Province, Iran, on Thursday. REUTERS

On Thursday morning, Jordan reported intercepting incoming Iranian missiles for a second day running, while Kuwait said an Iranian strike that hit a building belonging to a Chinese company killed one person.

The return to direct hostilities followed a brief pause in fighting meant to give talks a boost.

"Negotiations between parties are ongoing, particularly on [the] Strait of Hormuz and to de-escalate," Pakistani Foreign Ministry spokesperson Tahir Andrabi told presspersons in Islamabad.

Israeli strikes kill four in Gaza as talks on peace plan continue

Reuters
CAIRO

Israeli strikes killed at least four persons, including two children, in the Gaza Strip on Thursday, health officials said, as mediators held new talks with Hamas leaders to work towards full implementation of a U.S.-brokered Gaza peace plan.

A Hamas official and a diplomat close to Cairo talks with mediators said discussion were "positive" and "making progress".

The diplomat said the negotiations were ongoing and making progress toward a road map that would see all heavy and light weapons in Gaza decommissioned.

Meanwhile, medics said an Israeli air strike on a tent encampment in Khan Younis, in the south of the enclave, killed a man and an eight-year-old girl, while another strike on Bureij refugee camp killed an 18-month-old child and wounded at least eight persons.

Militants attack security checkpost in northwest Pakistan, killing 9 policemen

Press Trust of India
PESHAWAR

At least nine policemen, including a senior officer, were killed and over two dozen others injured when militants attacked a checkpost in northwest Pakistan, police said on Thursday.

The attack late Wednesday on the Khazina Banda checkpost in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa's Hangu district, bordering Afghanistan, also left 15 militants dead, police said.

No group or individual immediately claimed responsibility for the attack.

A security force member stands guard after a militant attack on a checkpoint at Hangu district in Pakistan's Khyber Pakhtunkhwa. AFP

Inspector General of Police Zulfiqar Hameed said that the checkpost was attacked by Fitna al Khawarij, a term the government uses for the banned Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP) militants. Following the attack on the police checkpost, reinforcements were dispatched to assist, he said. However, the vehicle carrying additional personnel also came under fire, he added.

During the intense exchange of fire, nine policemen, including Deputy Superintendent of Police Diyar Khan, were killed while 28 others were injured, Mr. Hameed said.

He added that 15 militants were killed while multiple others were injured.

President Asif Ali Zardari and Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif have condemned the attack.

Crisis-hit Cuba opens pharmacies and fuel bunks to private firms

Agence France-Presse
HAVANA

Cuba moved to open crisis-ravaged parts of the state-run economy to private firms on Wednesday, as the communist government struggles to ease acute shortages resulting from a U.S. energy blockade.

A lengthy decree lifted restrictions on a swath of sectors including gas distribution, electricity generation, trash collection and the manufacture and sale of medicines.

A U.S. fuel embargo has upended daily life in Cuba, deepening rolling blackouts, water cuts and acute shortages of food and medicine.

The latest reforms seemed designed to target the most affected parts of daily life, and to provide a release valve for growing political pressure.

It was not immediately clear how these projects would be developed, but an economist said they would inevitably need injections of foreign capital.

Sport

Prannoy loses; Kiran, Unnati Devika and Tanvi advance

ANI
TAIPEI CITY

H.S. Prannoy crashed out of the Taipei Open Super 300 badminton on Thursday, while Unnati Hooda and three other Indians advanced to the quarterfinals. Prannoy was beaten 21-9, 21-19 by Hong Kong's Jason Gunawan.

The results: Second round:

Men: Jason Gunawan (HK) bt H.S. Prannoy 21-9, 21-19; Kiran George bt Tharun Mannepalli 21-15, 21-16; Lin Siang-ti (Tpe) bt Anmol Kharb 21-10, 22-20.

Women: Unnati Hooda bt Tanya Hemanth 21-19, 21-12; Tanvi Sharma bt Thalita Wiryawan (Ina) 21-17, 22-20; Devika Sihag bt Ni Kadek Dhinda Pratiwi (Ina) 21-16, 21-15.

Duke Of Tuscany and Dyf may fight out the finish

RACING

BENGALURU: Duke Of Tuscany and Dyf may fight out the finish of the Zavaray S. Poonawalla Bangalore St. Leger (2,800m), the chief event of the concluding day's races, to be held on Friday (July 31). There will be no false rails.

1 CHAMPION TRAINER TROPHY (Div. II), 1,600m, rated 00 to 25, 1-00 p.m.: 1. Turkoman (8) Faizan Khan 61, 2. Best Of Us (2) Darshan 60, 3. Alpha Legend (1) M. Rajesh K 59.5, 4. Force Of Nature (4) Sai Kiran 59.5, 5. Big Sauce (5) Pavan 59, 6. Bruce Almighty (3) Akshay K 58, 7. Double Scotch (7) G. Vivek 57.5 and 8. Shock And Awe (6) Arul 55.5.
1. BEST OF US,
2. DOUBLE SCOTCH,
3. BRUCE ALMIGHTY

2 CHAMPION JOCKEY CUP (Div. III), 1,200m, rated 20 to 45, 1-30: 1. Mystical Queen (3) Vishal S 60, 2. Flavianus (8) Abhay K 59.5, 3. Fortissima (7) Pavan 59.5, 4. Shadai (5) Antony 59.5, 5. Whitney (11) Laxman S 59, 6. Dr Ash (10) Rafique S.K. 58.5, 7. Royal Jewel (1) M. Rajesh K 58, 8. Sustaining Grace (6) Vinod Shinde 57, 9. The Make Sure (9) A. Asbar 57, 10. CR Seven (4) Kiran Rai 56 and 11. Kings Victoryqueen (2) Sai Kiran 56.
1. THE MAKE SURE,
2. FALVIANUS, 3. SHADAI

3 CHAMPION TRAINER TROPHY (Div. I), 1,600m, rated 00 to 25, 2-00: 1. Estelle (1) Aleemuddin 62.5, 2. Art Of Romance (8) M. Rajesh K 62, 3. Blazing Fire (3) Vinod Shinde 61.5, 4. Inicio (2) Antony 61.5, 5. Lex Luthor (6) Vishal Bunde 61.5, 6. Carter (4) Akshay K 61, 7. Joyful Spirit (5) Kiran Rai 60 and 8. Superhero (7) Rayan 59.5.
1. INICIO, 2. CARTER,
3. LEX LUTHOR

4 RACING OFFICIALS CUP (1,400m), rated 20 to 45, 6-y-o & over, 2-30: 1. Double Vision (11) Abhishek Mhatre 61, 2. Master Way (1) Asirvatham 61, 3. Southern Force (7) Antony 61, 4. Star Comet (4) Akshay K 60, 5. Versace (2) A. Hangal 60, 6. Acantha (12) Laxman S 58.5, 7. Breeze Bluster (6) Pavan 58, 8. Coolie (8) Vishal S 58, 9. Ebotse (5) Aleemuddin 57, 10. Sassy (9) M. Rajesh K 56.5, 11. Augusto (3) L.A. Rozario 53.5 and 12. Sling Shot (10) Arul 53.5.
1. MASTER WAY,
2. SOUTHERN FORCE,
3. STAR COMET

5 LEADING STUD CUP (1,400m), rated 80 & above, 3-00: 1. Ricardo (1) Aleemuddin 61.5, 2. Yukan (5) Antony 59, 3. Mandarino (6) Pavan 58, 4. Star Glory (3) M. Prabhakaran 57, 5. Touch Of Grey (2) Neeraj 57 and 6. Regal Reality (4) Akshay K 50.
1. MANDARINO,
2. REGAL REALITY

6 ZAVARAY S. POONAWALLA BANGALORE ST. LEGER (2,800m), 4-y-o & over (Terms), 3-30: 1. Duke OF Tuscany (10) G. Vivek 58.5, 2. Dyf (4) Yash 58.5, 3. Golden Thunder (9) C. Umesh 58.5, 4. Ramiel (7) Antony 58.5, 5. Redefined (6) Akshay K 58.5, 6. Victor Hugo (5) L.A. Rozario 58.5, 7. Gold Empire (8) Darshan 57, 8. Pyrite (1) Neeraj 57, 9. Star Of Night (3) B.R. Kumar 57 and 10. Caccini (2) Trevor 55.5.
1. DUKE OF TUSCANY,
2. DYF,
3. REDEFINED

7 KARNATAKA GOVERNOR'S TROPHY (1,600m), maiden 3-y-o only (Terms), 4-00: 1. Shaolin Star (7) Darshan 56, 2. The Archer (5) Trevor 56, 3. Fine Silver (2) Akshay K 54.5, 4. Immortal Star (3) Yash 54.5, 5. Majestic Legacy (6) Antony 54.5, 6. Moon Oracle (4) A. Asbar 54.5 and 7. Royal Legacy (1) G. Vivek 54.5.
1. IMMORTAL STAR,
2. ROYAL LEGACY

8 CHAMPION JOCKEY CUP (Div. I), 1,200m, rated 20 to 45, 4-30: 1. Hyperdrive (2) Vishal S 62.5, 2. Waitara (10) Antony 62, 3. Quantum (3) A. Hangal 61.5, 4. Crown Angel (11) Md. Ashraf Reza 60, 5. El Rey (7) Akshay K 60, 6. Lauterbrunnen (4) M. Rajesh K 59.5, 7. Magestic Persona (9) Rafique S.K. 59.5, 8. Rocking Star (5) L.A. Rozario 59, 9. Power Of The Sea (1) Pavan 58, 10. Noble Cause (6) Tousif 57.5 and 11. Incredible Luck (8) Yash 55.5.
1. POWER OF THE SEA,
2. ROCKING STAR,
3. INCREDIBLE LUCK

9 CHAMPION JOCKEY CUP (DIV. II), 1,200m, rated 20 to 45, 5-00: 1. Darrington (3) Pavan 60, 2. Carat Love (4) Neeraj 59.5, 3. Lena (10) Rayan 57.5, 4. Jolie's Star (9) Vishal Bunde 56.5, 5. Absolute Katrina (8) Salman Khan 55.5, 6. Desert Kingdom (1) Vinod Shinde 55.5, 7. Elveden (6) Vishwa V. 55, 8. Divo (7) Jagadeesh 54.5, 9. Lockheed (2) Rushal G.A. 54, 10. Aldenn (11) Sai Kiran 53 and 11. Double Your Money (5) A. Asbar 52.
1. LENA, 2. CARAT LOVE,
3. DOUBLE YOUR MONEY

Day's best: **POWER OF THE SEA**
Double: **BEST OF US – INICIO**
Jkt: 5, 6, 7, 8 and 9; Mini Jkt: 6, 7, 8 and 9; Tr (i): 1, 2 and 3; (ii): 4, 5 and 6; (iii): 7, 8 and 9.

LIVE TELECAST

CWG 2026: Day 8, Sony Sports Ten 2 & LIV, 1 p.m.

Durand Cup: Sony Sports Ten 5 & LIV, 4.30 & 7.30 p.m.

Starzella wins the feature event

BENGALURU: Prasanna Kumar-trained Starzella (Antony up) won the Bangalore Summer Million (1,600m), the feature event on Thursday. The winner is owned by Capt. Jamshed J. Appoo, Mr. K. Narayan, Dr. N. Swaroop Kumar, M/s. Blazing Saddles (PF) & Mr. Rustam Phiroze Mehta. Trainer Prasanna Kumar won three races.

1. OWN OPINION PLATE (DIV. II), 1,400M: BLAZING PEARL (G. Vivek) 1, Royal Vanguard (Vishal Bunde) 2, Lysia (Akshay K) 3 and Wanganui (Antony) 4. 3-1/4, 2-1/2 and 1-3/4. Im 24.92s. ₹53 (w), 17, 13 and 12 (p), SHP: 40, THP: 33, FP: 269, Q: 169, Trinella: 899/402, Exacta: 705/294. Favourite: Wanganui. Owners: Mr. Ashok Ranpise, Mr. Daulat Chhabria, Mr. Meka Yugandhar, M/s. DT Racing & Breeding LLP & Mr. S.R. Sanas. Trainer: Prasanna Kumar.

2. SHA TIN PLATE (DIV. III), 1,200M: FOREVER ROYAL (Kiran Rai) 1, Princess Jasmine (Laxman S) 2, Dr. Colchester (Vinod Shinde) 3 and Flamingo Dream (Asirvatham) 4. 1-3/4, 1-1/2 and 1. Im 14.76s. ₹21 (w), 11, 40 and 19 (p), SHP: 131, THP: 45, FP: 453, Q: 243, Trinella: 2,592/462, Exacta: 16,408/7,032. Favourite: Forever Royal. Owner: Mr. B. Ganesh. Trainer: Narayana Gowda.

3. OWN OPINION PLATE (DIV. I), 1,400M: ASTRID (Trevor) 1, Heimirich (G. Vivek) 2, Sai Princess (Jagadeesh) 3 and Shining Dawn (Antony) 4. Not run: Battle Crown and Sprezzatura. 1, 5-3/4 and 1-1/4. Im 26.00s. ₹29 (w), 11, 11 and 14 (p), SHP: 30, THP: 44, FP: 40, Q: 22, Trinella: 372/212, Exacta: 308/144. Favourite: Heimirich. Owners: M/s. Rapar Galloping Stars LLP & Sohna Stud Farm Pvt Ltd. Trainer: S. Dominic.

4. SHA TIN PLATE (DIV. II), 1,200M: CHISOX (L.A. Rozario) 1, N R I Jet-power (Akshay K) 2, Hold Your Breath (Kiran Rai) 3 and Embosom (Vinod Shinde) 4. Nk, 3/4 and 1/2. Im 15.47s. ₹106 (w), 18, 18 and 12 (p), SHP: 59, THP: 51, FP: 824, Q: 479, Trinella: 3,491/641, Exacta: 18,810. Favourite: Hold Your Breath. Owner: Dr. C.N. Devayya, Mr. Abhishek Nagaraj, Mr. M. Sudheer Reddy & Mr. Mohammad Abdul Raheem. Trainer: Pradeep Annaiah.

5. LEADING OWNER TROPHY (1,400M): STORM SHADOW (G. Vivek) 1, Final Call (Trevor) 2, Disciple (Antony) 3 and Starvinsky (M. Rajesh K) 4. Not run: The Leader and Bestidentification. Lnk, 2-3/4 and Snk. Im 25.36s. ₹23 (w), 13, 12 and 12 (p), SHP: 34, THP: 49, FP: 57, Q: 48, Trinella: 139/38, Exacta: 476/275. Favourite: Storm Shadow. Owners: Mr. K. Harish Nayak, Mr. H.J. Balram, Mr. K. Manoj Kumar & Mr. Aniruddha Mehta. Trainer: Prasanna Kumar.

6. B.T.C. WORKFORCE CUP (1,600M): SICYON (Trevor) 1, Winfield (Antony) 2, Pledge (Akshay K) 3 and Turf Paradise (A. Asbar) 4. Not run: Alamgir. Shd, Shd and 3. Im 37.56s. ₹30 (w), 11, 21 and 13 (p), SHP: 39, THP: 50, FP: 146, Q: 84, Trinella: 306/161, Exacta: 3,815/1,816. Favourite: Sicyon. Owners: M/s. Blazing Saddles(PF) rep. by Mr. Niraj Tyagi & Mr. Vikas Sachdeva. Trainer: S. Attaollahi.

7. BANGALORE SUMMER MILLION (1,600M): STARZELLA (Antony) 1, Shrishti (Yash) 2, Dardanus (Trevor) 3 and Sensuous (G. Vivek) 4. 3-1/2, 2-3/4 and Nose. Im 37.48s. ₹12 (w), 11 and 23 (p), SHP: 32, THP: 31, FP: 35, Q: 28, Trinella: 136/93, Exacta: 484/234. Favourite: Starzella. Owners: Capt. Jamshed J. Appoo, Mr. K. Narayan, Dr. N. Swaroop Kumar, M/s. Blazing Saddles (PF) & Mr. Rustam Phiroze Mehta. Trainer: Prasanna Kumar.

8. SHA TIN PLATE (DIV. I), 1,200M: SWEET WINNER (A. Asbar) 1, Windcleaver (A. Hangal) 2, First Choice (N.S. Parmar) 3 and Dasadyu (Akshay K) 4. 1/2, 7-3/4 and 3/4. Im 14.03s. ₹21 (w), 14, 13 and 39 (p), SHP: 37, THP: 105, FP: 52, Q: 63, Trinella: 976/933, Exacta: 1,577/764. Favourite: Sweet Winner. Owner: Mr. Dinesh Kumar K. Trainer: V. Lokanath.

9. HOLDING COURT PLATE (1,600M): LOTS OF LUCK (A. Asbar) 1, Unforgettable Star (Darshan) 2, Seize The Grey (N.S. Parmar) 3 and Stalingrad (Pavan) 4. 1-1/4, 1-1/4 and Hd. Im 38.13s. ₹23 (w), 16, 25 and 19 (p), SHP: 90, THP: 31, FP: 706, Q: 411, Trinella: 1,126/398, Exacta: 8,481/3,634. Favourite: Lots Of Luck. Owner: Mr. Dinesh Kumar K. Trainer: V. Lokanath.

Jackpot: 873; Runner-up: 145; Mini Jackpot: 292; Treble (i): 1,837; (ii): 2,878; (iii): 98.

NUMERO UNO

South Africa's le Clos becomes most decorated athlete in CWG

REUTERS

South African swimmer Chad le Clos won a 21st Commonwealth Games medal on Wednesday to overtake Australia's Emma McKeon as the most decorated athlete in the Games' history. The 34-year-old swam the butterfly leg as South Africa took bronze in the men's 4x100 medley relay for his third medal of the 2026 Games.

DISGRACE

Idi Amin's grandson disqualified after headbutting his opponent

AFP

The grandson of former Ugandan president Idi Amin saw his bid for Commonwealth boxing gold end in disgrace as Aziz Abdul was disqualified for a headbutt in his quarterfinal on Wednesday. Aziz was jeered out of the ring after a tempestuous bout against England's Damar Thomas in the superheavyweight division.

FRUITFUL STINT

Rahane leaves with an unbeaten record as India Test captain

FILE PHOTO

Ajinkya Rahane remained unbeaten as Test captain, winning four and drawing two. Out of this six, three were at home and three in Australia. The Mumbaikar began his captaincy stint against the Aussies at Dharamshala in 2017 and oversaw an eight-wicket win which helped the home side regain the Border-Gavaskar Trophy.

SAFE HANDS

Rahane one of 43 fielders to take 100 catches in the longest version

FILE PHOTO

Besides his batting, Ajinkya Rahane added value to the team with his close-in catching and agile fielding. Rahane is one of the 43 fielders to have taken 100 or more catches in Test history. He is one of the seven Indians to achieve the feat. Rahane snapped up 102 catches from 85 matches.

After Glasgow heroics, Sreeshankar sets sights on Asian Games gold

The 8.09m effort earns the 27-year-old the silver behind Jamaican Gayle; home nation's Mackenzie completes the podium; Lokesh, the other Indian in the fray, finishes a creditable fifth

CWEALTH GAMES

K. Keerthivasan
GLASGOW

Weeks before the Commonwealth Games got underway, M. Sreeshankar knew that if he wanted to win gold, he would have to overcome one of the finest long jumpers in the world – Jamaica's Tajay Gayle, a three-time World Championships medallist.

The 29-year-old Jamaican, renowned for his explosive take-offs and ability to produce big jumps under pressure, was the man to beat, and Sreeshankar was well aware of the challenge. Competing in tricky conditions, with the temperature hovering below 17 degrees at the Scotstoun Stadium on Wednesday night, the Indian produced a best effort of 8.09m. It earned the 27-year-old, whose season's best stood at 8.38m, the silver medal, while Gayle clinched gold with a leap of 8.15m.

Stephen Mackenzie of Scotland emerged third with a jump of 8.08m while Lokesh Sathyanathan of India finished fifth with a leap of 7.97m.

Gayle, too, found the conditions challenging. He opened with a jump of 8.08m before managing just 6.08m in the second and then fouling his third. He came back strongly with a leap of 8.15m in the fourth before signing off with efforts of 8.00m and 7.87m in his fifth and sixth attempts respectively.

It was a huge triumph for Jamaica as the country won its first-ever CWG long jump gold and in Gayle's second appearance, after the 2018 edition.

After taking the lead with a jump of 8.09m in the second round, Sreeshankar remained in front until Gayle responded with the leap of 8.15m in the fourth. Needing something special in his sixth and final attempt, the Indian received a rousing ovation from the crowd, who clapped rhythmically in the hope that he would come up with something special. He gave it everything, but could manage only 7.97m, thereby settling for the silver.

Sreeshankar said he was grateful for the silver medal after a major knee injury that threatened his career in the year 2024. "The silver medal really means a lot to me. To win a medal for the country after a major injury like patellar tendon [in his left knee] is very special. And for everyone who supported me during the tough times and everyone who said that I won't be jumping again ever in my career, this medal is for them," he said.

The 2023 Asian Games silver medallist admitted that his performance in Glasgow would not be enough to secure a podium finish at the Asian Games in Japan.

"I have to jump much better and farther than I did here if I want to win a medal for my country at the 2026 Asian Games," he said.

Having clinched back-to-back silver at the CWG, Sreeshankar will turn his attention to the Asiad, hoping to convert it to a gold.

Leap of faith: Sreeshankar feels it is special to win a medal after a major knee injury threatened his career. PTI

Celebration time: Gavit set a Games record to take the top spot while Basil produced his season's best to finish second. ANI

Gavit, Basil complete 1-2 in men's 100m T47

Press Trust of India
GLASGOW

India's para-athletes continued their fine show at the Commonwealth Games as sprinters Dilip Gavit and Mohammed Basil scripted another story of grit with a gold-silver finish in the men's 100m T47 final here on Wednesday.

Gavit set a Games record and his season's best time of 10.71 seconds to take the top spot, while Basil produced his season's best of 10.83s to finish second in a closely-fought race.

The men's 100m T47 is a para athletics sprint event covers arm impairment or absence, affecting strength, movement or coordination on one side.

Gavit's gold was India's third at the Games, following Mirabai Chanu's victory in the women's 48kg weightlifting event and Sharmila Dhankar's triumph in the women's shot put F57 para athletics category.

Neeraj in final; Rohit, Yashvir also make it

K. Keerthivasan
GLASGOW

India's Neeraj Chopra advanced to the Commonwealth Games men's javelin throw final after producing a best throw of 79.61m to finish fifth in the qualifying round at the Scotstoun Stadium here on Thursday.

Neeraj felt that the "windy and cold conditions" made life difficult for the throwers. "The conditions were quite tough, and it was challenging to judge the trajectory because of the wind. The warm-up, too, was very challenging. Since I was 18th in the throwing order, the wait was long in such tough conditions. It was windy and cold. I am happy that the other two Indians have also qualified for the final," the 28-year-old said.

Rohit Yadav and Yashvir Singh also booked their places in the medal round, coming ninth and 10th respectively among the 12 qualifiers. Rohit recorded a top effort of 78.37m, while Yashvir was just a centimetre behind his compatriot.

Paris Olympics gold medallist Arshad Nadeem from Pakistan finished seventh with 78.63m, his season's best. Sri Lanka's Rumesh Tharanga Pathirage, who arrived with a season's and personal best of 92.62m, topped the qualifying round by hurling the sphere to 82.84m. Anderson Peters of Grenada came second with 81.29m.

Neeraj. AP

Rahane retires from all formats

CRICKET

Amol Karhadkar
NEW DELHI

Ajinkya Rahane, one of Indian cricket's most understated performers and the architect of one of its greatest overseas triumphs, called time on his career on Thursday, bringing the curtains down on a prolonged journey defined more by resilience than fanfare.

The 38-year-old announced his retirement from international cricket and all formats through a video posted on social media. His final appearance in India colours came in the second Test against the West Indies in Port of Spain in July 2023.

"I have always relied on timing in my batting, and I have always understood its importance. Today, I feel the timing is right for me to move on and announce my retirement from international cricket and all formats," Rahane said.

Gutsy and skilful: Among Rahane's 12 Test centuries, eight came in alien conditions abroad. AFP

Few Indian cricketers had to wait as long for recognition despite producing consistently at the domestic level. Having risen through Mumbai's formidable cricketing structure, Rahane made his international debut in 2011 and went on to become one of India's most dependable batters overseas.

His compact technique, calm temperament and ability to thrive in demanding conditions made him a permanent fixture in India's middle-order during one of the team's most successful Test eras.

Rahane played in 85 Tests, scoring 5,077 runs at an average of 38.46 with 12 centuries and 26 fifties. He also represented India in 90 One-Day Internationals and 20 T20 Internationals, registering 2,962 and 375 runs, respectively.

Realising a dream

"Every single day, every innings, every opportunity I got to bat, the dream was always to wear the India cap. I lived by one simple rule: always put my country and my team ahead of myself," Rahane said.

"While my chapter as an Indian cricketer comes to an end, my journey with the game doesn't. I look forward to helping the next generation, sharing the values the sport has taught me, and giving back to the game that has given me everything," Rahane added.

The brave warrior walks into the sunset in his inimitable quiet way

TRIBUTE

K.C. Vijaya Kumar

The last cog in an erstwhile Indian Test batting juggernaut has bid farewell. Ajinkya Rahane's retirement, along with the earlier departures of Cheteshwar Pujara, Virat Kohli and Rohit Sharma, besides Murali Vijay's slow fadeout, marks the passing of a collective baton.

The Mumbaikar, now charting a fresh path as a commentator, belonged to a school of batsmanship lit up by Sunil Gavaskar, Sachin Tendulkar, Dilip Vengsarkar and Rohit. Equally, it was an alumni that featured the gifted Vinod Kambli and technically compact Sanjay Manjrekar, though the two could not fulfil their immense potential after promising much. There was also the doughty Ravi Shastri, who maximised his skill-sets.

Among these varied paths of his fellow city-dwellers, Rahane's progress remained distinct. There was an ease to his shots, a solidity to his tenure at the crease, and yet 5,077 runs from 85 Tests averaging 38.46, while highlighting longevity, also points to a talent that never reached its zenith. Among his 12 Test tons, eight were etched overseas, revealing a batter, at ease in alien conditions.

Soft-spoken and with a quiet demeanour, much like Pujara, Rahane seemed a throwback to a gentler past. But throw him into a fiery battle, and he would reveal his mettle. The eyes would narrow, the half smile would vanish, and then he quelled the red cherry hurled at him. In that zen moment, he extended the Bombay legacy of fortress-like batsmanship.

He did have the shots and his resurgence in the Indian Premier League is a pointer to his versatility. But it was in Test whites, that Rahane left a deeper imprint. The triumph in the Border-Gavaskar Trophy in Australia during the 2020-21 series with Rahane the skipper adroitly marshalling his meagre resources after many key players left due to injury or personal reasons, would remain the biggest talking point in his career.

Turning around a team that was shot out for 36 under Kohli at Adelaide, Rahane led from the front. His 112 at the Melbourne Cricket Ground marked a revival; it was a rejuvenation that had its crowning glory at the Gabba with Rishabh Pant ushering a miracle.

The perfect ending like Stuart Broad's six and a wicket as his last endeavours with the bat and ball, is a rare spectacle in cricket. Rahane, true to his manner, has left in his inimitable quiet way, with grace intact, and memories galore.

Highlights: Rahane en route a hundred at Lord's in 2014. Six years later at the MCG, India rode on the stand-in captain's century to score a memorable win before sealing the series at Gabba. GETTY IMAGES

Rahane's journey in numbers

	M	Inns	Runs	HS	Avg	SR	100s/50s
Tests	85	144	5077	188	38.46	49.50	12/26
ODIs	90	87	2962	111	35.26	78.63	3/24
T20Is	20	20	375	61	20.83	113.29	0/1

INBRIEF

Shrikanth, Kishore shine in Point Break Challenge

D. Shrikanth topped the men's Open category with scores of 9.00 and 7.67 on the opening day of the Point Break Challenge, the third stop of the Surfing Federation of India National Surf Series, at Mahabalipuram on Thursday. Kishore Kumar impressed in the u-18 boys' division with 9.33 and 8.17, including the highest single-wave score of the day (9.33). In the u-14 boys' category, Prahalad Sriram led the way with scores of 6.50 and 6.33. Around 80 surfers from across the country were in action. The competition will conclude on August 1 before the National Series moves to the Covelong Classic from August 6 to 8.

UEFA to boycott FIFA events over plans to sell WC stakes

UEFA member-federations, on Thursday, agreed to boycott all FIFA competitions in protest at Gianni Infantino's plan to sell stakes in the World Cup to private equity investors. "UEFA and its national associations will not participate in FIFA competitions," the European football body said after an online meeting of the 55 members.

Raengdai pulls off an upset win over Indian Navy

FC Raengdai began its maiden Durand Cup campaign with a memorable 1-0 win over Indian Navy in a Group D match at the Khuman Lampak Stadium in Imphal on Thursday.

The results: Group D (Imphal): FC Raengdai 1 (Amarjit Singh 58) bt Indian Navy 0.
Group B (Kolkata): Samaleswari SC 4 (Marat Tareck 10, Gnohere Krizo 45+1, Basit Bhat 56, 61) bt Baghpat FC 1 (Crispin Cleetus 30).

We've made a lot of progress fitness-wise, says Harmanpreet

The India skipper feels the team is capable of ending the World Cup medal drought; says the side is excited to be in the same pool as Pakistan

HOCKEY

Ashwin Achal
BENGALURU

An India-Pakistan clash in any sport evokes heightened passion. For the players, the marquee match is all about keeping emotions in check while focusing on the task at hand.

Their resolve will be tested once again at the Men's Hockey World Cup where the arch-rivals will face each other in a Pool D game on August 19. India has held the wood over Pakistan, thanks to the twin victories in the FIH Pro League last month.

India skipper Harmanpreet Singh felt that the fixture will be "intense", but called on his men to keep it strictly business.

"There will be a lot of drama. We are excited to be in the same pool, and to play on such a big platform. But everyone knows their responsibilities and priorities. We have to focus on the match and play. We have to be mentally calm and focus on our task," Harmanpreet told *The Hindu* on the last day of the camp at SAI here on Thursday.

India will open its campaign against Wales before taking on England. While the duel with Pakistan will have added significance as the last pool-stage contest, Harmanpreet underlined the importance of taking it "match by match".

Under coach Craig Fulton, a special emphasis has been placed on fitness.

Harmanpreet will hope that all the conditioning work will come to use when the side plays three group matches in a short span of five days at Amstelveen.

"If you are performing at the top level, you have to be fit. We have spent a lot of time here on fitness and strength, and we have made a lot of progress."

The 30-year-old is confident that India will break the World Cup jinx and clinch a medal at the global tournament for the first time since 1975. "At Tokyo 2020, we won an Olympic medal after 41 years. This time, our target is to win the World Cup," he said.

Speaking about the much-debated move to replace the iconic blue national-team jersey with a saffron one, the captain said: "We just played a training match with the orange jersey. I think the new jersey looks good".

Battle-ready: Harmanpreet in good spirits at the National camp. K. MURALI KUMAR

India's jersey change from blue to saffron draws criticism

Sports Bureau
NEW DELHI

Even as the Indian hockey teams hope to break their World Cup jinx next month, the sport finds itself embroiled in controversy over Hockey India's decision to change the colours of the team kit.

The new jerseys unveiled are a bright orange that the federation terms 'Saffron' with designs and patterns drawn from Indian tradition in barely-visible tones.

The marks a drastic move away from the traditional blue uniform for the Indian team.

The decision drew a backlash from fans and former players alike.

Former captain Viren Rasquinha was the first to question in a social media post. "...this is embarrassing. The legacy and identity of the Indian team has always been blue. I wore the blue jersey with pride for many years. Fans want to see our Indian team in blue. What is the logic of orange?" he wrote.

The legendary Dhanraj Pillay, too, expressed disappointment.

"Saffron is part of the national flag and I respect that but Indian hockey's identity has always been blue.

"The national team has its unique identity that is different from franchise leagues. Personally, I have never had any issue with blue uniforms on blue turf," he said.

The new Indian jersey. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

> The national team has its unique identity that is different from franchise leagues. Personally, I have never had any issue with blue uniforms on blue turf
> – DHANRAJ

The federation issued an official statement following the backlash.

"The decision to change the uniform colour was based on player recommendations and support staff, and detailed consultations with them. The primary consideration was technical.

"It was observed that the blue playing uniform tended to blend/merge with the blue synthetic playing surface, which is now the standard colour of international hockey pitches.

"This visual similarity affected on-field clarity and visibility for the players," it said.

Root to lead England; Fleming named coach

Agencies
LONDON

Joe Root was on Thursday reappointed as England's Test captain while former New Zealand skipper Stephen Fleming was named the head coach.

The announcement from the England and Wales Cricket Board (ECB) follows the sacking of Brendon McCullum as Test coach and the shock retirement of Ben Stokes from international cricket. Root will resume his role as skipper in the three-match series against Pakistan but Fleming is not scheduled to arrive until December.

Fleming, 53, will take charge of an England side looking to rebuild after a decline in results and a series of off-field incidents.

Root and Fleming have their hands full. FILE PHOTOS

Double delight as Manush and Sreeja lead India to team titles

C'WEALTH TT

Amol Karhadkar
NEW DELHI

Manush Shah won two-in-two as the Indian men edged a spirited Malaysia 3-2 to retain the team title, joining the women's side atop the podium at the 22nd Commonwealth Table Tennis Championships at the Thyagaraj Sports Complex on Thursday.

The triumph also helped India avenge the shock league-stage defeat to Malaysia on the opening day of the tournament. Manush led the charge with victories in both his singles, including a gripping all-left-handed duel against Wong Qi Shen that turned the final India's way.

Earlier, Sreeja Akula-led Indian women overcame surprise finalist Malaysia 3-0. Despite the scoreline, the contest was far from straightforward. Sreeja was stretched to the limit by leftie Karen Anak in an absorbing opening rubber after Swastika Ghosh put India ahead. Yashaswini Ghorpade then breached the dogged defence of chopper Alice Chang to seal the title.

The men's final, however, hung in the balance until Manush scripted a remarkable comeback against Wong.

Trailing 4-6 in the deciding game, Manush appeared to have been dealt another blow when his topspin dipped into the net. After the point ended, he pointed to a wet mark on his rubber, seemingly caused by sweat that had dripped off Wong's face on the ball. Since the point had concluded, the umpire awarded the point to Wong.

At 7-4, with momentum firmly in his favour, Wong responded with a remarkable act of sportsmanship.

Believing Manush had been unfortunate, the Malaysian deliberately served into the net to concede the next point.

That proved the turning point. Manush reeled off seven consecutive points, his forehand topspins proving too good for Wong as he completed a stunning comeback.

Although G. Sathiyan was beaten by Tey Hong Yu and Wong later outclassed Manav Thakkar to force the decider, Manush left no room for another twist.

Facing Javen Choong in the deciding rubber, he dominated from the outset, sealing India's title before a near-capacity home crowd erupted in celebration.

The results (final):
Women: India bt Malaysia 3-0 (Swastika Ghosh bt Ai Xin Tee 11-7, 11-2, 9-11, 11-9; Sreeja Akula bt Karen Lyne Anak Dick 9-11, 11-6, 11-4, 5-11, 11-3; Yashaswini Ghorpade bt Alice Lee Sian Chang 7-11, 11-3, 17-15, 11-5).

Men: India bt Malaysia 3-2 (Manav Thakkar bt Javen Choong 12-10, 11-7, 5-11, 11-5; Manush Shah bt Qi Shen Wong 11-13, 11-9, 11-7, 2-11, 11-7; G. Sathiyan lost to Tey Hong Yu 7-11, 8-11, 10-12; Manav lost to Wong 11-4, 8-11, 11-8, 7-11, 1-11; Manush bt Choong 11-7, 11-4, 11-4).

On a high: The Indian men and women are ecstatic after their triumph. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

Dagar hopes for an IPL return through DPL

CRICKET

Vivek Krishnan
NEW DELHI

After a decade of playing for Himachal Pradesh, Mayank Dagar wants to make a mark for Delhi – his city of birth – in the upcoming domestic season.

The left-arm spinner, who represented India in the 2016 U-19 World Cup in Bangladesh, obtained a No-Objection Certificate (NOC) from the concerned parties in January, paving the way for a switch ahead of the 2026-27 campaign.

The 29-year-old will kick off the new season by making a maiden appearance in the Delhi Premier League. The tweaker, who has claimed 137 wickets in 51 First Class matches, will turn out for North Delhi Strikers in the third edition of the T20 competition.

For the experienced operator, the change is to find a route back into the Indian Premier League. He played three games for Sunrisers Hyderabad in IPL 2023 and five for Royal Challengers Bengaluru in the following season, but hasn't featured since. "I have played for Himachal for a long time and I've done well as well. I was just looking for opportunities to get back into the IPL circuit. If I perform well on a platform like the DPL, somebody or the other will notice me. That is my hope," Dagar told *The Hindu*.

His presence in the DPL – he has represented Himachal right from the age-group level – may not have pleased some members of the Delhi & District Cricket Association (DDCA) at the time of the auction earlier this month. Asked about the 'outsider' tag, Dagar, whose uncle is former India and Delhi opener Virender Sehwag, asserted that he belongs here.

"My entire family is from Delhi. I've come to Delhi because I wanted a change in my career. My job is to work hard and try to win matches if I get to represent Delhi," Dagar said.

Chance to shine: Dagar is set for his maiden stint in the DPL. FILE PHOTO: K.V.S. GIRI

Samba magic in Kolkata as Brazil to face India in a friendly on Oct. 3

FOOTBALL

Anirudh Velamuri
HYDERABAD

The Brazil national football team will face India in a friendly at the Yuba Bharati Krirangan Stadium (Salt Lake Stadium) in Kolkata on October 3, the Brazilian football federation (CBF) announced on Thursday.

With Brazil currently ranked fifth in the world, this fixture will mark the highest-ranked opposition India has faced since the FIFA World Ranking was introduced in 1992.

Prior to coming to India, Carlo Ancelotti's side is scheduled to take on Australia at the Queensland Country Bank Stadium in Townsville on September 25 before facing the Socceroos again at the Suncorp Stadium in Brisbane four days later.

"After the friendlies in Australia, our next destination will be India, where we will write an unprecedented chapter in our history. The national team will take the field for the first time on Indian soil," the Brazilian Football Confederation (CBF) said in a statement.

"It will be a special encounter with a country that hosts the largest international fanbase of the Brazilian national team and that, for generations, has followed the history of Brazilian football with immense affection and passion."

New cycle

For the Selecao, these matches will kick-start preparations for the next cycle, starting with the 2028 Copa America and followed by the 2030 World Cup.

"Against India, there is the technical aspect and a great deal of gratitude to the Indians, who showed enormous affection and support for the Brazilian national team during the World Cup. So it is only fair that we go there as a way of thanking them, but also to put on a great performance," Rodrigo Caetano, the General Coordinator of CBF's men's national teams, said.

Huge challenge: Ancelotti's side will be the highest-ranked opposition India has faced. GETTY IMAGES

Purveyor of all-round excellence

The talismanic Joe Root has found a second wind in ODIs by leading the scoring charts since the start of 2025. As England tries to reset its one-day game in the lead-up to the 2027 World Cup, the 35-year-old's role as the nation's batting lynchpin has never been more pronounced

GETTY IMAGES

N. Sudarshan

For a singer, possessing a five-octave vocal range is proof of ultimate versatility. From the deepest bass notes to the whistle-register tones, it is a span that very few human voices are blessed with.

For a batter, an equivalent can be found in having skills to excel across formats. From the slam-bang universe of T20 cricket to the toned-down world of the 50-over game to the slow-burn realm of Tests, tackling all three successfully makes one float in rarefied air.

Across six days in mid-July, Joe Root showed why he may be one of those batters. Admittedly, the Englishman's exploits came in three ODIs against India, but his ability to play innings of such contrasts, and play them so well, proved that even in this era of ultra-specialisation, he was an all-pervading cricketer.

Masterclass

In the first fixture in Birmingham, he made an unbeaten run-a-ball 76 but found very little support as England lost by six wickets. In the second at Cardiff, though, his 99 not out (133b, 9x4) was a masterclass in how to grind opponents to dust as he carried the home side to a four-wicket victory in a 234-run chase.

In the decider at Lord's, he made a swashbuckling 74 from 48 balls, a knock embellished by audacious reverse-sweeps and reverse-scoops, as England racked up a mammoth 387-run total and eventually stopped India 27 runs short. A series-leading 249 runs, without even being dismissed once, earned the 35-year-old the much-deserved Player-of-the-Series award.

"I mean... some player he is, right?" gushed England coach Brendon McCullum. "He's played a number of match-winning games for us, and he just continues to not just lead with his batting, but also educate other guys.

"Today [July 19] was a nice blueprint for some of the other guys. Just in identifying the tempo that you can operate at in one-day cricket versus maybe Test or T20. We're very lucky to have him and he continues to get better and better," added the Kiwi.

In fairness, Root does not need this late-career validation to remind the world of his greatness.

In Tests, his tally of 14,114 runs is second only to Sachin Tendulkar's 15,921. He has played 166 matches, made 41 hundreds and averages an impressive 50.58. So much so that he is back as England's full-time captain – a role he performed from 2017 to 2022 – after the retirement of Ben Stokes.

He may have played just 192 ODIs, but he has accumulated 7826 runs at an average of 51.15, with 20 tons and 48 fifties. He is 35th in the run charts, but only three men above him average 50 or more – M.S. Dhoni, A.B. de Villiers and Virat Kohli. In England's maiden World Cup-winning campaign, he top-scored with 556 runs.

Hunger and desire

Yet, his recent purple patch is evidence of his hunger and desire to evolve. From 2020 to 2024, Root made just 666 ODI runs from 25 visits to the crease at an average of 28.95 and no hundreds.

But since the start of 2025, he is the highest scorer in the 50-over format with 1304 runs from 21 innings.

His average of 81.5 is the best for anyone who has played three innings or more, and he has struck at a healthy strike-rate of 93.74. He is joint-top with Kohli for centuries (four) and has made a remarkable nine fifties.

"I just didn't play a lot of it [one-dayers] and probably lost the rhythm of the game slightly," Root said in Cardiff about his lean phase.

"Sometimes you come back into things and you're not in as good a form as you'd like, and it doesn't work out how you want it to and it can snowball.

"More than anything, it was just about trying to get back to the rhythm of the game, understanding what my role looks like in this team and trying to deliver on that as often as possible."

It is safe to say that Root has understood his role all too well. World champion in 2019, England's 50-over game had slipped into a state of decay after the disastrous title-defence in 2023. Between trying – and mostly succeeding – to preserve the primacy of Tests and chasing the T20 moolah, ODIs had become a neglected middle child.

The defeat in the first one-day contest at Edgbaston to India was England's 20th in the previous 30 matches, and leading into the engagement against the Men in Blue, England had lost six out of eight bilateral ODI series.

But with back-to-back triumphs against Sri Lanka (January 2026) and India, England is in recovery mode ahead of the World Cup in South Africa, Zimbabwe and Namibia late next year. And Root has played a pivotal role in this turnaround, having scored 111 not out, 75 and 61 away in Lanka too, another series-high.

"Having worked with Baz [McCullum] has changed the way that I look at the game," Root had said in August 2025. "I've got less technical, I've become more about trying to manage the game better and finding ways of problem-solving.

"It's been very refreshing to have someone with a very different way of looking at things come and add a huge amount to my game. He's been brilliant."

Root's white-ball revival comes at a time when the 50-over game is at a crossroads. Recently, there were even whispers that it could be shortened to 40 overs a side in order to make it more appealing to present-day cricketers and the modern-day audience, both of whom seem to have short attention spans.

Hand-holding generals

Seen through a different prism, one-dayers are pregnant with possibilities and ripe for innovation, for they give a platform for players with diverse skillsets.

The fact that three of this era's best batters in Kohli, Rohit Sharma and Root continue to play the format is testimony to its standing. They can be the hand-holding generals and lead-inspirers.

"One of the biggest challenges for this team is that the young guys who are coming through, and anyone who comes into this team in a little while, do not have a wealth of experience and understanding of 50-over cricket," Root said about the next generation of English cricketers.

"We are not exposed to it anymore and there is not that element of grounding that happens before you get to this [international] level like it does elsewhere in the world. So there are going to be times when guys have to learn on the job and learn quickly.

"You've just got to find different ways of doing it. You find yourself on a really good pitch and you need to get 400 for a par score, you've got to have a range of game... right?

"Everyone who plays T20 cricket can manipulate the field and take the game on. [But] when you find yourself in a situation, and on a surface like that [Cardiff], can you find a way of doing it ugly and just getting yourself across the line?"

Shining virtues

Humility and selflessness were the other virtues of Root that shone through. He said he never missed an opportunity to learn from watching Kohli and Rohit bat and credited them for being "miles ahead" and for having "moved the bar and changed goalposts for everyone".

In Cardiff, he gave up the chance to score his 21st ODI hundred as Gus Atkinson collected almost all the runs when 19 were needed and Root was already on 98.

"I told him to just get it done," Root said. "It's all about winning and there's no better feeling than being there at the end when you chase something down."

At Lord's, with England scoring at a rollicking rate, Root had sounded out McCullum to retire him out if he was unable to march in step with his teammates.

"He did sort of mention at one stage that if we didn't think that he was going to be able to clear the ropes, then we could feel free to retire him out. And then he was 70 [74 n.o.] off 40 [48b]. So I'm not sure he was as confident in himself as we were. That, again, is a testament to his selflessness and ambition for the team".

THE GIST

- Starting 2025, Root has scored a world-leading 1304 ODI runs at an average of 81.5, strike-rate of 93.74, with four centuries and nine fifties
- Both against Sri Lanka in January and versus India recently, Root was England's highest scorer with 247 and 249 runs, respectively
- Against India, Root showcased his innate versatility by buckling down when required and turning expansive when the situation demanded
- Root has impressed by being humble enough to evolve as a batter and has received wholesome praise for his team-first attitude

Girl's death in China reveals human cost of unregulated science

The case has prompted debate about 'first in human' gene-editing trials, particularly for rare but serious disorders; investigation into the death has raised important questions about the oversight of such an experimental personalised trial and the way the researchers and their institutions communicated their choices

Vasudevan Mukunth

A six-year-old girl in China died in March 2025 after receiving what researchers said they believed was the world's first base-editing therapy directed at the brain, according to an investigation by *Science and Retraction Watch*.

The investigation has raised important questions about the oversight of an experimental personalised gene-editing trial and the way the researchers and their institutions communicated their choices.

The girl had Snijders Blok-Campeau syndrome, a rare neurodevelopmental disorder caused by a mutation in the CHD3 gene. Although the condition affects intellectual development and its severity varies widely, most people with the condition live full lives.

But that such a case could still clear the bar for an unprecedented, high-risk brain intervention says something about a society uneasy with disability and enamoured of techno-scientific interventions.

The girl's parents sought the experimental treatment after learning of research led by neuroscientist Zilong Qiu at the Shanghai Jiao Tong University.

Base-editing is a more recent invention than CRISPR-Cas9. The American biochemist David Liu developed it at the Broad Institute in 2016 after finding a way to convert one DNA letter directly into another – say, C to T – without cutting both strands of the DNA double helix, as Cas9-based editing does.

As a result, base-editing is, in principle, more 'gentle' and can cause fewer unintended mutations. Its development thus renewed hopes that gene-editing could graduate from being a proof of concept and to treating rare disorders caused by defects in single genes.

That said, the memory of He Jiankui, the Chinese scientist who announced in 2018 that he had edited the genomes of twin girls at the embryonic stage without adequate ethical review, scientific justification, and even disclosure to his own university, has weighed heavily on the field.

He was later sentenced to three years in prison for his actions, and the episode forced China to tighten its rules on human gene-editing research. But as the new investigation by *Science and Retraction Watch* has found, the rifts between what the law says and how it is enforced have remained wide enough for a similar failure to recur.

Dr. Qiu's team developed a personalised base-editing therapy designed to correct the genetic mutation in the child's brain cells.

However, delivering the 'editor' to the brain required the researchers to inject large doses of adeno-associated viruses (AAVs), which are known to carry risks of severe immune reactions.

According to the investigation report, the child's parents helped finance much of the therapy's development, contributing around $860,000 (₹8.3 crore) from their personal savings and money borrowed from relatives.

Big case: The investigation has raised important questions about the oversight of an experimental personalised gene-editing trial and the way the researchers and their institutions communicated their choices. REUTERS

The treatment proceeded as a clinical trial initiated by the investigator at the Xinhua Hospital in Shanghai. This process did not require the National Medical Products Administration, China's national drug regulator, to review it first.

However, the report has quoted independent experts expressing concerns with several aspects of the process – including whether preclinical studies (in animals) had adequately proved the treatment's safety for human use.

Toxicology studies in monkeys reportedly found that all the treated animals had developed liver injury and one monkey's kidneys were damaged as well.

However, the researchers proceeded to inject the therapy into the girl's cerebrospinal fluid on March 24, 2025. Within days, she developed a fever and kidney damage, and died a week later.

Hospital's internal review

An internal review at the hospital concluded that the treatment was certainly linked to her death, and listed the cause of death as thrombotic microangiopathy, a complication that has previously been associated with genetic therapies involving high doses of AAVs.

According to *Science and Retraction Watch*, neither the researchers nor the hospital disclosed the girl's death at the time. Several months later, local health authorities fined the hospital for shortcomings in trial oversight and registration, but did not sanction the lead researcher.

The family said they later asked that a research paper related to the trial be withdrawn, arguing that it did not reflect the appropriate outcomes.

The investigation also examined a paper published in *Nature* earlier this year describing the underlying preclinical work. Some independent experts questioned aspects of the reported data and argued that the journal should examine the underlying evidence and funding disclosures.

Nature said it had not been informed of the patient's death or the regulatory issues before publication and that such information would have been considered during editorial review.

The case has prompted renewed debate about 'first in human' gene-editing trials, particularly for rare but serious disorders.

In June 2024, *Nature* had reported a similar story in India: researchers across the country raced against time to develop a treatment for Uditi Saraf, a 20-year old with familial encephalopathy with neuroserpin inclusion bodies, or FENIB – a rare and aggressive brain disorder with symptoms similar to dementia.

Sadly, Uditi passed away before the treatment was ready, although the Sarafs, who helped fund the tests, and the researchers expressed hope afterwards that their efforts could help other people with FENIB.

The researchers' challenges included identifying the mutation, engineering the base-editor, manufacturing the AAV vectors, and improving institutional capacity to produce a gene therapy of direct clinical value.

Both instances – Uditi Saraf and the little girl in China – began with researchers committing themselves to a schedule they knew would be uncertain and high-pressure.

But in Uditi's case, while the researchers worked 12-hour days and called in favours from colleagues abroad, their efforts also had to contend against the friction of collaborating across borders and dealing with the U.S.'s more cautious regulatory system. In India as well, Arkasubhra Ghosh at Narayana Nethralaya Eye Hospital was waiting for approval from Indian regulators to manufacture AAVs when Uditi passed away. In China, on the other hand, the researchers faced little resistance going from decision to injection.

Of course, this doesn't mean India treats disability better than China. Stigma against disabled people here is widespread, sustained by misunderstanding, misinformation, and prejudice.

Affordable gene-editing

The Sarafs' experience also opened a window to India's opportunity to become a centre for affordable gene-editing as it wound through Ghosh's ambition to manufacture AAVs within the country and Debojyoti Chakraborty's efforts at the CSIR-Institute of Genomics and Integrative Biology to develop inexpensive CRISPR therapies.

That said, while India offered the possibility of acting before it was too late, the researchers might have faced similar questions over the preclinical evidence and toxicology reports and regulatory penalties against hospitals if the treatment had gone awry.

Finally, none of the regulatory philosophies at work in these episodes guarantees success. One emphasised exhaustive reviews before 'first in human' use. Another allowed investigator-initiated trials to proceed more rapidly. A third was willing to devolve trust based on reputation and clinical stature over external reviews, including of safety.

In fact, while the law in China forbids charging patients for unproven therapy, it is also written narrowly enough for informal payments to individual researchers – such as the gifts to Dr. Qiu – to fall outside its purview.

Communicating risk and the possibility of death also have thorny social dimensions, including the optimism surrounding frontier biotechnologies and the emotional entanglement that can develop between families and researchers.

(mukunth.v@thehindu.co.in)

THE GIST

- A six-year-old girl in China died in March 2025 after receiving what researchers said they believed was the world's first base-editing therapy directed at the brain, according to an investigation by *Science and Retraction Watch*. The girl had Snijders Blok-Campeau syndrome, a rare neurodevelopmental disorder caused by a mutation in the CHD3 gene
- The treatment proceeded as a clinical trial initiated by the investigator at the Xinhua Hospital in Shanghai. This process did not require the National Medical Products Administration, China's national drug regulator, to review it first. However, the report has quoted independent experts expressing concerns with several aspects of the process — including whether preclinical studies (in animals) had adequately proved the treatment's safety for human use
- An internal review at the hospital concluded that the treatment was certainly linked to her death, and listed the cause of death as thrombotic microangiopathy, a complication that has previously been associated with genetic therapies involving high doses of AAVs

What Alanine aminotransferase level can reveal about liver health

Athira Elssa Johnson

According to the World Health Organization (WHO), liver diseases account for around two million deaths globally every year. Viral hepatitis alone caused an estimated 1.3 million deaths in 2022, with about 254 million people living with chronic hepatitis B infection and around 50 million with chronic hepatitis C infection. There is also a rising burden of metabolic dysfunction-associated steatotic liver disease (MASLD), previously known as non-alcoholic fatty liver disease, driven by increasing obesity and diabetes.

An early marker

Alanine aminotransferase (ALT), also known as serum glutamic-pyruvic transaminase (SGPT), is an enzyme found predominantly inside liver cells. When these cells are damaged or inflamed, ALT leaks into the bloodstream, making it one of the earliest laboratory markers of liver injury.

Arul Prakash, gastroenterologist and hepatologist, SRM Prime Hospitals, Chennai, says ALT is also present in smaller amounts in muscles and the heart. Therefore, an elevated ALT level does not necessarily indicate liver disease and should prompt further evaluation to identify the source of the abnormality.

Check up: The Union Health Ministry has urged people to monitor alanine aminotransferase (ALT) levels as an early indicator of liver injury. GETTY IMAGES

ALT is one component of the liver function test, which includes other liver enzymes and measures of liver function. Although ALT is a sensitive indicator of ongoing liver injury, patients can still have significant liver disease despite normal ALT values.

ALT testing is performed on a blood sample, with results typically available within a few hours. Although many laboratories consider ALT levels below 40 units per litre as normal, interpretation depends on the patient's condition. For example, lower thresholds are often applied in people with chronic hepatitis B or C.

People living with MASLD may have normal or only mildly elevated ALT despite having liver disease. In advanced cirrhosis, ALT levels may return to normal because there are too few functioning liver cells left to release the enzyme. As a result, normal ALT values do not exclude significant or advanced liver disease.

Who should be tested?

ALT testing is already part of most comprehensive health check-ups, says Dinesh Jothimani, director of hepatology, Rela Hospital, Chennai. For adults without recognised risk factors, testing once a year is generally adequate. Those at higher risk may benefit from more frequent monitoring, depending on clinical advice.

People living with obesity, diabetes, thyroid disorders, high cholesterol, viral hepatitis, long-term medication use, alcohol consumption, a family history of liver disease or sedentary lifestyles are at greater risk of liver injury and should undergo regular evaluation, he says.

Dr. Jothimani notes that liver enzyme elevation may occur in acute viral hepatitis, alcohol-related liver disease, MASLD, autoimmune hepatitis and chronic liver diseases. However, many patients remain asymptomatic because the liver has a remarkable ability to regenerate and continue functioning despite ongoing damage. Symptoms often appear only in advanced stages of disease, making routine screening particularly valuable.

Elevated ALT

An elevated ALT level is not a diagnosis but an indication for further assessment, experts emphasise.

Dr. Prakash says doctors usually perform a complete liver function test, additional blood investigations and, where appropriate, cardiac evaluation to determine the cause. If liver disease is confirmed, treatment depends on the underlying condition. Lifestyle modifications, including reducing alcohol intake, , maintaining a healthy weight, limiting excess saturated fat, refined carbohydrates and sugary foods, and increasing physical activity, remain central to managing metabolic liver disease. Viral hepatitis and autoimmune hepatitis require specific medical treatment.

Experts recommend that people with persistently abnormal ALT levels or suspected liver disease undergo further evaluation under the guidance of a medical professional.

(athira.elssa@thehindu.co.in)